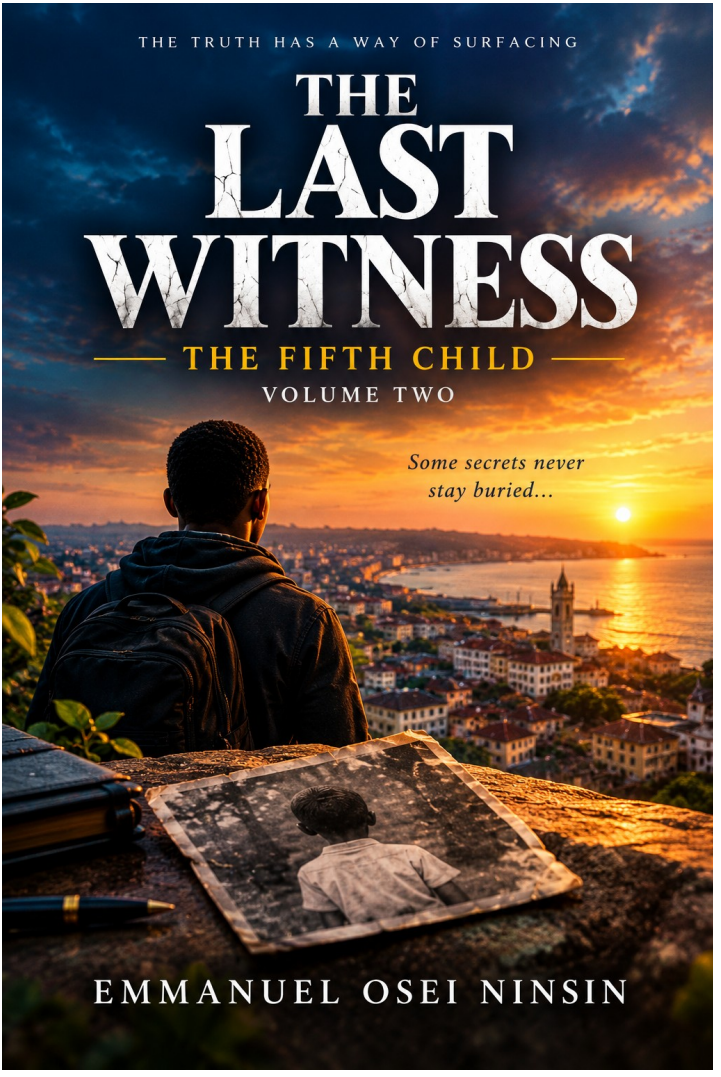

THE TRUTH HAS A WAY OF SURFACING
THE LAST WITNESS
THE FIFTH CHILD
VOLUME TWO
Some secrets never stay buried...
EMMANUEL OSEI NINSIN

THE LAST WITNESS

VOLUME TWO

THE FIFTH CHILD

A mystery suspense novel

Emmanuel Osei Kojo Ninsin

DEDICATION

This book is dedicated to all young people who dare to dream, work hard, and believe in a better tomorrow.

To my mother, Agnes Osei Addai, for her endless love, prayers, and sacrifices. You have been my greatest inspiration and my first teacher.

To every student, parent, teacher, and guardian who supports, encourages, and believes in the power of education, this book is also for you.

May your dreams never be limited by your circumstances.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

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To everyone who, in one way or another, has stood by me, encouraged me, and contributed to the journey, I offer my heartfelt thanks.

May God bless you all.

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PART ONE
THE FORGOTTEN CHILD

CHAPTER ONE

The Box Without a Number

The box was not supposed to exist.

It stood on a steel trolley in the regional registry's records room, wedged between two cartons marked for disposal and a cabinet whose lock had been awaiting replacement for three months. Damp had softened its corners. Cotton tape crossed the lid, and the front bore no accession number—only a pale strip where a label had been.

Ama Serwaa first took it for another bundle of building-maintenance files. Such boxes often surfaced in the wrong place. Her task was to catalogue every parcel before month's end, and the backlog was already long.

Then she noticed the handwriting on the strip.

HAVEN HOUSE — REVIEW MATERIAL.

She read the label twice. The public inquiry had dominated the news for weeks: a retired judge was dead, a senior official had been arrested, and the courts were preparing to test what could actually be proved. The registry had answered three requests connected to the case with the same careful phrase: no additional file had been located.

Ama glanced at the open doorway. The corridor was empty. With no number, transfer note, or intact

seal, the box needed documenting before it could be moved. Yet leaving it there would make it accessible to anyone who entered.

She reached for her phone, then stopped. A personal photograph was no substitute for an official record. She fetched the department camera and incident register.

At 10:17 a.m., she logged an unnumbered parcel found during routine inventory. She described the tape, damaged label, and missing transfer receipt, then asked a colleague to witness the entry. Only after both had signed did she cut the tape.

Inside lay six folders, loose sheets, and a blank envelope. The first folder held routine correspondence about the relocation of Haven House’s administrative office; the second, invoices. The third was empty apart from two rusted staples and the faint rectangle left by a removed document.

The fourth folder made her stop.

Its cover read: ROOM FOUR — CHILDREN’S REGISTER — REVIEW COPY.

Ama left the folder closed and called her supervisor, Mr. Dapaah. He arrived eleven minutes later with his own register and the wary look he wore whenever a small administrative problem threatened to become a public one.

“You have not removed anything?” he asked.

“I have opened the parcel in the presence of a witness. Everything is still in the order in which we found it.”

“And you have not copied anything?”

“No, sir.”

He checked the incident entry, signed beneath Ama’s name, and had the witness do the same. Then he put on gloves and lifted the folder. The paper had yellowed at the edges, but the ink remained legible: a register assigning children to rooms and beds. Several entries were crossed out. Beside one line, the paper had been scraped almost through.

Five lines remained visible. Four carried names; the fifth held only a dash and a date. In the margin, someone had written in pencil: ASK THE FIFTH CHILD.

Mr. Dapaah lowered the page as if it had become heavier.

“This should have been transferred to the inquiry team,” he said.

“Was it?” Ama asked.

He turned to a card stapled inside the cover. It traced the parcel through Haven House, a district office, a temporary archive, and finally the regional registry. The last two dates were written in different inks; one entry lacked initials.

Mr. Dapaah copied the reference number into his notebook. “We will seal this again and notify the records director.”

“Should I call the police?” Ama asked.

“Not yet. We will follow procedure.”

He spoke as if procedure could serve as a wall. But when he closed the folder, Ama saw his hand tremble.

By noon, the parcel was secured in a locked cabinet. Its condition was recorded, and two officers signed for custody. The records director was notified and a formal notice drafted. Every step had a paper trail; nothing had been copied outside the approved process.

Yet before the office closed, a call came from an unknown number on the registry’s public line. The caller asked whether an unnumbered Haven House box had been found. The receptionist asked for a name and a reference number. The caller hung up.

The receptionist recorded the call in the message book. She could not have known that another office, twenty kilometres away, had received the same question that morning.

At 4:36 p.m., Mr. Dapaah called Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu. He gave the discovery time, the parcel description, and the names of the two officers who had witnessed the opening. He did not speculate about who had hidden it or why. Badu asked

him to preserve the original packaging and not to move the folders again until an evidence officer could attend.

“Is there anything unusual in the contents?” Badu asked.

Mr. Dapaah glanced through the glass wall at the locked cabinet. “A children’s register. One entry appears to have been erased. There is a note in the margin.”

“What note?”

Mr. Dapaah hesitated. “Ask the fifth child.”

For a moment, neither man spoke. Badu had seen the phrase on another copy, whose origin remained unverified. He would treat it as a lead, not a conclusion: a missing name raised a question; it did not answer one.

“Do not discuss the contents with anyone outside the chain of custody,” he said. “I will send a team first thing tomorrow.”

After the call, Badu opened the case file and wrote a new entry beneath the unresolved questions from Volume One. He recorded the discovery as reported, not as verified fact, and attached the registry’s reference number. He then called Mabel Owusu.

“They have found another Haven House record,” he told her.

“Does it name the child?”

“Not yet.”

“Does it prove the fifth child existed?”

“It gives us a reason to investigate. We still need to authenticate it.”

Mabel was quiet. “Then don’t let anyone turn the note into a headline before we know what it means.”

“That is the plan.”

“And Kwame?”

“Yes?”

“If the box was hidden, someone knew it was there. If someone knew it was there, they may already know you have found it.”

Badu studied the entry he had just made. The earlier investigation had shown how easily a record could be altered—and how difficult it was to prove who had altered it. This time, every transfer would be logged and every claim tested. No one would be allowed to fill a gap with certainty simply because uncertainty was hard to bear.

“Then we begin with the box,” he said.

Across the city, a person who had not been named in any public report received a message containing only six words: THEY HAVE FOUND THE FIFTH REGISTER.

The reply came almost immediately.

A second inventory

Kwame Badu returned to the evidence room after most of the staff had left. A file became dangerous when people treated it as a story before establishing what it was. Under the fluorescent lights, the unnumbered box looked ordinary. Dust around the lid suggested the missing label had once been there.

He put on fresh gloves and photographed the box from every side. He recorded the seal, the condition of the cardboard, the marks left by old adhesive, and the faint impression where a label might once have been fixed. None of those details identified a culprit. Together, however, they established a condition that could later be compared with the records of anyone who had handled it.

A young evidence clerk asked whether the missing number proved deliberate tampering. Badu shook his head. A label might fall off, be covered during repacking, or be removed on purpose. The photographs would preserve the condition; the report would record the possibilities without choosing one. The clerk looked disappointed. People wanted investigations to move in straight lines. Evidence rarely did.

Inside the box, the papers had been arranged in bundles, each separated by a strip of discoloured paper. The first bundle contained routine correspondence. The second held copies of appointment notices. The third had a cover sheet with a blank where a reference should have appeared. Badu did not remove the last bundle immediately. He checked the seal and the handling log, then asked another officer to witness the opening.

The final packet held no confession, complete list, or page that explained the case. It contained a faint cross-reference in another ink; the last character might have been a B. Badu recorded that as a possible reading, not a fact. If the mark became important later, the distinction would matter.

When he left the room, he carried no original document away. The evidence remained sealed and logged. What he carried was a question: why had someone preserved the papers carefully enough to keep them together, yet allowed the box’s identifying number to disappear? It could have been negligence. It could have been a deliberate attempt to break the chain of custody. He would need the records around the box before he could decide which explanation deserved more weight.

The conservator’s preliminary report arrived two days later. The strip attached to the register page appeared to be of a similar general age to the

surrounding paper, but the conservator could not date the adhesive precisely or determine why the strip had been applied. Its edges showed signs of earlier handling. The report recommended non-invasive imaging before any attempt to lift it, and warned that even careful separation might damage the underlying entry.

Badu read the report with Daniel and Mabel present. The strip was no longer merely an obstacle to be removed; it was itself evidence, carrying a history that had to be understood. If they tore it away to reveal the hidden name, they might destroy clues about when it was attached and whether it had been moved. The team approved the imaging plan and agreed that any physical intervention would require written authorisation and a complete record of the process.

While they waited, the archive supplied the wider index search. It showed that supplementary schedules had been filed separately in several cases, sometimes under a subject heading and sometimes under the name of the office that requested the review. One entry matched the date range of the Haven House papers, but its reference number had been transcribed incorrectly in a later index. The original card appeared to contain 17-B; the later card read 17-8. The characters were similar enough to explain why a search using only one form had failed.

The new entry was not the missing schedule itself. It was a route to a second register, held in another part of the depot. Badu requested an authorised inspection and asked that the archive preserve both catalogue cards, including the mistaken transcription. The error had delayed the search, but it also showed why the team needed to document how each clue had been followed. Without that record, a future reviewer might assume they had simply overlooked an obvious reference.

Mabel compared the index cards with the anonymous messages. The sender had known the phrase “ask who held the pen,” but there was no proof that the sender had seen the catalogue card or the register. The message might have come from someone with inside knowledge; it might also have been written by someone who had heard a rumour. The digital investigator had established that the message came through a service that concealed the sender’s ordinary number. That limited the technical lead, but it did not identify a person.

“Could the sender be trying to help us?” Daniel asked.

“Possibly,” Badu said. “Could the sender be trying to steer us toward a particular suspect? Also possible. We judge the information by whether it can be verified, not by whether the person sending it claims to be on our side.”

The authorised inspection of the second register took place in the presence of two archive officers. Its entry confirmed that a supplementary schedule had once been received, but the location field referred to a transfer made during an office reorganisation. A later stamp indicated that the schedule had been sent onward. The receiving office was named, but the receipt number was incomplete. The trail had become more precise without becoming complete.

Badu instructed the team to obtain the transfer list from the receiving office and to ask whether the schedule had been scanned before the reorganisation. He also asked for a search of disposal records, not because he believed the schedule had been destroyed, but because the search needed to cover that possibility honestly. A missing document could have been misfiled, transferred, damaged, or disposed of under a procedure that someone had wrongly applied. Each possibility demanded a different line of inquiry.

That evening, Daniel sat alone with the certified image of the register. He no longer expected a single line to explain his life. The records showed that the names Emmanuel Sarpong, Emmanuel Badu, and Daniel Sarpong had been associated with a related sequence of references. They did not yet explain who authorised each change, whether the same person had made them, or whether every change had been made for the same reason. His identity was not a puzzle for other people to solve without him; it was his history,

and he wanted the evidence handled in a way that could survive challenge.

He wrote a statement for the inquiry. He described the documents he had seen, the names used in his records, and the questions that remained unanswered. He did not accuse Kwame Badu's father, Yaw Ofori, or Inspector Mensah. He asked the inquiry to establish the sequence of custody and to identify who had authority to approve the amendments. His statement was less dramatic than a confession would have been, but it was his own account, and he signed it only after reading every line.

Mabel added Daniel's statement to the evidence schedule. It was not proof of the original identity by itself, but it recorded the person most directly affected by the documents and clarified which claims he was making. Badu arranged for the statement to be reviewed by the inquiry's lawyer and for any further interview to be conducted with appropriate safeguards. The case had to make room for Daniel's voice without asking him to carry the burden of proving every administrative act that had shaped his life.

The anonymous sender remained silent. Badu reminded the team that silence could mean fear, satisfaction, indifference, or nothing at all. They would continue the lawful digital enquiries, but the next steps would not depend on another message. The

transfer list, the second register, the original movement slip, and the missing schedule offered independent routes forward.

When Mabel closed her notebook, she understood the title of the case differently. The second truth was not a secret answer replacing the first. It was the discovery that a truth could be real and still be incomplete, that a record could preserve a fact while concealing the path by which it had been created, and that justice required patience with the parts no one yet understood.

The team left the archive with a list of tasks, not a victory speech. The next search might produce the schedule, or it might establish that the schedule had been lost beyond recovery. Either result would matter if it was properly documented. For the first time, the investigation had a chain of verifiable steps stretching beyond the anonymous sender and beyond the recollections of witnesses. The fifth child’s identity remained a question to be answered by evidence, not by the urgency of their hopes.

Before leaving, Ama checked the room-access sheet with senior archivist Mr Agyapong. The log listed a cleaner, two clerks, and a courier collecting a different parcel; it did not explain the box’s arrival. They photographed the trolley and surrounding shelves, then added a note that the origin and missing accession number remained unverified. No item

would be moved or removed without a logged reason and a second signature.

Agyapong cautioned her not to assign the box a permanent number based on its contents. They would retain the temporary intake reference until an independent transfer record established its origin.

The access sheet narrowed the inquiry but did not prove that no unrecorded entry had occurred. Ama filed the photographs with the intake record and asked the supervisor to countersign the amendment.

The next morning, a colleague who had not seen the box reviewed the photographs. He independently noticed the old adhesive mark and the faint impression of a former label. Ama added his observation to the record without treating it as proof of deliberate removal.

The box remained sealed in restricted storage. Its temporary number would stay in place until the archive could verify where it had come from.

Mabel Owusu did not like the sound of a name spoken as if it were a door being opened.

She had spent years learning to distrust the small confidence with which people announced that they knew who someone was. A name in a file could be a fact, a mistake, a convenience, or a lie that had survived long enough to acquire a stamp. The new box from the regional registry had reminded her of that lesson before she had even seen it.

At half past eight, she stood in the records room with a photocopy of the inventory laid flat beneath a desk lamp. Five lines had been typed beneath the heading CHILDREN PRESENT DURING REVIEW. Four names remained legible. The fifth line had been scraped, then overwritten in a hand that looked too careful to be casual.

She had not touched the original. Ama Serwaa had witnessed the opening, Mr Dapaah had signed the access sheet, and Badu had photographed the register before it was moved. Those precautions did not prove the document genuine; they made its handling traceable.

Beside the fifth line, someone had made a faint pencil mark: a small hook followed by a short vertical stroke. It might have been an initial, a check mark, or

nothing at all. Mabel wrote in her notebook: “Pencil mark beside fifth line. Meaning unknown.” Then she underlined unknown.

Ama appeared at the door holding a paper cup. “Have you found the name?”

“No.”

“But you recognise something?”

“I recognise the way people want the paper to answer before we have asked it properly.”

Ama glanced at the copy. “The mark?”

“The mark, the scraped line, the instruction. We need to know whether the pencil mark is original, whether it was made during the review, and whether the copy reproduces it accurately.”

“You sound like the detective.”

“I have learned from watching detectives get things wrong.”

Ama gave a short laugh, then stopped. “Someone called the registry this morning. A man. He said he was from the inquiry office and wanted to know who had opened the box.”

“Did he give his name?”

“He said it was on the file.”

“Was it?”

“No.”

The call had come at 8:04 a.m. The caller asked whether the box had been opened, who witnessed it, and whether any pages were missing. He never asked what the pages contained. That was the detail Mabel kept returning to: he seemed to know what mattered before anyone told him.

“Send Badu the call note,” Mabel said. “Keep the original. Don’t add your interpretation.”

“You think this is dangerous?”

“I think it is important. Those are not the same thing. We should not make it more frightening than the evidence allows, and we should not make it less serious either.”

Mabel photographed the copy beside a ruler, then recorded the file reference and the time. She did not post anything. She had learned that a public question could become a private warning to whoever was trying to conceal the answer.

Her phone vibrated. Badu asked whether she had seen the pencil mark. She replied that she had, but could not identify it. He told her not to compare it with any known signature until they had a proper scan. She sent him the note about the call.

When he rang, he asked who else had seen the copy. “You, Ama, Dapaah, and me. I don’t know who may have seen the original during the inventory process before we arrived.”

“Good. Keep the list narrow. I’m asking the registry to preserve the call log and any available switchboard record.”

“Do you think the caller was connected to the old inquiry?”

“I think the caller knew the box mattered. That is all I can responsibly say.”

Mabel looked again at the five lines. “The fifth line sits lower than the others. If a name was removed and another entered, the person may have worked around the old line rather than retype the whole page.”

“Or the original page was misaligned when copied,” Badu said. “We need the scan.”

“I know.”

“I’m not dismissing it.”

“I didn’t say you were.”

Their working relationship had survived public accusations, private mistakes, and a case that had grown beyond the murder that began it. Both knew how quickly suspicion could enter a partnership. Each new clue seemed to demand a culprit before it had earned one.

Badu asked her to describe what she remembered about Room Four—not what she thought the new document meant, but what she remembered. Mabel’s hand tightened around the phone.

“I remember a pencil tapping against a table. I remember an adult saying that the fifth line should not be copied. Another voice asked why, and the answer was that the list had already been approved.”

“Did you see who was holding the pencil?”

“No. I was near the doorway. I saw a sleeve, a hand, and a ring. I couldn’t identify the person then, and I can’t now.”

“Describe the ring.”

“Plain, dark, perhaps a signet. I was a child. The room was dim. I will not pretend I saw more than I did.”

“That’s important,” Badu said. “You know the limit of your memory.”

“People rarely thank a witness for being careful.”

“I do.”

After the call, Mabel divided a notebook page into three columns: what she saw, what she heard, and what she inferred. The ring belonged in the first, qualified by uncertainty; the words about the fifth line belonged in the second, with a note that they might not be exact. Her belief that the adults were altering a record went in the third. Keeping the columns separate stopped an inference from hardening into a memory.

At noon, she met Badu in a quiet interview room. A high-resolution image of the inventory filled his tablet. The pencil mark was clearer but remained ambiguous. The fifth line showed a shallow depression, as if a word had once been written there and erased.

“Can the lab recover it?” Mabel asked.

“Possibly. They may use different light sources to detect impressions or residues. They may also find nothing. We need the original handled under proper conditions.”

“And if they recover a name?”

“Then we ask whether it belongs to the original entry, a later alteration, or an unrelated note. Recovering a mark does not authenticate it.”

“You are determined to ruin every dramatic moment.”

“I’m a detective. Drama is usually what people add when they don’t have enough facts.”

They reviewed the four visible names. Two were independently confirmed. A third appeared in a school register, though the dates did not align neatly. The fourth might be a nickname. Each needed separate checking; genuine names could still appear in an unreliable list.

Daniel Sarpong’s name was not there. Mabel noticed Badu pause at that absence.

“Do not turn that into an answer,” she said.

“I haven’t.”

“You were thinking it.”

“I was thinking that if Daniel was not named on this copy, it does not tell us whether he was among the five children. He may have been recorded under another name. He may have been present at another time. Or the list may not be complete.”

“And it tells us nothing by itself about what your father knew,” Mabel added.

The mention of Emmanuel Badu changed the room’s atmosphere. His name appeared in a separate appointment ledger connected to the old review, but its meaning remained uncertain. Kwame had spent months resisting the urge to turn a family connection into either accusation or defence. A gap in a record could invite a convincing story without making that story true.

“Your father’s name is another question,” Mabel said. “It must stay another question until evidence joins it to this one.”

“I know.”

“You say that as if knowing makes it easy.”

“It doesn’t.”

They agreed to wait for the document examination and preserve the call log. Mabel would not publish the

mark, though she made clear that careful reporting was not the same as permanent silence.

As she left, her phone vibrated again. An unknown number had sent a grainy photograph of a ruled page. Five short horizontal strokes had been drawn in pencil. Four were crossed through. The fifth remained untouched. Beneath them was a message: You remember more than you admit.

Mabel stopped in the corridor. She did not reply. She took a screenshot, noted the time, and sent it to Badu. His call came within a minute.

“Where are you?”

“Outside the interview room.”

“Stay there. I’m coming.”

“It may be a bluff.”

“It may be. Don’t delete anything.”

The image named no one and proved nothing about who had been in Room Four. It might have been copied from a document, invented from a news report, or made by someone who knew just enough to frighten her. But the sender knew she was connected to the discovery. The archive no longer felt like a place where the past simply waited to be found; someone was watching what they did with it.

Mabel did not leave the archive immediately. She took the photocopy to a table beside the public reading

room and compared it with the image she had made earlier. The pencil mark on the fifth line was faint enough to disappear when the page tilted away from the light. It was not a name. It was not even a complete letter. It might have been the beginning of a number, the tail of a signature, or a mark left by a hand that had rested too long in one place.

She asked the attendant whether the copy had been produced from an original or from an earlier photocopy. The attendant checked the request slip. “It says duplicate from microfilm.”

“Does it say when the microfilm was made?”

“No date on this slip.”

“Can that be checked?”

“Through the supervisor. Not here.”

Mabel thanked the attendant and recorded the answer without interpretation. A faint mark on a second-generation copy might be an original pencil stroke—or dirt, damage, or a copying flaw. A detail became dangerous when a reporter mistook its vividness for certainty.

Outside, the afternoon heat pressed against the pavement. Mabel called Badu and described the mark, the microfilm notation, and the missing date. He asked her to send the request slip as well as the image. She could hear paper moving at his end of the line.

“We need the production history,” he said. “Who filmed it, when, and from which source. And we need to know whether the original still exists.”

“You sound as if you expect it not to.”

“I expect nothing until someone checks.”

That answer irritated her because it was careful, and comforted her for the same reason. “The fifth line may be nothing.”

“Then we record that possibility too.”

Before she put the phone away, she looked again at the anonymous message. Five strokes. Four crossed out. No explanation. The sender might have seen the same register, might have copied an old symbol, or might simply know how to make a journalist imagine a pattern. Mabel saved the image in a separate folder and labelled it UNVERIFIED COMMUNICATION. She refused to let it sit beside the official copy as if the two carried equal weight.

At the gate, she noticed a man standing beside a parked taxi. He was watching people leave, not the building itself. When their eyes met, he looked down at his phone. Mabel did not approach him and did not decide that he had been waiting for her. She noted the taxi’s colour and registration as best she could, then walked toward the main road where there were other people and open shops. By the time she looked back, the taxi had pulled away. It could have been

coincidence. She would not turn coincidence into a witness.

The school register

Mabel asked for the school register before she asked anyone to explain the pencilled name. She wanted to see the page in context: the entries before it, the entries after it, and the ordinary corrections made by the same hand. A name written in pencil could mean a temporary entry, a later amendment, or nothing more sinister than a clerk who had run out of ink. Context was the difference between noticing a mark and understanding it.

The head administrator met them in a narrow office where old files were stacked in cabinets that did not match. He explained that the school had changed its filing system twice and that some registers had been moved during renovations. He would not let them take the original away, but he agreed to arrange a supervised inspection and provide a certified copy if the request was approved. Mabel accepted the delay. A properly obtained page would be harder to dismiss than a hurried photograph.

The entry showed a name written over a pale erasure. The paper fibres were rough where the surface had been rubbed. The name could be read as Emmanuel, but the surname was less clear. A later entry in the same column used a different spelling.

Mabel resisted the urge to connect the two immediately. She noted the page number, the date of the register, and the names of the staff who had custody of it.

Outside, she told Badu that the pencil mark felt familiar. She remembered adults speaking in lowered voices, and a sheet being turned over when she entered a room. But she could not remember seeing this exact page. Badu asked her to write down the memory before discussing it further. That way, what she remembered now would not quietly absorb the new information from the register.

At home that evening, Mabel separated her notes into two columns: what she had seen as a child and what she had learned as an adult. The columns did not always agree, and that troubled her. Then she realised the disagreement was useful. It showed where the investigation needed corroboration instead of asking memory to carry the entire burden. She left the uncertain surname uncircled and closed the notebook.

When they finished, she felt a small loosening in her chest. For years she had believed that to be taken seriously she had to remember everything. Now she could see that the truth might depend on showing exactly where her memory ended.

Together they built a timeline with three columns. In the first, Mabel placed details she believed she remembered from childhood. In the second, she

recorded words she remembered hearing but could not attribute with confidence. In the third, she listed facts learned from documents or interviews years later. The third column was longer than she expected. That did not make her original memory worthless. It made the boundaries visible.

“Some will. Others understand that a person who admits the limits of memory is less likely to pretend certainty where there is none.” He opened his notebook. “Let us separate what you saw, what you heard, and what you learned later.”

“People hear uncertainty and think you are hiding something.”

Badu listened without interrupting. “You are allowed to say you do not know. A careful witness is not a weak witness.”

When she had first told the story, she had used the word “man” as if it described a single person beyond doubt. Over time, the image had become fused with photographs and names other people had mentioned. Memory could preserve a scene while borrowing details from later years.

Outside the records room, she sat beneath a window facing the courtyard and tried to summon the day she had first seen a file removed from Room Four. Her memory came in fragments: the edge of a brown folder, a voice raised and then lowered, the scrape of a chair, a child waiting in the passage. She remembered

the feeling of being noticed by an adult who did not want her there. She could not reliably remember the colour of his tie.

Mabel copied the visible letters exactly, including the uncertain stroke at the end. She used brackets where she could not read the mark. It looked less satisfying than writing a name in full, but it was honest. In her notebook she made a separate heading for interpretation and left it blank.

“Possibly. The register was used by more than one office over several years. That is why we document its condition and chain of custody. If someone tells you the line was added on a particular day, ask what evidence supports the date.”

“Could a later user have added it?”

“This was written in pencil,” the officer said. “That is all I can certify from visual inspection. I cannot tell you when it was written, whether anything was underneath it, or who wrote it.”

Mabel kept her hands in her lap. She had spent years imagining the missing name as a person waiting behind a locked door. Now the page looked ordinary: ruled columns, faded ink, a crease from long storage, and a tiny brown stain near the binding.

The records officer placed the register on a foam support. “You may examine the page here. If you need

a copy, we will make one under supervision. Please do not mark the original.”

The Question of Pressure

Mabel returned to the register with a fresh sheet of paper and a rule written across the top: record what is visible before deciding what it means. The line in pencil sat between two names written in darker ink. Its letters were lighter, but that difference could have come from the pencil, the paper, or the pressure of the hand. She had no basis for calling it an erasure yet.

Before Mabel left the registry, she asked for a copy of the request number and wrote it on the inside cover of her notebook. She had learned to keep ordinary details because later, when a conversation became disputed, those details could anchor it. The time on the wall clock, the name of the clerk, the colour of the envelope, the exact words used to refuse a request: none solved a case alone, but together they could expose a contradiction.

At the bus stop, she reviewed the photograph of the pencilled line. The mark was faint and the paper had been copied too many times for its pressure to be judged. It might have been a name partly erased, a correction made by a clerk, or a line transferred from another page. She enlarged the image once, then stopped. Magnification could make a blurred stroke look more definite without making it more reliable.

She called Badu and told him she wanted the original examined if it could be found. He agreed, but reminded her that the original might not survive. If it did not, they would have to describe the limits of the copy instead of pretending the missing detail could be recovered by staring at it long enough.

Mabel made two columns in her notebook. The first was headed WHAT THE PAGE SHOWS; the second, WHAT I AM TEMPTED TO BELIEVE. In the first she wrote four legible names, one obscured line, and a pencilled mark in the margin. In the second she wrote nothing for several minutes. The empty column irritated her. She was accustomed to finding a lead quickly, but this time she understood that speed could turn an uncertain mark into a person’s entire identity.

At the newspaper office, her editor, Adwoa, listened while Mabel explained the box and the partial inventory. Adwoa did not ask whether the missing child was Daniel. She asked whether Mabel had permission to publish the names that remained. The question pulled Mabel back from the edge of a story she had already begun composing in her head. These were children’s records, even if the children were now adults. Their privacy did not disappear because officials had failed to protect it years earlier.

Mabel drafted a short request to the registry, asking how the inventory had been preserved, when the box was discovered, and whether any transfer

record identified its source. She did not mention the anonymous message. She wanted to see whether the institution's ordinary records would independently lead to the same questions. When she reread the request, she removed the phrase "the erased child." It was vivid, but it presumed that a child had been deliberately erased. For now, all she could say was that one line was unreadable in the copy she had received.

That evening she placed the page in a clear sleeve and wrote the date and source on a separate note. She did not mark the original photocopy. The difference between preserving a clue and improving it, she realised, could be a single pencil stroke. Before closing her notebook, she wrote one sentence beneath the two columns: A name may be missing for many reasons; the reason must be proved, not supplied by fear.

The discipline irritated her because she had spent years living with a memory that others had dismissed as incomplete. Yet she understood the distinction. Her memory was evidence of what she remembered; it was not a substitute for a record she had never seen. If she wanted her own account treated fairly, she had to give the documents the same fairness.

That evening, she made two lists. The first contained things she could place with confidence: the corridor, the folder, the argument, the fear she had felt when an adult noticed her watching. The second

contained things she had supplied later from other people's accounts: the room number, the names attached to the inquiry, and the suggestion that the folder had contained a list of children. She marked every item in the second list with a question mark.

When the anonymous message arrived, it contained only five short strokes, four crossed through. No greeting, no explanation. Mabel saved the message and recorded the time. She did not answer. The sender wanted a reaction, and a reaction might be the only thing the sender was measuring.

Mabel sent her editor a revised pitch that avoided calling the missing line a deliberate erasure. Adwoa approved the change and asked her to build the story around the record trail rather than a dramatic accusation. Mabel interviewed a former social worker who explained that institutions sometimes kept separate lists for residents, visitors, and children considered for temporary placement. The explanation did not solve the discrepancy, but it warned against treating every list as if it counted the same people in the same way. Mabel checked the social worker’s employment dates and noted that she had not worked at Haven House during the disputed period. Her account was useful background, not direct evidence. Mabel updated the notebook and kept the two columns separate.

Mabel placed the interview notes beside the inventory, not over it. The inventory was a surviving record; the interview was a later account of what it might mean. Neither could quietly replace the other.

She marked the conclusion provisional and kept the original inventory unchanged in the evidence file.

She placed the phone face down and returned to her notes. For the first time, the pencilled line seemed less like a hidden answer and more like a test: would she force a name into the gap because she desperately wanted one? She wrote beneath the image, in block letters, DO NOT COMPLETE WHAT THE SOURCE DOES NOT SHOW.

The Margin Meeting

Mabel asked the newspaper's records librarian to meet her after the morning edition had gone to press. The librarian, Esi Quartey, arrived carrying a shallow archive box and the expression of someone who had been asked to reopen a matter she had hoped was settled.

"I have not brought you a revelation," Esi said. "I have brought you the things we should have checked before we called the old article complete."

Inside the box were two galley proofs, a typed correction slip, and a thin envelope labelled with a date. Esi placed each item on the table without overlapping them. The first proof contained a

sentence about a child being moved from Haven House after an administrative review. In the published version, the sentence had become a general reference to a transfer. The change was small enough to escape a casual reader, but it removed the suggestion that a specific child had been involved.

“Who requested the alteration?” Mabel asked.

“The slip says ‘desk instruction.’ No name, no initials.”

“Was that normal?”

“It happened. It should not have happened without a note in the production log, but it did.” Esi tapped the envelope. “This is the log for that week. The page is intact. The entry is missing.”

Mabel refused to turn ‘missing’ into ‘stolen’. She photographed the log, noted its dimensions, and asked Esi to record how it had been stored. A gap was evidence of a gap—not proof of the explanation.

Esi remembered a late telephone call from an editor who had since died. She could not recall the caller’s name, and she admitted that she might be combining two separate evenings. Mabel asked her to describe the call without trying to identify the speaker. Esi remembered a request to remove “the personal detail,” followed by a warning that the newspaper should not expose a child’s identity.

“That could have been protection,” Mabel said, “or pressure.”

“Yes,” Esi replied. “And the paper does not tell us which.”

Mabel wrote both possibilities in her notes. She would ask the former production assistant whether the desk used a code for sensitive stories. If the answer could not be verified, the article would say so. The proof did not name the child, but it established that someone had considered the detail important enough to alter. For now, that was the honest limit of what they had.

Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu arrived with a plain-clothes officer and no visible hurry. That was how Mabel knew he was concerned. When he was angry, he moved quickly. When he was worried, he became deliberate.

He asked her to show him the message without forwarding it again. He photographed the screen with the device used for case documentation, recording the number, the time received, and the steps they had taken. He did not ask her to guess who had sent it.

“Did you open any link?” he asked.

“There was no link.”

“Did you reply?”

“No.”

“Good. We’ll ask the service provider to preserve what can be preserved. It may lead nowhere, and the number may be temporary.”

“Do you think the sender is connected to the registry?”

“I think they want you to believe they are. That is not the same thing.”

He arranged for an officer to accompany Mabel to her office, then returned to the records room. Ama Serwaa had placed the original register inside a protective sleeve and signed across the seal. The box remained where it had been, its position marked on the access sheet. Mr Dapaah stood beside it with a face that suggested he had not enjoyed the morning.

“I have worked in records for twenty-six years,” Dapaah said. “I have never seen a file cause this much trouble.”

“Files do not cause trouble,” Badu replied. “People do.”

Dapaah handed over a folder. “This is the archive movement register. I found a receipt attached to the back. It should not be there.”

The receipt was a narrow slip of paper, yellowing at the fold. It recorded the transfer of a sealed parcel from the central records annex to the regional registry. The date was eleven years earlier, long after the original Haven House review. The parcel number matched the new box’s temporary inventory code, not its official archival reference.

At the bottom was a signature.

Badu placed the receipt on a clean surface, photographed it with a scale, and asked Dapaah to describe where he had found it.

“Between the movement register and its backing sheet,” Dapaah said. “It was folded into the spine. I did not remove it until this morning, when I checked the register after your call.”

“Who else knew you were checking?”

“My deputy. Ama. The archive supervisor in the central office, because I asked for the old transfer list yesterday.”

“Did you tell anyone what you found?”

“No. I thought I should wait for you.”

“That was sensible.”

The signature was accompanied by block capitals: K. MENSAH. Retired Inspector K. B. Mensah had been associated with the earlier investigation, but the letters did not establish that he had signed the receipt. A signature could be forged, abbreviated, or entered by someone else. Even a genuine signature would prove only that the person signed a transfer record, not that they knew what the parcel contained.

Badu wrote: “Potential link to retired Inspector Mensah. Authorship and significance unverified.”

“Have you contacted him?” Dapaah asked.

“Not yet.”

“If it is his signature—”

“If it is his signature, we still need to know why he signed it, what he believed he was receiving, and

whether the parcel described here is the same object now before us. One step at a time.”

The movement register showed that the parcel had passed through three offices before reaching the regional registry. Two transfers carried full signatures and badge numbers. The third had only initials and a date. The line for the final destination had been filled in with different ink.

“Could the different ink simply mean a different clerk?” Badu asked.

“Yes,” Dapaah said. “It could.”

“Could the missing badge number be a routine omission?”

“It could.”

“Could the receipt have been attached years after the transfer?”

“It could.”

Badu looked up. “You are being very careful.”

“I am learning from you.”

“Then learn this too: a pattern is worth following, but it is not yet a conclusion.”

He requested certified copies of the movement register and transfer list, and arranged for the original receipt to be sealed for examination. Each handover was signed. When the receipt left the room, it became an item whose custody could be accounted for.

At the station, Badu spread the documents across a table. The parcel number appeared in one index as “H.H. review supplementary material.” In a second, the same number was recorded as “administrative returns.” A third list omitted it entirely. The discrepancies might reflect poor indexing, a change in classification, or deliberate interference. None could yet be ruled out.

He called the central records annex and asked the supervisor to preserve the old transfer books without alteration. He then spoke with a forensic document examiner, who advised that the receipt should be submitted with known examples of the possible signatory’s handwriting, collected lawfully and with a documented source.

Only after those steps did he telephone retired Inspector K. B. Mensah.

“Badu,” Mensah answered.

“Good afternoon, sir. I need to ask you about an archival transfer receipt dated eleven years ago.”

“Which receipt?”

“A parcel associated with the Haven House review. The initials read K. Mensah.”

There was a pause long enough to notice, but not long enough to prove anything.

“Where did you find it?” Mensah asked.

“In a movement register at the regional registry.”

“Then it has been there a long time.”

“Do you recognise the transfer?”

“I would need to see the document.”

“That can be arranged through a formal interview.”

“I’m retired, Superintendent. I don’t answer to every person who finds an old paper.”

“I’m asking you to assist an inquiry into a murder and the handling of records connected to it.”

“Send a formal request,” Mensah said. “I will speak to you through the proper channel.”

The line went dead. Badu wrote down the exchange, including Mensah’s question about where the receipt was found. He did not mark the response as suspicious. A retired officer might reasonably want to know whether a document had been handled properly before discussing it.

Sergeant Esi Tandoh studied the index pages. “The parcel seems to disappear and reappear depending on which list you read.”

“That may be a records problem.”

“And if it isn’t?”

“Then we will establish that through evidence.”

She tapped the line labelled administrative returns. “Why would a children’s-home review be filed as returns?”

“Someone may have sent supplementary material back to the archive. A clerk may have used a generic category. Or the description may have been deliberately vague. We have three possibilities and no basis yet to choose one.”

“Do you ever get tired of refusing the obvious?”

“I get tired of people calling their preferred explanation obvious.”

The dates did not align neatly. The receipt recorded a parcel movement in March. A central annex list showed a parcel with the same number received in February, while the regional registry’s intake stamp was dated April. If all dates were accurate, the parcel had spent weeks in transit or in an unrecorded holding area. If one date was wrong, the apparent gap might vanish.

Badu asked the records unit to establish the calendar and staff roster for the period. A public holiday could explain a delay; a staff transfer could explain a missing signature; an office relocation could explain the different ink and inconsistent numbering. They would check ordinary explanations before treating the gaps as evidence of wrongdoing.

At five o’clock, the central records supervisor called back. Two bound transfer books had been located. One was intact. The other had a section cut from its index, leaving a ragged edge along the stitching. The supervisor said the damage was old and might have occurred during routine rebinding.

“Do not remove anything else,” Badu told him. “Photograph the book as it is. Record who has handled it. I’ll send an officer to supervise the transfer.”

Tandoh looked at him. “A missing section, a strange receipt, and a threatening message.”

“Yes.”

“You still won’t say they’re connected.”

“Not until we have evidence connecting them.”

“But you will investigate them together?”

“I will preserve the possibility that they are connected while testing whether they are. That is different.”

He drafted an evidence map with separate branches: the new box, the receipt, the incomplete index, the unknown caller, and the message sent to Mabel. A line between two branches would be added only when a source justified it. For now, the lines remained unjoined.

That evening, Badu visited Daniel Sarpong. He did not take the receipt with him and did not tell Daniel

that Mensah's initials had appeared on it. He asked whether Daniel remembered any adult returning to Haven House after the original review.

Daniel sat near the window, listening without interrupting. Adwoa Sarpong stood by the kitchen doorway, arms folded.

"I remember people coming and going," Daniel said. "I remember a man who never signed the book. I don't know his name."

"Did you see his face?"

"I remember his shoes. Dark leather, polished. He stayed near the office. I was a child. I watched what children watch."

"Do you remember when?"

"Not the date. It could have been before the review, during it, or later. My memories of that place are not arranged like a file."

"That's fair," Badu said. "We need to keep it that way."

Adwoa came forward. "Are you asking because you found something?"

"I found a transfer receipt that may relate to the review material. Its meaning is not established."

"Does it name Daniel?"

"No."

"Does it name the fifth child?"

“Not in a way we can trust yet.”

Daniel looked down at his hands. “Everyone keeps saying fifth child as if the person is waiting somewhere with the answer.”

“I won’t assume that,” Badu said. “The phrase may refer to a person, a record, or something else. We will test each possibility.”

“Good,” Daniel said. “I have spent too much of my life being turned into an answer to other people’s questions.”

Badu had no useful reassurance to offer, and a promise of certainty would have been dishonest.

When he returned to his car, a message from the central annex waited on his secure phone. A preliminary image of the cut index showed a faint impression beneath the remaining paper. The missing section had not been removed cleanly; pressure marks suggested another sheet might once have been placed over it.

Badu saved the image to the case file and recorded the time. It was another lead, not yet a discovery. The receipt might be genuine. Mensah might have signed it. The index might have been damaged by accident. The anonymous sender might have known the story from public reporting.

But the documents were beginning to ask the same question from different directions: who had handled

the parcel after the review was supposed to be finished?

Badu closed the case file. He would not answer that question tonight. He would make sure, however, that nobody had the chance to remove the question before morning.

Badu began the next morning by separating the questions that had started to merge in his mind. Was the receipt authentic? Did the parcel contain the register? Had the parcel been opened after transfer? And, separately, had anyone altered the index? Four questions, four evidential routes. A true signature on a receipt would establish a handover, not the contents of the envelope. A missing index page would establish a gap, not the identity of the person who caused it.

He asked the records officer to preserve the receipt in its current condition and prepare a high-resolution scan. The original was placed in a transparent evidence sleeve, with the handling details entered in the log. Badu did not touch the ink or try to compare it by eye with signatures from unrelated documents. Any handwriting assessment would require suitable known samples and a qualified examiner. For now, the initials were only initials.

The officer, a careful woman named Mrs. Osei, brought him the transfer ledger and a list of staff assigned to the annex during the relevant week. The

list was incomplete because the duty roster had been reconstructed from payroll records. Two temporary clerks were named only by staff numbers. One had left public service years earlier; the other’s file contained no current address.

“Can we identify them?” Badu asked.

“Possibly. The payroll unit may still have appointment forms. But I would not promise the forms include signatures.”

“Please request them. Record who searched and what was found, even if nothing turns up.”

Mrs. Osei nodded. “You want the gaps documented as carefully as the records.”

“Especially the gaps.”

Later, Mabel joined him at the station with her own notes. They compared the dates without treating a match as proof of a shared event. The receipt was dated eleven years after the review. The visitor register copy was undated. The audit summary referred to a discrepancy but did not identify the missing item. Each document touched the same administrative history, yet none independently named the person who had removed or changed anything.

“If we publish that a senior officer took the parcel, we may destroy the inquiry,” Mabel said. “And we may accuse someone on the strength of three incomplete records.”

“Then we do not publish it,” Badu replied. “Not as fact. We can report that the records conflict, if the public interest requires it and the documents are verified. But first we need to know what the parcel was meant to contain.”

Mabel wrote that sentence down. She had spent years watching powerful people use uncertainty as a shield. Now she was being reminded that uncertainty could also protect the innocent. The challenge was not to avoid a conclusion forever. It was to make the evidence strong enough that a conclusion could survive scrutiny.

Before leaving, Badu asked the officer to check whether the transfer receipt had a matching dispatch entry. A receipt could be genuine and still be attached to the wrong parcel. The dispatch number, seal description, weight, and destination might tell them whether the paper trail belonged to the register or to something else entirely. He added the request to the case log and set a reminder to follow it up. The investigation moved forward by inches, but each inch had to rest on something that could be checked.

The dispatch counter

The next morning, Badu and Mabel visited the dispatch counter named on the transfer receipt. The office had been renovated, but an old ledger cupboard remained behind a locked partition. The records

manager explained that outgoing bundles were sometimes recorded in a dispatch book while incoming offices kept their own receipt books. A complete chain required both ends. One entry could show that a parcel left; it could not prove that the intended recipient received it intact.

The dispatch clerk found a book for the relevant period. Several lines were faded, and a water stain crossed the lower corner of the page. The entry number matched the receipt, but the destination was abbreviated. Beside it was a short notation that might have been a date correction. The clerk would not guess at the initials and warned them that different staff used similar marks.

Badu requested a certified image of the full page, including the entries above and below. He also asked whether the office maintained a register of damaged or returned bundles. The clerk said such a register might have been kept separately, depending on the year. He wrote down the search request and signed it. The signature was clear, dated, and linked to an official process—a small example of what the missing records should have provided.

Mabel noticed that the receipt had been folded so that the destination line sat inside the crease. That alone did not prove deliberate concealment; the paper might have been folded for storage. She photographed the fold with the clerk’s permission and described it in

her notes without assigning motive. She had seen how easily a neutral detail could become an accusation once repeated often enough.

Before they left, the clerk mentioned a returned parcel whose sender had never collected it. He could not say whether it was their bundle. The return book was stored off-site and would take several days to retrieve. Badu thanked him and recorded the reference. For the first time, the paper trail suggested not just a transfer but the possibility of a failed delivery. Whether that failure was accidental or arranged remained unanswered.

Badu signed first. Mabel added the time. Neither knew whether the missing receipt would lead to a person or another gap. For the first time, however, they had a documented route to follow instead of a rumour about a vanished file.

Before they left, Mensima asked them to initial the visitor sheet. Mabel paused at the line. The register contained full names, arrival times, purposes, and staff initials. It was a simple record, but it made a point the older books did not: an office could not guarantee every entry would be perfect, yet it could make omissions visible and preserve a trail for later checking.

Mabel felt the urge to turn the empty column into a dramatic answer. She resisted it. If the missing signature was proof of deliberate concealment, they

needed more than an absence. They needed evidence showing how the office normally completed the field, whether the same clerk had handled the batch, and whether another document recorded the receipt elsewhere.

Badu asked whether there were batch sheets. Mensima said the office had kept them inconsistently. Some were attached to monthly summaries; others had been stored in separate cartons. She wrote down two box references and signed the note, confirming only that those references existed in the index.

“Not necessarily. A clerk may have failed to complete the field. A receipt may have been filed separately. A bundle might have been accepted under a general batch number. Or it might never have arrived. The blank tells us what the register does not record, not which possibility happened.”

“Does a blank mean no one received it?” Mabel asked.

Badu asked the station’s communications officer to print the message metadata available from the receiving device. It was not a miracle of technology; the record contained less than the sender might have feared and less than the investigators wanted. It showed the time the message arrived and the route by which it reached Mabel, but it did not establish who had typed it. The number could be prepaid, borrowed, or registered under someone else’s details. Badu

refused to let the team turn a phone number into a culprit before they had a person.

He then interviewed the receptionist who had accepted the courier envelope at the newspaper office. She remembered a motorbike helmet and a dark raincoat, but the morning had been busy and the reception camera's angle showed only the counter. Her description was recorded as a recollection, not an identification. When another officer suggested showing her photographs of known suspects, Badu stopped him. "We are not going to teach a witness whom to remember," he said. They would preserve her account first and decide later whether a formal identification procedure was justified.

Mabel watched the process with mixed relief and frustration. The rules slowed everything down. They also made it harder for an official to dismiss the investigation as a journalist's rumour. Badu explained that a message could be genuine and still be misleading. A sender might know one fact, misunderstand another, or deliberately combine truth with a false conclusion. Their task was not to reward the sender for being mysterious. It was to test every claim against records they could independently verify.

Before they parted, Badu asked Mabel to write down the exact sequence in which she had received, opened, photographed, and reported the message. She did so, including the moment she had first shown it to

a colleague. He made no accusation about the delay. Instead, he attached her account to the evidence log and asked her to notify him before responding if another message arrived. “We can investigate a warning,” he said. “We cannot let it direct the investigation.”

In the records room, Mensima laid a photocopy of the receipt beside a page from the destination register. The first carried a dispatch date; the second carried a date two days later. Between them sat a gap where the receiving signature should have been. The paper was not torn. The column had simply been left blank.

Badu asked that the request and response be logged. Mensima wrote the reference on a duplicate slip and stamped it. The small administrative act mattered: there would be a record of what they had asked for and when the office had agreed to search.

Mabel watched the clerk compare the dates. The receipt had been treated as if it were a map showing exactly where the file had gone. In fact, it was only one link in a chain. A dispatch entry could show that a packet left one desk; it could not prove what was inside it or who opened it at the other end.

“There is a mark beside it. Whether it is an initial or a processing mark is not clear from this copy.” She turned the book so they could see the headings. “I will not guess for you. We can arrange an official copy of the entry, including the lines above and below it.”

“Was the change initialled?” Badu asked.

The senior clerk, Adwoa Mensima, checked the number in a bound index. “There is a matching dispatch entry, but the destination code was changed in the next register. I need to bring the two books together before I can explain it.”

The courier company supplied a route sheet showing that the envelope had been scanned at a local depot before delivery. The scan established a point in the journey, not the identity of the person who prepared the parcel. Badu requested the original route record and the company’s explanation of its scanning procedure. He also asked whether the courier had accepted any other item from the same sender that morning. The answer was inconclusive: the route included many collections, and the records did not preserve the contents of each parcel. Mabel was disappointed, but Badu reminded her that a reliable negative result could narrow a search. They added the route sheet to the chronology and left the sender’s identity open.

Badu reminded the team that every lead should have a next step and a stopping point. If a source could not be verified after reasonable checks, the report would say so. An unanswered question was not a licence to keep repeating the most convenient theory.

No one would be named in the briefing until independent material connected that person to the act.

Following the Route, Not the Rumour

The dispatch office was busier than it had been on their first visit. Clerks sorted envelopes into trays while a courier waited beside the counter with a sack of registered mail. Badu showed his authorisation and asked for the movement record associated with the receipt number. He did not mention the theory that the bundle had been deliberately diverted. He wanted the office to answer a narrow question before he asked a wider one.

The Depot Interview

Badu met the depot supervisor in a small office that smelled of paper dust and floor polish. The supervisor, Kofi Annan-Sarpong, had worked for the courier company for nearly thirty years and now trained new staff on the tracking system. He was careful not to pretend that experience gave him a perfect memory.

“The old system was partly electronic and partly manual,” he explained. “A scan showed that a parcel passed a point. The paper sheet showed who was assigned to the route. Neither one, by itself, proved who packed the parcel.”

Badu showed him the receipt number. Kofi checked the database, then fetched a retired route

ledger kept for audit purposes. The ledger's line had been ruled in blue ink. The delivery point matched the office named on the receipt, but the parcel description was generic: sealed document packet.

"Could a packet be opened and resealed during transit?" Mabel asked.

"Physically, yes. Under procedure, no. If it were damaged, we would note it and ask a supervisor to witness the condition. I see no such note here."

"Does that prove it stayed sealed?"

"No," Kofi said. "It proves no damage was recorded. Records are not windows. They are what people wrote down."

He explained that the route driver signed for the sack, not each envelope inside it. A clerk at the receiving office would normally sign the receipt, but the surviving copy had a blurred mark where the signature should have been. The original might still exist in a box sent to off-site storage after the company changed premises.

Badu requested a search under the receipt number, the destination office, and the month. He also asked for the retention schedule so the team could establish whether missing paperwork should have been preserved. Kofi promised to answer in writing.

As they left, Mabel asked whether the company had ever investigated lost documents from that period.

Kofi recalled one general audit after several departments complained about delayed mail. He could not remember whether this packet had been included.

“That audit could matter,” Badu said outside. “But only if we can find its records.”

Mabel glanced at the route ledger copy in the evidence sleeve. The packet had moved through a real system, under ordinary procedures, with ordinary gaps. That made the trail more credible, but it did not yet tell them what the packet contained or who had handled it after delivery. They would pursue the audit without assuming it was the missing link.

The first thing Daniel remembered about Haven House was not a face. It was the beds.

Five narrow iron frames stood in the room at the end of the corridor, their paint chipped where restless hands had worried at it. The mattresses were thin, the sheets were washed so often that they had lost their colour, and the space between each bed was barely wide enough for a child to stand without touching the next frame. Daniel remembered the beds because he had counted them when he was too young to understand why counting made him feel safer.

He remembered five beds. He did not remember five children sleeping in them at the same time.

That distinction had followed him into adulthood. Whenever someone asked about the fifth child, they seemed to expect him to produce a name from the locked room in his memory. He could not. He could offer only fragments: a blanket folded at the foot of a bed, a cup with a blue rim, the sound of a cough behind a partition. Fragments could be real and still be insufficient. He had learned not to turn them into a story just to satisfy someone else's impatience.

The day after Badu's visit, Daniel sat at the kitchen table while Adwoa placed two mugs of tea beside a stack of old photographs. She had taken them from a

biscuit tin kept on the highest shelf of a cupboard. The tin had once held sewing needles and spare buttons. Now it held the small, fragile evidence of a childhood that neither of them had been able to organise into a reliable timeline.

“You don't have to look at them today,” Adwoa said.

“I know.”

“You didn't sleep.”

“I slept a little.”

She did not challenge him. She sat opposite and opened the tin.

The photographs were mostly ordinary: a school group in front of a painted wall, children arranged in uneven rows, a woman holding a baby whose face had blurred from movement. On the back of one photograph, someone had written a date in blue ink. On another, a name had been scratched out so forcefully that the paper had torn.

Daniel picked up the school photograph. He recognised the building from the shape of its windows, though the paint had been different when he lived there. The children were dressed in mismatched clothes. Some stared straight at the camera; others looked toward whoever stood just beyond the frame.

“How many?” Adwoa asked.

He counted them. “Nine.”

“And you recognise any?”

“Not with confidence.” He set the photograph down. “That boy might be me, but the face is too small. The ears look similar. That isn't enough.”

“Could we have it enlarged?”

“Yes. But we should keep the original safe and not write on it.”

Adwoa gave him a look. “You sound like Badu.”

“He is right about records. I don't have to like his habits to admit that.”

They sorted the photographs by paper type and apparent age, not by a guessed sequence. Adwoa wrote each temporary number on a separate sleeve. They photographed the front and back of each image, noting any writing without trying to erase or enhance it. Daniel was surprised by how much the process steadied him. For years he had thought of memory as a room he must enter alone. Now he could set a photograph on a table and describe what he saw without being forced to decide what it meant.

The third photograph showed a dormitory. Five beds ran along one wall. The picture had been taken from the doorway, and the far corner was shadowed. A small shape lay on the bed nearest the window, mostly hidden beneath a sheet. At first Daniel thought

it was a folded blanket. Then he noticed the shape of a foot at the edge of the fabric.

He stopped breathing for a moment, then let the air out slowly.

“Do you know who that is?” Adwoa asked.

“No.”

“Does it look familiar?”

“The room does.” He tilted the photograph toward the light. “The bed nearest the window had a loose iron bar. It made a sound when anyone sat on it.”

“Can you tell which bed that is?”

“I think so. But the picture doesn't prove who was sleeping there, or when it was taken.”

Adwoa sat back. “You keep adding warnings to every sentence.”

“Because people have used my life as evidence for things I never said.” He looked at her. “I don't want to do that to someone else.”

She reached across the table and rested her hand over his. “Then we will be careful together.”

They made a note of the photograph's details and placed it in a separate sleeve for later examination. No name was added. No theory was written beside it. The five beds had become a new question, but it was not yet an answer.

Across town, Badu received a message from the central records annex confirming that the two transfer books had been secured. An officer had witnessed the books being placed in protective packaging. The damaged index had not been touched further. A preliminary examination could be arranged, but the examiner warned that pressure marks and missing paper did not guarantee that any readable text would be recovered.

Badu read the message twice before forwarding it to the case team. He wanted everyone to understand both parts: the material might yield something important, and it might yield nothing. He had seen investigators build entire theories around a promising mark that later proved to be a stain. The discipline was not in finding meaning. It was in resisting meaning that the evidence could not bear.

Sergeant Tandoh entered carrying a thin folder. “The Haven House staff list from that year has arrived.”

“Original or copy?”

“Certified copy from the district office. The original register is reportedly in a separate archive.”

“Reportedly?”

“The clerk who sent it says the original was transferred during an office move. She hasn't located the transfer note yet.”

Badu opened the folder. The list contained staff names, job titles, and dates of appointment. Several names were familiar from the old case file. Others belonged to people who had never been interviewed. One line had a handwritten amendment beside the name of a night supervisor. The note read: “temporary reassignment — Room Four.” It was dated three days after the review meeting.

“Who wrote the amendment?” Badu asked.

“No attribution. It could be the supervisor, the administrator, or a clerk copying an instruction.”

“Then we record it as unattributed.”

Tandoh pointed to the date. “Three days after the review. Does that mean the room was still in use?”

“It means someone wrote that the supervisor was temporarily reassigned to Room Four. We need to know what the phrase meant in that institution. It might refer to the physical room, an internal code, or a duty assignment. Don't turn the words into a scene before we know the language.”

“Understood.”

They checked the other entries. The same phrase appeared twice in the following month, but in different handwriting. One entry had a supervisor's initials; the other had none. The documents suggested that Room Four had continued to matter

administratively after the review. They did not show what happened there.

Badu requested the original staff register, any key-control log, and the institution's floor plan from the relevant period. If Room Four was a room in the ordinary sense, its location and access arrangements could be established. If it was an administrative label, the plan might show nothing. Either result would help narrow the question.

That afternoon, Mabel came to the station with a written account of the anonymous message. She had kept the original message on her phone and had not replied. Badu recorded the statement and asked whether she was willing to have the device examined by a specialist, with the scope and privacy limits explained in advance.

“I will cooperate,” she said. “But I want the examination documented. I don't want unrelated personal messages copied into the case file.”

“That is reasonable. The request will specify the relevant message and the technical information needed. If a broader extraction becomes necessary, we will discuss the legal basis and safeguards before proceeding.”

Mabel signed the statement. “I have also found something in my own notes.”

She opened a small notebook she had kept for years. It was not a diary in the usual sense. She had used it to record fragments of reporting, addresses, and questions she could not yet answer. On a page near the back, beneath a list of school names, she had written: “five beds / four names / do not copy the last line.” The handwriting was hers, but she could not remember writing it.

Badu read the line without touching the page. “When did you make this note?”

“I don't know. There are dates on the pages before and after it, but this page is undated.”

“Could it have been written during the first investigation?”

“Possibly. I carried the notebook then. But it might be older, or I might have added it later.”

“Do you remember the phrase?”

“Not clearly. The words sound like the memory I told you about, but I cannot say whether they came from Room Four or from a conversation afterwards.”

Badu asked her to photograph the page and the surrounding pages, then made a note to arrange a documented scan. He did not take the notebook from her. The fact that a note existed was significant; its date and context remained uncertain.

Mabel looked at him. “Does this help?”

“It gives us a line to investigate. It does not confirm what the line means.”

“I thought you would say that.”

“You came because you wanted the truth, not because you wanted me to praise a theory.”

She closed the notebook. “Sometimes I would settle for a theory that lets me sleep.”

“I understand. But if we choose one too early, the wrong person may pay for it.”

Mabel glanced toward the window. “I keep thinking about the message. The sender says I remember more than I admit. What if I do?”

“Then we will write down what returns to you, separately from what you conclude. You don't have to force a memory to appear. And you don't have to accept someone else's claim about your mind.”

For a while she said nothing. Then she described another fragment: the smell of damp paper, the scrape of a chair, and a voice asking whether the children had been counted before the visitors arrived. She could not place the voice. She did not know whether it belonged to a man or a woman. She remembered only that someone answered, “They are all on the list.”

Badu asked her to repeat the words as she remembered them, not to improve them. He recorded the account with her permission, then read it back. Mabel corrected one phrase and marked another as

uncertain. When she finished, she looked exhausted but less frightened.

Before she left, Badu gave her the case liaison's number and reminded her to report any further contact, however harmless it might seem. He did not tell her to stop working or to disappear from public life. He offered practical precautions and let her decide what she could safely continue.

That evening, Daniel and Adwoa delivered digital copies of the photographs to the investigator assigned to the archive review. They kept the originals at home. The image of the five beds was included, with a note stating that the date, location, and identity of the figure on the bed had not been established.

Daniel looked at the copy one last time before closing the folder.

For most of his life, he had thought the missing name was the centre of the mystery. Now he wondered whether the name had been removed because it mattered—or whether the act of removing it had been meant to make everyone look at the wrong thing. A record could hide a person. It could also hide the person who had changed it.

He did not write either thought on the photograph. He wrote only: “Dormitory image. Five beds visible. Date and identities unverified.”

Then he put the folder away.

The next morning, a certified copy of the old floor plan arrived at Badu's office. Room Four was not a dormitory. It was a small administrative room beside the office where visitors signed in. The five beds in Daniel's photograph belonged to the dormitory at the far end of the building, labelled Room Two on the plan.

Badu read the labels carefully. Room Four and the room with five beds were different places.

The distinction did not resolve the mystery. It changed the shape of it.

He called Mabel first, then Daniel. Neither had claimed the beds were in Room Four, but both had spoken of the fifth child as if the phrase and the room might be connected. He told them the plan had arrived and asked them not to revise their memories to fit it.

“I'm not saying the photograph is unrelated,” he explained. “I'm saying the floor plan establishes that the rooms were separate. We must keep that fact visible while we investigate the phrase.”

Daniel was quiet. “So the five beds don't prove there were five children in Room Four.”

“Correct.”

“And Room Four doesn't prove there were five beds.”

“Correct.”

Mabel said, “Then someone may have wanted us to combine two things that were never the same thing.”

“Possibly,” Badu replied. “But we do not yet know whether that was anyone's intention.”

After the calls, he pinned the floor plan beside the inventory copy. Room Four was a small office with a door to the corridor and a second door opening into a records alcove. The dormitory was a different building section altogether. On the plan, a narrow passage linked the administrative rooms to the courtyard. The route was ordinary, unremarkable, and easy to overlook.

Badu marked the two rooms in separate colours on his working copy, then wrote beneath them: “Do not conflate.”

The fifth child might still be a person. The fifth line might still contain a name. The five beds might be a separate clue, or simply a detail that had survived in Daniel's memory because it had once mattered to him. None of those possibilities could be dismissed. None could be treated as settled.

At the bottom of the floor plan, in a corner partly obscured by a fold, was a note about the visitor register: “Duplicate to be returned with monthly papers.” There was no signature and no date.

Badu photographed the note and added it to the evidence map. For the first time, the phrase return

appeared on a document connected directly to the old institution—not on the later receipt, and not in an index. It was a small connection, but at least it was a connection that could be described without guessing.

He opened a fresh page in his notebook and wrote three questions:

Who made the visitor-register duplicate?

What were the “monthly papers”?

Was the duplicate returned?

He left space beneath each question for the evidence that might answer it. Then he closed the notebook and returned to the case file, aware that the story was growing more complicated, not less. The task was not to make every fragment fit. It was to discover which fragments belonged together—and to leave the rest apart until they earned their place.

That afternoon, Mabel returned to the surviving floor plan and laid it beside a later maintenance sketch. The drawings were not made to the same scale. One showed the children’s sleeping area; the other marked a corridor, a store cupboard, and a room whose label had been overwritten during renovation. A casual reader might have treated the repeated number four as a single location. The measurements warned against that shortcut.

She asked a retired maintenance worker, Mr. Tetteh, to explain the building’s old layout. He

remembered the dormitory because a leaking roof had forced the children to sleep in the common room for several nights. He did not remember the confidential room described in the review papers, and he was careful not to pretend otherwise.

“People call every room by the name they remember,” he said. “After repairs, the numbers changed. A room could be called Four in one book and Store in another. That does not mean the rooms were the same.”

“Could a visitor reach the confidential room from the main corridor?”

“Yes, if the door was open. But I cannot tell you who went in. I was maintenance, not security.”

Mabel recorded the interview with his permission and later checked the dates against the renovation file. The roof repairs had happened after the review period. That made the maintenance sketch useful for understanding the building, but not a perfect map of the night under investigation. She marked the drawing “retrospective reference—not contemporaneous” and attached the source details.

At home, she spread five small paper squares across the table and labelled them with the separate questions: five beds, Room Four, the fifth line, the fifth child, and the phrase from the anonymous message. She moved the squares apart until none touched. The

arrangement looked absurd, but it helped her resist the temptation to make one clue explain all the others.

The beds were a physical fact reported by people who had seen the dormitory. Room Four was an administrative label whose location had to be established for the relevant date. The fifth line was a mark on a copy. The fifth child was a phrase whose meaning remained unknown. The message was an unverified communication. If the questions eventually connected, the connection would need evidence of its own.

She photographed the layout for her notes, then removed the squares before anyone else could mistake her working theory for a finding. The case was beginning to resemble a puzzle, but real people had lived inside these records. A wrong conclusion could attach suspicion to a person who had done nothing except sign a form or sleep in a numbered bed. Mabel would not let the neatness of a theory outrank the dignity of the people it described.

The caretaker remembers

Madam Efua Nyarko agreed to meet them in the shaded courtyard behind her home. She had kept a small notebook after leaving Haven House, not as an official record but as a personal reminder of children who had needed extra clothing, medicine, or a different sleeping arrangement. She warned them that

the notebook was incomplete and that memory after many years could be unreliable. Badu asked her to tell them what she knew before showing her any documents.

She described the dormitory as a long room with five narrow beds at one end during a period when the home was crowded. The beds were not the same thing as Room Four, she stressed. Room Four was an administrative space; the dormitory was where children slept. The similar number had caused confusion before, especially when people spoke quickly or wrote abbreviated notes.

Mabel asked whether five beds meant five children had been assigned to the room. Nyarko said it might mean five beds were present, not that every bed was occupied on a particular night. Children moved between rooms when they were ill or when repairs were being made. A bed inventory could show the layout, but it could not establish who slept there without attendance records or independent testimony.

Nyarko opened her notebook to a page marked with a month and a list of supplies. One line referred to a mattress being moved into storage. There was no child’s name beside it. The note was ordinary, almost trivial, but it offered a date range for a later comparison with the dormitory inventory. Badu asked permission to photograph it and documented that it was a personal notebook, not an official register.

As they were leaving, Nyarko said she remembered an evening when staff were told not to use the main corridor. She could not recall the date or who gave the instruction. Mabel did not press her to name someone. Instead, she asked what made the event memorable. Nyarko recalled that the corridor had been freshly mopped and that a bucket stood near the stairwell. Those details might help identify a maintenance log, but they were not proof of who had issued the instruction.

On the drive back, Mabel studied the map. Five beds did not identify the fifth child, and Room Four did not explain the missing file. But the places were beginning to separate from the rumours attached to them, making the next question more precise.

Daniel returned to the memory only after Mabel stopped asking questions. He sat with his hands folded, looking past her towards the window, where a trotro hooted at a taxi that had blocked the lane. He could remember the room’s heat and the way the corridor smelled of soap and damp concrete. He remembered one child crying after lights-out and another whispering a counting rhyme. Yet when he tried to place a face on each bed, the memories refused to settle into a complete picture.

“I can tell you there were five frames,” he said. “I cannot swear that five children slept there that night.” He expected disappointment, perhaps even disbelief.

Instead, Mabel repeated the distinction and asked if he wanted a break. The offer mattered. For years, people had treated his uncertain memories as a puzzle they could solve by pressing him harder. He had learned to give answers that ended conversations, even when the answers were not entirely his own.

Badu arranged for Daniel to speak with a counsellor familiar with adult witnesses recalling childhood events. The meeting was not designed to recover a hidden truth or suggest what Daniel ought to remember. It was meant to help him speak without being led. Badu also made clear that a counsellor’s observations would not substitute for evidence about the old register. A person’s distress could explain why an interview needed care; it could not prove who altered a record.

Afterwards Daniel drew a rough plan of the room from memory. He placed the door, the window, the five bed frames, and the cupboard. He marked one space with a question mark because he could not recall whether it had held a mattress or a stack of folded bedding. He signed and dated the drawing. When Badu asked whether he was certain of the layout, Daniel said he was certain only that it was the best drawing he could make today. Badu preserved it with that qualification attached. The drawing did not settle the number of children present, but it showed exactly where Daniel’s memory ended.

Before leaving, Badu asked Yeboah to sign a short statement describing the plan and his recollection of the buildings. It did not ask him to identify a suspect. It recorded what he had personally known, what he could infer from the plan, and what he could no longer remember. Yeboah read every line before signing.

Mabel marked the uncertainty beside the window. Their records contained rooms with shared numbers and people with shared names. If they treated every ‘Room Four’ as the same place, a true detail from one location could be used to support a false account of another.

Yeboah confirmed that a narrow window in the administration passage looked toward the yard, though a later extension had partly blocked it. He could not remember whether the extension existed during the year in question. That detail would need to be dated from maintenance records or photographs.

“The map is a guide for testing accounts, not evidence by itself,” Badu said. “If someone places a witness where the plan blocks the view, we can ask how they know what they claim to have seen. But this sketch is not a measured survey.”

At the end of the walk, Mabel drew a rough map in her notebook. She marked the administration block, the dormitory, the side entrance, the caretaker’s store, and the gate. Beside each place she wrote a question:

Which room held the review file? Which room contained the beds? Which entrance appeared in the visitor records? Which staff member controlled the keys? Which route could a child have seen from the passage?

They walked the old yard at a measured pace. Yeboah pointed out the foundations of a removed wall and the place where a rainwater pipe once crossed the passage. His memories helped them understand how a person might move between buildings, but he did not claim to have seen the unknown visitor use any particular route.

Badu asked whether the plan was original. Yeboah said it appeared to be, but he could not identify the draughtsman or give a precise year. The paper could help locate spaces, not establish who entered them on a particular day. Badu photographed both sides and recorded where the plan had been found.

“Not according to this layout. The dormitory was across the yard. The review room had a desk, two chairs, and a cabinet. I remember it because I was asked to repair the cabinet lock once. I cannot say what documents were in it.”

Mabel studied the plan. “Could the five beds have been in the room where the review file was kept?”

Daniel later reviewed the room plan with a neutral interviewer who asked him to describe the drawing without looking at the old photograph. He

remembered that one bed stood nearer the window, but he was unsure whether the cupboard had been against the wall or in the corridor. The interviewer recorded the variation rather than asking him to choose between alternatives. Daniel said the uncertainty made him feel that he was failing the investigation. The interviewer explained that a careful witness was not required to produce a perfect memory; he was required to distinguish what he recalled from what he inferred. Daniel added a note to the drawing, marking the cupboard’s position as uncertain. That small annotation mattered more than a confident guess would have.

Daniel left the meeting with a copy of his drawing and a written explanation of how it would be stored. He asked that no one circulate it outside the inquiry. Badu agreed, and the request was recorded as part of the handling notes.

The drawing recorded Daniel’s memory on that day, not a guarantee that every detail was exact.

“People hear ‘Room Four’ and assume every reference points to the same place,” he said. “But there was the review room in the administration block, the dormitory rooms, and a storage room staff called the fourth room because of its position along the corridor. The names were not always official.”

The Caretaker's Plan

The former caretaker, Mr. Yeboah, met them at the side entrance to the old children's home. He had brought a folded plan kept with maintenance papers, not with the children's records. Its corners were softened from handling, and a pencilled note identified the east dormitory as "Room Five." He explained that room numbers had changed after a partition was built, which was why old staff sometimes used descriptions instead of numbers.

The Old Dormitory

Daniel asked to return to the former children's home in daylight, with his lawyer present. Badu agreed after arranging permission with the property manager and making clear that the visit was not a reenactment. Daniel would be shown the surviving layout; nobody would ask him to prove his memories by matching them to a building that had changed over the years.

The dormitory had been converted into offices. New partitions divided the long room, and the old windows had been replaced. Mr. Yeboah, the former caretaker, stood near the doorway with the folded maintenance plan tucked beneath his arm. He pointed out where the beds had once stood, but he did not claim to remember which child slept in each one.

“I moved furniture when the roof leaked,” he said. “Sometimes five beds, sometimes four. One might be in repair. A bed count was not a child count.”

Daniel looked along the wall. “I remember a narrow space beside the last bed.”

“There was a cupboard there,” Yeboah said, then paused. “Or there was later. I must not tell you that you remember it because I remember it.”

Badu noted the exchange. It was the first time the caretaker had corrected his own recollection without being prompted. He explained that the room labels had been changed after a partition was installed. A maintenance sheet referred to “Room Five,” while a social-work note from the same year referred to “the fifth bed.” They could easily be mistaken for the same reference if read quickly.

Mabel photographed the plan beside a scale and recorded the caretaker’s explanation. Daniel was quiet until they reached the doorway at the far end. He said he remembered waiting there while an adult spoke to someone inside another room. He could not recall the words, faces, or date.

“Does it feel like the day of the photograph?” his lawyer asked.

“I don’t know,” Daniel said. “It feels like a place I knew. That doesn’t mean I can identify the day.”

They left without asking him to choose a room number. Badu requested building plans, repair invoices, and the dates when the partitions had been installed. Those records might establish the layout at different times. They would not prove who had slept where, but they could prevent the investigation from confusing the name of a room with the identity of a child.

Outside, Daniel asked whether the visit had been useful. Badu told him it had narrowed the questions. It had not answered them. Daniel seemed relieved that no one was asking him to turn a feeling into a fact.

The visitor register arrived at the station in a cardboard sleeve sealed with two strips of evidence tape. It was not the original book from Haven House. That volume had disappeared years earlier, according to the surviving records. This was a duplicate: a monthly copy that should have been returned with the administrative papers, if the note on the floor plan was accurate.

Badu watched Sergeant Tandoh photograph the sleeve before they opened it. The courier signed the transfer form, Tandoh recorded the time, and a second officer witnessed the seal being cut. They had learned that a document could become the centre of a case long before anyone knew whether it was important. Its history had to be preserved as carefully as its contents.

Inside lay a thin exercise book with a blue cover, its corners softened by handling. The first pages listed staff, deliveries, and visitors to the children’s home. Several entries were routine: a nurse, a supplier, a

maintenance worker, a district officer. Others had been written in a different hand. At the end of each month, someone had copied selected names onto a separate sheet. The duplicate was incomplete, but the surviving pages included the month of the confidential review.

“Let’s not assume the omissions are deliberate,” Tandoh said.

“I’m not,” Badu replied. “We need to establish how the duplicate was made and what it was meant to include.”

The monthly sheet listed four visitors on the day of the review. Three had already been identified from the inquiry file. The fourth entry was a surname and initial: “Mensah, K.” The time column was blank. The purpose column contained a short dash. There was no badge number, office, or signature.

Tandoh looked up. “The same surname as the receipt.”

“The same surname and initial. That is a lead, not an identification.”

“Could be a different Mensah.”

“Could be. Could also be a clerk recording a visitor’s name from memory. We need to compare the handwriting and check who was using the visitor book that month.”

Badu photographed the entry at several angles, then set the register aside while Tandoh prepared a list of people who could authenticate the record. The surviving office roster named two administrators who had worked at Haven House during that period. One had died. The other, a retired matron called Madam Efua Nyarko, lived outside Cape Coast and had previously declined to speak to journalists.

Badu requested a formal interview through the appropriate channel. He did not telephone her directly. A former staff member's memory could be valuable, but the process mattered: she needed to know why she was being contacted, and her account had to be recorded without pressure.

While they waited, Mabel arrived carrying a notebook and a sealed envelope. She placed the envelope on the table.

"This came to my office by courier," she said. "No sender's name. I haven't opened it."

Badu checked the envelope's exterior and asked her to describe how it had been delivered. Mabel gave him the courier receipt and the time she had received it. The envelope was not automatically part of the criminal evidence simply because it had been sent to a journalist. But because it might relate to the threatening message, Badu documented it before asking whether she consented to opening it in his presence.

Inside was a photocopy of a visitor page. The image was faded and cropped. Four names were visible. At the bottom, a fifth entry had been covered with a black rectangle. In the margin, someone had typed a sentence: “The visitor was never entered in the main book.”

Mabel studied the page without touching it. “That could mean someone was omitted from the main register. Or it could be a note written by a person who wants us to believe that.”

“Exactly,” Badu said.

“The copy might be genuine.”

“It might.”

“Or it might be made from this duplicate.”

“Also possible.”

Mabel glanced at the blue-covered book. “Can we tell whether the photocopy came from this page?”

“Not yet. The crop removes the page edge and most of the ruling. We’ll compare the ink marks, spacing, and any visible defects. We should also find out whether the sender had access to the duplicate.”

He recorded the envelope’s arrival and photographed the contents. Mabel asked for a copy of the receipt to keep with her notes. Badu provided a certified image of the courier slip, but not the evidence

photograph. They agreed she would not publish the page until its origin could be assessed.

The visitor entry remained a narrow clue, but it changed the next step. Instead of trying to identify a person from a single initial, Badu needed to establish who had access to the visitor register, who made the monthly duplicates, and whether the duplicate was routinely checked against the original.

Tandoh found an old procedure sheet in the archive bundle. It stated that the receptionist was to record every visitor's full name, organisation, time of arrival, and purpose. The administrator on duty was to initial the page at the end of the day. At month's end, a clerk copied the entries into a summary sheet for the district office.

The surviving monthly copy did not meet that standard. It had partial names, missing times, and no initials from the administrator.

"That could be careless administration," Tandoh said.

"Yes," Badu replied. "And it could make the book unreliable. It does not tell us why the entries are incomplete."

He asked the records unit to identify the clerk responsible for monthly summaries. The name on the procedure sheet was Josephine Armah, who had transferred to another district shortly after the review.

Her personnel file showed that she had later retired. A current address was available through the official directory.

Before contacting her, Badu read the original inquiry notes again. One page mentioned that a visitor had arrived shortly before lunch and asked to see the matron. The visitor’s name was not recorded. The note had been filed under “administrative irregularities” and never followed up. It might refer to the person in the duplicate. It might refer to an entirely different day. The note had no date beyond the month.

He added it to the evidence map with a dotted line, not a solid one.

That afternoon, Madam Nyarko agreed to an interview at her home. Badu went with Tandoh, bringing a recorder, the relevant procedure sheet, and no photographs of the anonymous photocopy. They explained the purpose of the interview and told her she could ask for a break or decline to answer any question.

Nyarko was a small, upright woman with silver hair gathered into a low knot. She listened to the explanation without interruption, then folded her hands on the table.

“I wondered when someone would come back to this,” she said.

“Did you expect an inquiry?” Badu asked.

“I expected that the records would be found one day. Whether anyone would care enough to read them is another matter.”

“Do you remember the confidential review at Haven House?”

“I remember officials coming. I remember the children being told to stay in the courtyard. I remember that the matron was upset.”

“Do you remember a visitor whose name was not entered in the main book?”

Nyarko’s eyes moved toward the window. “There were many visitors over the years. Some signed. Some were brought in by officials. Some were people we were told not to question.”

“Who gave those instructions?”

“I cannot give you a name without being sure. It was not always the same person. Sometimes a district officer would arrive with someone and say there was no need to complete the usual form.”

“Did that happen during the review?”

“I believe so. I remember a man waiting near the office. I did not see him sign the book.”

“Can you describe him?”

“Not reliably. He was dressed formally. That was common among officials and people who wanted to be mistaken for officials.”

“Did you know him?”

“No.”

“Did he enter Room Four?”

Nyarko paused. “I cannot say. I was not in the office the whole time.”

Badu did not press her to fill the gap. Instead, he asked about the monthly summary sheets. Nyarko explained that the receptionist usually wrote the original entries, while Josephine Armah copied them at the end of the month. The matron or administrator was supposed to check the summary, but the practice varied when the home was busy.

“Would a visitor be omitted from the summary even if their name appeared in the original book?” Tandoh asked.

“Yes. A clerk might leave out a delivery person or a visitor who had only come to the gate. But the purpose was to summarise, not to erase. If a visitor was brought directly into the office by a senior official, the receptionist might not record the person at all.”

“Was that allowed?”

“No. It was not the proper procedure. But proper procedure and what happened were not always the same thing.”

“Did you ever see a list of five children connected with the review?” Badu asked.

Nyarko looked at him for a long moment. “I saw many lists. I cannot tell you that I saw the particular list you are looking for.”

“Do you remember a fifth name being removed?”

“No. I remember arguments about records, and I remember being told that the review had been approved. I do not remember seeing someone erase a child’s name.”

“Did you know Daniel Sarpong?”

“I remember a boy who was quiet and observant. I cannot be sure the name I knew him by was Daniel.”

“That distinction is important,” Badu said.

“It is important now. At the time, children were often called by the name written on the card the staff were given. We were not encouraged to question paperwork that came from above us.”

“Who supplied those cards?”

“Sometimes the district office. Sometimes the home’s administrator. I do not know where each one originated.”

Badu asked whether she remembered the initials K. Mensah. Nyarko did not answer immediately.

“I knew an Inspector Mensah,” she said at last. “I cannot say whether he was the person in that entry. There were other men with that surname, and the initials alone are not enough.”

“Did he visit during the review?”

“I remember an inspector coming to the home around that period. I do not remember the date, and I would not swear it was him.”

“Did you see him sign the visitor book?”

“No.”

“Did he ask you to keep anything out of the monthly summary?”

Nyarko shook her head. “No one asked me in those words. I was told that some matters were confidential and should be handled by the administrator. That could mean a legitimate confidential matter. It could also be used to keep people from asking questions. At the time, I did what I was instructed to do.”

Badu allowed a few seconds of silence before asking his final questions. He did not offer the anonymous photocopy as a prompt. He did not ask her to confirm the theory that the visitor had never been recorded. He asked instead whether she knew where the original visitor book might have gone.

“I believe it was moved when the home’s administrative office was reorganised,” Nyarko said. “I heard that old books were sent to the district store. I never saw a transfer receipt.”

“Would Josephine Armah know?”

“She would know who prepared the summaries. Whether she remembers the details after so many years, I cannot say.”

On the journey back, Tandoh reviewed her notes.

“Nyarko gives us a practice that could explain the missing entry,” she said. “An official visitor might have bypassed reception.”

“Yes.”

“And a possible inspector visit.”

“An uncertain recollection of a visit around that period. We cannot convert it into a confirmed entry.”

“You’re going to make me write ‘possibly’ a hundred times.”

“If the evidence supports ‘possibly,’ write it.”

At the station, Badu sent a formal request to interview Josephine Armah. He also asked the archive team to search for the original visitor book and any transfer documents from the district store. The search request was specific: all visitor registers from the relevant period, all monthly summaries, and any record showing the destruction, transfer, or reclassification of those books.

Mabel waited until he had finished before asking about the anonymous photocopy.

“Does Nyarko’s account make it more credible?”

“It makes one method of omission plausible. It does not authenticate the copy.”

“But it gives us a reason to look for an unrecorded visitor.”

“Yes. We now have a documented procedure, a witness who describes exceptions to that procedure, and an entry in a duplicate that is incomplete. Those facts justify further checks. They do not identify the visitor.”

Mabel closed her notebook. “I can work with that.”

“I know.”

Her phone remained silent for the rest of the afternoon. The absence of another message did not reassure her. It did, however, give her time to examine the photocopy’s visible features. She compared the ruling and spacing with a reference image of the monthly duplicate, noting that the black rectangle covered not only the name but part of the line above it. The copy could have been deliberately redacted. It could also have been a poor reproduction from a damaged sheet.

She wrote to the courier company asking them to preserve the dispatch details, then gave Badu the case reference. The sender had used a prepaid service and a collection point. That did not make the sender untraceable, but it meant the trail might end at a place used by many people.

Before leaving the station, Mabel looked once more at the visitor entry: “Mensah, K.” The blank time column made it impossible to place the visitor precisely. The dash in the purpose column might mean no purpose was recorded, or it might simply be the clerk’s way of indicating that the field had been left empty.

It was tempting to imagine the unlisted visitor standing outside Room Four, waiting for the right moment to enter. But the evidence did not yet put anyone there. It placed a partial name on a monthly summary and described a practice that allowed some visitors to bypass the usual procedure.

That was enough to ask the next question.

It was not enough to answer the last one.

Badu added a final note to the case file: “Visitor identity unconfirmed. Original register not located. Anonymous photocopy origin unknown. Obtain Josephine Armah’s account and trace transfer history before drawing conclusions.”

Then he closed the folder. The first part of the inquiry had begun with a box whose number did not match its contents. Now it had a visitor whose name might be real, a register whose omissions might be routine or deliberate, and a copy sent by someone who wanted them to look at the missing line.

The case had not become clearer. It had become more specific.

Mabel arranged a second conversation with Madam Efua Nyarko, this time in a quiet room at a community centre where the former matron felt less exposed than she had at the station. Mabel brought no photocopies to place in front of her. She wanted an account in the woman’s own words before showing her material that might influence her memory.

Madam Nyarko described the routines that governed visitors: ordinary guests signed at the front desk; officials sometimes arrived with letters or escorts; emergencies could interrupt the routine; and staff occasionally wrote details later when the register was unavailable. She could remember the system, but she could not say that any particular exception had occurred on the day in question.

“Did you personally see a man called Mensah?” Mabel asked.

The older woman paused. “I knew people from different offices. I remember men coming with papers. I do not remember that name well enough to identify a face.”

“Would you recognise him if I showed you a photograph?”

“Perhaps I would recognise a face. But that is not the same as remembering him at the home.”

Mabel thanked her and wrote the answer exactly. She did not show her a photograph. A photo array, if needed, would have to be handled through proper investigative procedure, not improvised by a journalist hoping to prompt a recollection. The conversation established how visitors might have been recorded. It did not identify the visitor on the duplicate.

After the interview, Mabel asked whether the home had kept copies of official letters. Madam Nyarko thought some were stored with accounts, but she did not know whether those papers had survived the closure. She gave Mabel the name of a former administrator who might remember where the boxes had gone. Mabel wrote it down and asked permission to mention the referral to Badu.

On her way out, she received a call from an unfamiliar number. The caller said nothing for several seconds, then asked whether she had spoken to the matron. Mabel did not answer the question. She asked who was calling. The line went dead.

She immediately recorded the time, number, and exact sequence of the call, then sent the information to Badu. She did not label it a threat. Silence on a telephone could have many explanations, and the caller had made no explicit demand. But the call showed that someone might be tracking the inquiry closely enough to know whom she had interviewed.

That was a reason to take sensible precautions, not a reason to decide who was responsible.

Badu told her to preserve the call log and avoid meeting unknown sources alone. He also asked her not to confront anyone named in the documents. “We do not know whether the sender is trying to help us, mislead us, or make us afraid,” he said. “The same message can do all three.”

Mabel looked once more at the photocopy of the visitor register. The blank time and dash in the purpose column might indicate a deliberate omission, a hurried entry, or a duplicate made from an incomplete original. The available evidence could not yet distinguish among those explanations. She added the new call to the chronology, separated from the documentary evidence, and left the visitor’s identity unresolved.

A gap in the visitor book

The visitor book was kept in a records cabinet with a damaged hinge. The surviving pages showed names, purposes, and times, but the practice had not been consistent across every shift. Some visitors signed in themselves; others were entered by the person at the desk. The absence of a signature could therefore mean an unrecorded visit, an incomplete entry, or a page that had been separated from the book.

Mabel compared the duplicate with the photocopy sent anonymously. The same blank space appeared in both, but the copies were too poor to establish whether the dash in the purpose column had been written at the same time as the name. She made a note of the differences in contrast and asked for access to the original. The anonymous copy remained a lead, not a substitute for the source.

A former receptionist remembered that official visitors sometimes arrived through the side entrance when the front desk was busy. She did not say that any particular person had done so on the night in question. She remembered a general practice, and Badu made sure her statement preserved that limitation. A routine that made an unrecorded visit possible did not prove that a specific visit occurred.

The team mapped the entrances and sightlines. From the side door, a visitor could reach the administration corridor without passing the front desk, but the route was visible from a caretaker’s window. The layout narrowed the questions they needed to ask: who had been on duty, whether the window had been occupied, and whether any maintenance work affected the door. It did not identify the visitor.

The duplicate visitor register was examined page by page under a desk lamp. Its entries had been copied by hand, and the handwriting changed from

one month to the next. Some lines were neat; others leaned into the binding, as if the clerk had been writing while standing. Tandoh recorded the page numbers before the team compared the entries with the surviving appointment book. A matching name would be useful, Badu said, but a mismatch would not automatically mean fraud. Clerks made mistakes, visitors used abbreviated names, and copies were sometimes prepared days after the event.

One entry listed a visitor only as “K.M.” with no department and no purpose. The time beside it had been overwritten. The ink beneath the alteration was too faint for the team to identify the earlier figure by eye. The examiner photographed it under different lighting and warned them that any enhanced image would need to be compared with the original. Digital contrast could reveal a stroke; it could also create an illusion from paper fibres and shadows.

Mabel searched the public directory for officials whose initials matched, but Badu told her to keep that work separate from the formal evidence schedule. A list of possible people was an investigative lead, not a finding. They would need duty rosters, appointment records, and independent testimony before claiming that a particular person had visited Haven House. Even then, a visit would establish presence, not wrongdoing.

The team sealed the register again after documenting the pages. Tandoh signed the seal record, and another officer checked the number before the parcel went into secure storage. The process felt repetitive, almost ceremonial, but Badu had seen cases weakened by a single unexplained handover. A record could survive for twenty years and still become useless if nobody could show who had handled it during the final week of an investigation.

That evening, Mabel received another message containing only a time written in four digits. It could have been a clock time, a file code, or an unrelated number. She preserved it and sent it through the agreed channel. For once, she did not try to solve it alone. The sender was offering fragments, and fragments became dangerous when she supplied the missing story herself.

The anonymous sender’s purpose remained unknown. The message might have come from someone trying to help, someone trying to frighten them, or someone hoping they would accuse the wrong person. Mabel added one more task to the list: find the duty roster, and preserve the original visitor book if it survived.

After she left, Mabel reviewed the evidence table. The register established that the copied record contained an entry for “Mensah, K.” with missing

details. Nyarko established that the visitor procedure could produce incomplete entries. Neither source established that Inspector K. B. Mensah was the visitor, that he had seen the review file, or that he had altered any record.

Badu asked whether a daily duty roster showed who had been assigned to the desk. Nyarko said the roster might have been kept in the matron’s office or administrative files. She signed her statement and marked the paragraph where her memory became uncertain. No one asked her to guess at the visitor’s identity.

Mabel respected the answer, even though it offered no immediate breakthrough. Nyarko described the side entrance, the desk, and the procedure for recording late entries. She explained that the visitor book could be completed by one person while another physically escorted a guest. The handwriting might belong to the clerk, not the visitor.

Nyarko considered the question. “I cannot say that I did. I remember officials coming and going, but I do not remember a face well enough to attach it to this entry. I will not tell you I recognised someone just because you have shown me a name.”

“Did you see Inspector Mensah enter the building on the date in question?”

“That was the rule. But the person at the desk could be called away. A senior official might be

escorted directly to the office. Sometimes a member of staff wrote the name later from a note. I did not approve of it, but it happened."

"Were all visitors required to sign the book?" he asked.

Madam Efua Nyarko, the former matron, came to the station for a follow-up interview. She had explained that official visitors sometimes used the side entrance, especially when meetings were held in the administration block. This time Badu asked her to describe the practice rather than identify a particular visitor.

"Correct," Badu replied. "And even a handwriting match would not prove why the entry was made. We need the source, the context, and the record's history."

"If the same person made both copies, the marks may look alike," Mabel said. "But that would not prove the original entries were written by the same hand."

The comparison with the appointment book found two entries written with the initials K.M., but neither carried a full name. One referred to a meeting at the district office; the other had no purpose recorded. The dates were close enough to justify checking, not close enough to establish that either entry described the Haven House visit. Badu requested the original appointment book and asked the clerk who maintained it to explain the abbreviations used at the time. The clerk could identify several common codes

but did not recognise this one. The team preserved that answer and continued searching for an independent roster. The initials remained a lead, not a person.

The register was returned to secure storage with its seal number checked aloud by two officers. Tandoh entered the time and signed the custody form. The procedure was routine, but routine was precisely what made the evidence easier to defend later.

The register's custody record was checked again before the team left the archive.

Mabel compared the line with the anonymous photocopy she had received. The spacing was similar, but the image quality was too poor for a reliable comparison. She asked the archivist to note the similarities without describing them as a match. Badu approved the request and had both images logged as separate exhibits.

The line "Mensah, K." appeared between two visitors whose times had been completed. The time field beside Mensah's name was blank. In the purpose column, a short dash had been drawn. No office or department was listed. The copy did not reveal whether the person had arrived and left without signing, whether the name had been added from another source, or whether the entry referred to a different person with the same surname.

The Second Copy

Two days later, the duplicate visitor register arrived in an archival sleeve. Badu checked the seal against the transfer note before the clerk opened it in the presence of the team. Because the original book had disappeared, they treated this later audit copy as a separate source whose copying history had to be established.

PART TWO
THE WITNESS RETURNS

THE WITNESS RETURNS

The first thing Mabel noticed about the photocopy was not the missing name. It was the line beside it.

The anonymous page had been cropped so tightly that the left edge of the visitor entry was missing, but a narrow strip of the margin remained on the right. Someone had written a small figure there, perhaps a five, perhaps a letter S. The mark was faint and partly hidden by the black rectangle covering the final entry. It might have belonged to the original register. It might have been added later. Whoever had sent the page had chosen a copy that preserved just enough to invite a theory and not enough to test one.

Mabel placed the photocopy inside a transparent sleeve and set it beside the image Badu had authorised her to consult. She did not write on either sheet. In her notebook, she recorded the visible details separately: the ruling, the crop, the black rectangle, the faint margin mark, and the four readable entries. Then she wrote in capital letters: DO NOT ASSUME THE TWO COPIES SHARE THE SAME SOURCE.

It was a rule she had learned through experience. A document could resemble another document without being a copy of it. Two records might share a template. A later clerk might reproduce an earlier page. Someone might create a convincing imitation

from details already made public. Resemblance could direct an investigation, but it could not finish one.

Badu called shortly after nine.

“The central archive has sent the first batch of scans,” he said. “There are three versions of the monthly summary. One is the sheet we already have. One is a carbon copy with four entries. The third appears to be a photocopy made much later.”

“Does the third include the fifth entry?”

“It includes a dark patch where the entry should be. The scan is not clear enough to say whether that is a redaction, a stain, or a reproduction fault.”

“And the margin mark?”

“Present on the later photocopy, absent from the carbon copy. But the edges differ, so we cannot conclude it was added later. The carbon copy may simply have been cut differently.”

Mabel looked at the anonymous page. “Then the person who sent this may have copied the later photocopy.”

“Possibly. Or they may have used another version. We need the original page or a reliable record of how each copy was produced.”

“Have you found the original visitor book?”

“Not yet. The district store has located several boxes of registers, but the inventory descriptions are

broad. They are preserving them while the search continues.”

“Can I see the scans?”

“I’ll send the approved set through the secure channel. Please don’t forward them or publish the images.”

“I won’t.”

When the files arrived, Mabel compared the three pages on her laptop. The carbon copy had a faint blue cast and a slight impression from the sheet above it. The later photocopy had a dark band along the bottom and a vertical streak near the right edge. The anonymous page had the same vertical streak, though the image was too grainy to tell whether the streak had been copied from the archive scan or from another source.

She enlarged the margin. The mark could be a five, but its upper curve was incomplete. It could also be a hurried capital S. Beneath it, nearly invisible, were two dots.

Mabel resisted the urge to turn the mark into a code. The human mind preferred a pattern to an empty space. She had seen people build entire accusations from a shape that might have been made by a leaking pen.

She sent Badu a careful note: “The anonymous photocopy appears visually similar to the later

photocopy in the archive scans, including a vertical streak near the right edge. Image quality is insufficient to establish a common source. The margin mark may be a numeral or letter; meaning unknown.”

His reply was brief. “That is the right level of certainty.”

At midday, Tandoh brought Mabel to the station for a supervised review of the scan metadata and the archive’s copying log. The log had survived in a separate administrative file. It showed that the monthly summary had been copied twice during the years after the Haven House review: once when the district office moved buildings, and once when an inquiry clerk requested background material for an unrelated audit.

The first copy had been made by a staff member whose initials matched the name on the transfer list. The second entry had no staff name, only a department stamp and a date. A note beside it read: “Reproduce selected pages; omit personal details not required for audit.”

“Could the black rectangle be from that instruction?” Mabel asked.

“It could,” Tandoh said. “The audit might have required a redacted copy. But we need the audit file to establish what was requested and what was removed.”

“Do we know what the audit concerned?”

“Only the broad subject: administrative handling of children’s records. The full file has been transferred to a different department. Badu has requested it.”

Mabel studied the copying log. “If the audit clerk redacted a name, the black rectangle may be legitimate.”

“Yes.”

“But if the anonymous sender used that version, the page doesn’t prove someone was unlisted in the original register.”

“Correct.”

They traced the dates. The first copy was made during the office move, three years after the review. The second was made nearly a decade later. The anonymous photocopy had been delivered to Mabel two days after the new box was opened. That timing made the sender’s knowledge of the current inquiry plausible, but not certain. The person could have followed public reporting. They could have worked in one of the offices. They could have obtained the page years earlier and chosen to send it only now.

The facts were beginning to form a chain, but several links were still missing.

Badu joined them with a folder from the archive team. “There is another item in the copying log,” he

said. “A handwritten note on the reverse of the later photocopy. It says, ‘Keep the margin intact.’”

Mabel leaned forward. “Who wrote it?”

“We don’t know. The note is on a separate cover sheet, not on the photocopy itself. The clerk who assembled the file has died. There is no signature.”

“Why would someone specify the margin?”

“Could be a routine instruction to preserve the whole page. Could be a request to retain a reference mark. Could be unrelated to this particular entry.”

“Do we have the cover sheet?”

“Yes. It is being preserved for examination.”

They examined the cover sheet under magnification. The instruction was written in blue ink, with a faint pressure impression beneath the words. There was no signature. The handwriting could be compared with known samples only if investigators found a lawful and reliable source. Even then, a similarity would need expert interpretation.

Tandoh looked at the note. “Someone wanted the margin preserved.”

“Someone wrote that instruction,” Badu corrected. “We don’t yet know who, or why.”

Mabel turned to him. “Suppose the margin mark is a five. What would that tell us?”

“Only that someone made a mark resembling a five. We would need context to establish whether it was a page number, a reference, a correction, or something else.”

“And if it is an S?”

“Same problem.”

“What if it is neither?”

“Then we will have spent time investigating an ambiguous mark, which is better than building a case on an assumption.”

She gave a small, tired laugh. “You make uncertainty sound like a full-time occupation.”

“It is.”

The audit file arrived late in the afternoon. It was incomplete, but the surviving pages established that the office had been asked to review how children’s records were transferred between the home, the district office, and the central registry. The audit was administrative, not criminal. It examined missing signatures, inconsistent names, and delays in updating records. Several recommendations had been made, including a requirement that future transfers include a receipt signed by both the sending and receiving officers.

One page listed “unresolved discrepancy in the number of children recorded during the Haven House review.” It did not say there had been five children. It

did not identify any child. The note simply stated that the attendance sheet, the visitor log, and the summary of the review did not agree.

Mabel read the sentence twice.

“This is the first independent document that says the records didn’t match,” she said.

“Yes,” Badu replied. “It supports the existence of a discrepancy. It does not tell us what caused it.”

“Was the discrepancy resolved?”

“The final page says the office was unable to reconcile the figures from the documents available. The recommendation was to locate the original register.”

“Which disappeared.”

“Or was transferred somewhere we haven’t found yet.”

Mabel looked at the report’s date. It had been written several years after the review, before the later photocopy was made. That mattered. The discrepancy had not been invented by the anonymous sender, at least not if the audit report was authentic and correctly dated. But the report did not support the claim that a visitor had been deliberately omitted, nor did it prove that a child’s name had been erased.

Badu added the report to the evidence map. For the first time, he drew a solid line between the original

review records and the documented discrepancy. He left the anonymous photocopy in a separate box.

“Why not connect the copy to the report?” Mabel asked.

“Because we don’t know who made the copy or whether the black rectangle covers the same entry discussed in the report. The report gives us a verified problem. The photocopy may or may not be a reliable part of it.”

The distinction was frustrating, but Mabel understood. A case could be damaged by dismissing a useful clue; it could also be damaged by allowing a clue to dictate the meaning of every document around it.

Before she left, Badu gave her a copy of the audit’s public summary and asked her to review it for any details already reported in the press. If the anonymous sender had relied on public information, that would affect how much weight could be placed on the timing and wording of the message. It would not identify the sender, but it might narrow the possibilities.

At home, Mabel spread her notes across the table. She made a chronology with four columns: date, document, what it established, and what it did not establish. The original review produced conflicting records. The later audit confirmed an unresolved discrepancy. The monthly summary had been copied

more than once. A redaction instruction existed, but its author and purpose were unknown. The anonymous photocopy resembled a later copy, but its source was unverified.

She wrote one final line beneath the table: “The margin is not the message until we know who marked it.”

Her phone rang. The number was unfamiliar, but not the one used for the earlier message.

She answered without giving her name.

A woman’s voice said, “You have the page with the black line.”

Mabel sat very still. “Who is this?”

“Someone who knows that the copy is not the original.”

“Then you understand why I cannot treat it as proof.”

“I didn’t say it was proof.”

“Who are you?”

“I can’t tell you that over the phone.”

“Then arrange to speak through the police.”

“No. They will ask for documents. Documents are why we are here.”

Mabel glanced at the notebook. “If you have information, you can provide it through a lawyer or

an investigator. I won't publish an accusation based on an anonymous call."

"I'm not asking you to publish anything. I'm asking you to look at the margin."

"What does the mark mean?"

"It means someone wanted the copy to survive."

"That is an interpretation. Do you know who wrote it?"

The woman breathed into the receiver, then said, "Look at the back of the audit cover sheet."

Mabel's pulse quickened, but she kept her voice steady. "What is on the back?"

"A number that does not belong to the file."

The call ended.

Mabel did not call back. She recorded the time and the exact words she could remember, distinguishing direct quotation from her own recollection. Then she contacted Badu using the agreed channel. She did not go searching through the files alone, and she did not assume the caller was the person who had sent the photocopy.

Badu's response came after several minutes. "Do not handle the original cover sheet. I'm asking the archive officer to inspect both sides and record the result."

Mabel looked at the photocopy again. A number on the back of the cover sheet might be an archive reference, a page count, a clerk's note, or something entirely ordinary. The caller could be telling the truth, mistaken, or attempting to steer the inquiry toward a false trail.

For now, all Mabel knew was that someone had called to direct her attention to a detail she had not seen.

She closed the notebook and placed it beside the laptop. The inquiry had moved beyond the question of whether a name had been hidden. It now had to establish who made the copies, why the audit failed to reconcile the records, and whether the anonymous sender possessed information that had never been made public.

The margin had become another witness.

Like every witness, it would have to be questioned carefully.

The archive officer's reply arrived the following morning. Badu forwarded it to Mabel with a warning not to treat the discovery as a breakthrough until the physical sheet had been examined. The reverse of the cover sheet carried a handwritten number: 17-B. It was not listed in the audit file's index, and it did not match the archive's current catalogue number.

There was also a shallow rectangular impression near the lower edge, as if a label had once been attached and later removed. The officer had photographed the sheet in place, recorded its dimensions, and sealed it again. No one had written on it during the inspection. The number and the impression were now documented observations, not yet explanations.

Mabel read the report twice. Seventeen-B sounded like a shelf reference, but the archive catalogue used a different format. It might have belonged to an earlier filing system. It might have been a page number in a separate bundle. Or it might have been a private reference created by someone who wanted to find the document again without placing its location in the official index.

She called Badu. ‘Can the number be traced?’

‘The archive team is checking old accession books. We have to be careful not to assume the number was deliberately concealed.’

‘The caller said it did not belong to the file.’

‘The caller may know something. The caller may also want us to think the number is important. We need an independent route to its meaning.’

That answer annoyed her less than it would have a week earlier. She had begun to understand that caution was not the same as disbelief. Badu was not dismissing the clue; he was keeping it from becoming a conclusion before the evidence could support it.

At the archive, a records officer named Mrs. Osei brought out the surviving accession books from the period when the district office had been reorganised. Their covers were worn, and the entries had been made by several hands. Some numbers had been crossed out and replaced. Others referred to bundles that had later been divided between departments. The officer placed each volume on a foam support and turned the pages with a thin paper guide.

The first book produced no match. The second contained a sequence of references beginning with 17, but the suffixes were letters rather than numbers. One entry, dated eleven years after the Haven House review, read: ‘17-B — supplementary papers; transfer pending.’ The destination column was blank. In the remarks column, someone had written ‘retain margin’ in a hand too small to identify from the scan alone.

Mabel felt the quick lift of excitement, then made herself sit back. ‘Does this refer to our cover sheet?’

Mrs. Osei kept her finger beside the entry without touching the ink. ‘It could. The date and wording are suggestive. But this book does not identify the contents

of 17-B, and the reference may have been reused.'

'Can we find the transfer record?' Badu asked.

'We can search. I won't promise it survived.'

The search took most of the morning. A movement ledger listed a bundle under the same reference, but the destination had been entered in abbreviated form. The letters might stand for the regional registry, a review unit, or a temporary holding room. A later clerk had drawn a line through the entry and written 'received' beside it. There was no recipient's signature.

Badu photographed the page according to the archive's procedure and requested a certified copy. He did not permit Mabel to publish the entry. The ledger was an original record whose significance had not yet been established, and the investigation could not risk exposing the archive to unnecessary pressure. Mabel wrote the facts in her notebook: a matching reference existed; its description was vague; a transfer was recorded; receipt was marked without a named recipient.

'It feels like every answer comes with three new questions,' she said as they left the records room.

'That is what happens when a record has passed through several offices,' Badu replied. 'Each office records the part it thinks matters. Years later, we try

to reconstruct the whole journey from the pieces they left behind.’

‘And if someone wanted the journey to be hard to reconstruct?’

‘Then we may find signs of that. But we should not call every gap evidence of a plan. Poor administration can hide the truth as effectively as deliberate interference.’

Outside, the sky had turned a flat grey. Mabel stopped beneath the veranda and reviewed the images on her phone, checking that the reference number was legible and that she had not confused the entry date with the transfer date. She sent the photographs to Badu through the approved channel, then deleted the temporary copies from her gallery as the archive officer had requested.

A message appeared while she was putting the phone away. It came from the same unknown number that had sent the five strokes earlier. This time there was no photograph, only a sentence: ‘17-B was never supposed to come back.’

Mabel did not answer. She saved the message, captured the screen with the time visible, and forwarded it to Badu. The wording could be a warning, a boast, or an attempt to make an ordinary archival reference appear sinister. Yet the sender had

mentioned a number that had not appeared in any public report she knew of.

Badu called within minutes. ‘Do not respond. We’ll preserve the message and ask the service provider what can lawfully be obtained. It still does not tell us who sent it.’

‘They know about the ledger.’

‘Or they have access to the same old records. Or they guessed that the number would matter. We’ll investigate each possibility.’

‘Do you think the sender is the woman who called?’

‘We cannot establish that from the wording. Different people can use the same information, and one person can use different methods. For now, we record them separately.’

That evening Mabel returned to the chronology she had started the day before. She added the accession-book entry and the message, using different symbols for verified records and unverified communications. The ledger established that a bundle called 17-B had existed. It did not establish that the bundle contained the original visitor register, the missing fifth entry, or any document connected to Daniel’s identity. The message established only that an unknown sender

wanted her to believe the reference had been deliberately buried.

Mabel took the cropped photocopy to a print technician who had worked with newspaper archives for years. He examined the black rectangle, the ragged left edge, and the faint mark in the margin. He could enlarge the image, sharpen the contrast, and compare the paper grain with other copies. He could not restore words that had never been captured. “A machine can make the mark easier to see,” he told her. “It cannot tell you who made it or what they meant.”

They tried several settings and saved each result separately, preserving the untouched scan as the master image. On one version the mark looked like a five; on another it resembled an S. A third version made it look like two separate strokes. Mabel felt the old temptation to choose the image that fitted her theory. Instead, she wrote down all three appearances and asked the technician to document the settings used. She wanted another examiner to be able to repeat the process and reach a different conclusion if the evidence supported it.

Back at the office, she compared the mark with numerals in the visible entries. The clerk’s fives usually had a flat top; the disputed mark appeared rounded, though the low resolution made that comparison weak. The handwriting might belong to another person, or the copy might have distorted it.

She recorded both possibilities. The cropped left edge troubled her more than the shape of the mark because it concealed the beginning of the entry, where a code or initial might have appeared.

She prepared a short note for Badu, not an article. It included the original image, the enhanced versions, the technician’s limitations, and her unanswered questions. He thanked her and added the material to the case file. “This is useful because it tells us what we cannot yet say,” he said. Mabel understood that the most responsible discovery of the day was not a number. It was a boundary around the story.

She drew a line beneath the two entries, but did not connect them. Instead, she wrote a question in the margin: Who can independently identify the contents of 17-B? The next step was not to guess. It was to locate a transfer inventory, a receiving clerk, or a later catalogue that described the bundle. If none survived, the investigation would have to say so plainly.

Before bed, she read the audit summary once more. Its language was dry, almost apologetic: figures could not be reconciled; original records should be located; further action was deferred pending recovery of the register. Nothing in it named a child or accused an official. Yet the summary confirmed that the discrepancy had existed long before the anonymous messages began. That was the solid ground beneath the growing fog.

Mabel switched off the lamp, then turned it on again to write one final note. ‘Do not let the sender decide what the evidence means.’ She underlined it once. The unknown person had supplied a clue, perhaps even a genuine one. But the investigation belonged to the facts, not to whoever had learned how to make those facts frightening.

In the morning, Badu would request the transfer inventory and identify every office that had held the 17-B bundle. The archive would preserve the original cover sheet. The phone message would be logged as an investigative lead, not a finding. And until the bundle’s contents could be independently established, the black line on the photocopy would remain what it had always been: an unexplained mark on a document whose history was incomplete.

The audit meeting

The audit office arranged a meeting with two retired clerks who had worked on monthly summaries. Neither was asked to explain the whole case. Badu presented the documents one at a time and asked each clerk to describe the normal process for preparing a summary, checking attendance totals, and correcting errors. The purpose was to learn how the records should have been made before deciding whether the surviving copies showed an irregularity.

One clerk explained that the summary was usually compiled from several sources: the daily attendance sheet, the visitor book, and notes from the duty officer. If a number changed after the summary was typed, the correction should have been initialled or supported by a note. The second clerk remembered that this rule was sometimes followed loosely when staff were under pressure. A procedural weakness was not automatically evidence of fraud, but it created opportunities for an alteration to go unnoticed.

The two clerks disagreed about the placement of a small mark in the margin. One thought it indicated a checked total; the other said it might mark a figure carried forward. Neither could identify the handwriting from the copy. Badu recorded the disagreement rather than selecting the explanation that best fitted his suspicion.

Mabel asked whether a missing cover sheet could be reconstructed from the remaining pages. The clerks said a replacement could be made for administrative convenience, but it should be labelled as a reconstruction and should cite the sources used. A recreated cover without that warning could later be mistaken for an original. The distinction gave the team a new test: any surviving summary should reveal whether its front sheet belonged to the first version or a later assembly.

After the meeting, Badu prepared a written request for the audit office to preserve all versions of the monthly summary, including drafts and carbon copies. He specified that no page should be removed from its folder and that any necessary handling should be logged. The request did not accuse anyone. It established that the records now mattered and that their condition needed to be protected before further comparison.

The archive appointment was scheduled for the following afternoon, and Badu insisted that Mabel attend as an observer rather than an informal assistant. Her reporting skills were useful, but the case needed a clean account of who handled each item. The archive supervisor prepared a table, two pairs of gloves, and a log sheet. Every document would be identified before it was opened, and every image made during the inspection would be numbered.

The first summary had a narrow blue line down the left margin. The carbon copy had no blue line but carried faint impressions from a sheet that had once rested above it. The later photocopy reproduced both marks, though one was darker than the others. None of those details established which version came first. The supervisor explained that a photocopier could deepen a stain and that carbon impressions could survive even after the original top sheet had been discarded.

Mabel asked whether the fifth entry had been removed from the first summary. The supervisor did not answer immediately. He compared the spacing above and below the gap, then measured the ruled lines. There was a slight irregularity, but the paper had shrunk unevenly. The irregularity could support a question, not a conclusion.

“So it may have been cut out?” Mabel asked.

Mabel prepared a comparison sheet showing the mark at its original size, enlarged size, and in each enhancement setting. She included the technician’s notes beneath every image so another examiner could see what had changed. The sheet looked less persuasive than a single dramatic enlargement, but it was honest about the uncertainty. Badu sent a copy to an independent document examiner who had not been told which interpretation the team favoured. The examiner agreed that the mark could not reliably be read from the copy alone. Mabel felt a brief sting of disappointment, then recognised the value of an independent check. If a future image or original page clarified the mark, the comparison would still be useful.

Mabel saved the unaltered scan in a read-only folder and labelled the enhanced images as working copies. She wanted the next examiner to see the original first, without being influenced by the

interpretation that had already gathered around the mark.

The examiner’s uncertainty was included in the report rather than hidden in a footnote.

“It may have been omitted before this copy was made. It may have been on a separate attachment. It may have been removed later. We cannot distinguish those possibilities from this page alone.”

Badu asked for the compilation instructions used that year. The supervisor found a circular describing how monthly summaries were assembled from daily attendance sheets, the visitor register, and duty notes. Corrections were permitted, but the clerk making a correction was expected to initial it and retain the earlier version. The circular did not prove that the procedure had been followed at Haven House; it gave them a standard against which surviving records could be compared.

A second folder held a routine audit checklist. Most boxes had been ticked in blue ink. Beside the line marked “supporting schedules attached,” someone had made a small pencil dash. It was impossible to tell whether the dash meant yes, no, or simply that the item had been reviewed. The checklist was useful because it named the schedule they needed, not because it revealed what the schedule contained.

Mabel wrote the circular number in her notebook and asked the supervisor to certify the copies. He said

he could certify that the copies accurately reproduced the pages in his custody, but he could not certify the truth of the entries themselves. She thanked him. It was a narrow distinction, but one that could matter when the records reached a hearing.

On the journey back, she and Badu compared their notes. They had found a procedure, a missing attachment reference, and a gap that could not yet be explained. They had not found a name. Badu folded the request receipt and placed it in his case file. “A good day,” he said, “is not always a day that gives us an answer. Sometimes it gives us a better question.”

The Retired Compiler

The retired records compiler, Mrs. Akosua Frempong, lived in a modest house near the old district offices. She received Badu and Mabel at a dining table cleared of family photographs and covered with a clean cloth. Before answering their questions, she asked to see the authorisation and wrote down the reference number herself.

“I learned that habit after I retired,” she said. “People would call and ask me to remember official work as if my memory were a register.”

She remembered compiling monthly summaries from attendance sheets and visitor books. When a supporting schedule arrived late, the office sometimes filed it separately and added a reference in the

margin. The reference was supposed to be copied into the summary index, but during busy periods it could be left blank and corrected later.

“Could a schedule be missing from a file even if it had once been there?” Mabel asked.

“Yes. It could be moved to another bundle. It could be filed under the date it was received rather than the date it described. It could also never have arrived. You must not decide which one happened just because you found a blank.”

She asked for the disputed page and studied the pencil mark. She did not recognise the handwriting. The mark could have been a check, a reminder, or the beginning of a reference that was never completed. She said the office used several kinds of pencil, and the mark was too faint to compare reliably with the examples in the surviving manual.

Badu asked whether staff could alter a summary after it had been signed. Mrs. Frempong explained that a correction should preserve the earlier wording, show the reason, and carry the initials of the person making it. In practice, some offices used replacement pages when a summary was retyped. If the old page was not retained, the audit trail could be lost without anyone physically removing a document from a file.

“That sounds like a way to hide a change,” Badu said.

“It could be abused,” she replied. “But it could also be poor administration. The same weakness allows both. You need evidence of who knew what and when.”

She offered to review the office’s old circulars if the archive could provide certified copies. She would not sign a statement saying the missing schedule existed. Instead, she signed a statement describing the procedure as she remembered it and marked every point that depended on memory rather than a document.

On the drive back, Mabel said the interview made the case less simple, not less important. Badu agreed. A weak system could explain how a record disappeared from view, but the investigation still needed to establish whether anyone deliberately exploited that weakness.

The first official response to reference 17-B arrived before nine the following morning. It was not the transfer inventory Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu had requested, but a brief email from the regional registry stating that no bundle could be released until the request had been reviewed by the records manager. The message was courteous, correctly formatted, and almost entirely unhelpful.

Badu read it twice. “They have acknowledged the request without answering it.”

Mabel stood beside his desk with her notebook open. “Maybe the bundle is missing.”

“Then they can say it is missing. Maybe it was transferred. Then they can identify the transfer. What they cannot reasonably do is pretend the reference is too delicate to discuss while refusing to say whether it exists.” He placed the email beside the certified image of the accession book. “We will give them time to

follow procedure. We will not give them permission to make procedure a wall.”

The reference 17-B had appeared in a ledger, but that was only the beginning. An accession number could describe a folder, a box, or a group of papers assembled for an administrative purpose. It could also be copied incorrectly. Until they had the original inventory and a reliable description of its contents, the number could not prove that the missing Haven House records were inside.

Badu had written that caution into the request itself. He had asked for the entry, its surrounding entries, the transfer record, and any index that explained the code. He had also requested that the relevant pages be preserved. He did not ask the registry to confirm his theory. He asked it to show him what it held.

Mabel watched him arrange the documents in date order. “You think someone is delaying us.”

“I think we have been delayed. That is a fact. Who caused it, and why, are questions.” He looked up. “If we turn every obstacle into proof of a conspiracy, we will become careless. The people who altered these records may be counting on us to become careless.”

She disliked the answer because it was sensible. The anonymous sender had been feeding them just enough to make every closed door feel deliberate. The five strokes, the warning about the cover sheet, the

reference number: each clue seemed designed to move them forward while keeping them dependent on a person they could not identify.

“Then we need a route that does not depend on the sender,” she said.

“Exactly. We verify the record from the office that created it, then from the office that received it. Two independent accounts, if we can obtain them.”

At ten, they went to the old district administration building, where a retired registry assistant named Kofi Agyapong had agreed to meet them. He had worked in records administration during the final years before the offices were reorganised. He was not a suspect merely because he had handled paperwork, and Badu made that distinction clear before asking his first question.

Agyapong arrived carrying a slim folder of notes. He was in his late sixties, careful in his movements, and plainly uncomfortable with the attention. He had agreed to speak because the request concerned a system he had once helped maintain, not because he claimed to remember every file that had passed through his hands.

“I cannot identify a box from a number alone,” he said. “There were thousands of entries. Some numbers were carried forward when a department changed its name. Others were cancelled and reused under a new series. The index matters.”

“Would a suffix such as B have had a standard meaning?” Badu asked.

“Not a universal one. In our office it sometimes meant a second bundle, but that depended on the year and the register. You must not assume the same code was used everywhere.”

Mabel wrote that down. She had imagined 17-B as a hidden file with a fixed identity. Agyapong’s answer made it a question again.

Badu showed him the certified image of the accession-book entry. Agyapong adjusted his glasses but did not touch the page. His expression changed when he reached the initials beside the movement notation.

“K. Mensah,” he said. “Or someone wrote K. Mensah.”

“Can you identify the handwriting?”

“Not from this copy. The downstroke is blurred. It could be a capital K, but I would want the original. And initials are not a signature.”

“Did Inspector K. B. Mensah work with this office?”

Agyapong paused. “Several officers used the registry. Inspector Mensah came here on official business at least once, perhaps more. That does not mean he wrote this entry. Nor does it mean the entry refers to Haven House.”

Mabel felt the familiar disappointment of a clue refusing to become an answer. Yet Agyapong had given them a useful boundary. The initials could direct their search, but they could not identify the hand or the person behind it.

Badu asked whether the old office kept specimen signatures or staff duty rosters. Agyapong said staff rosters might survive in personnel files, but specimen signatures were not routinely collected for registry movements. If a person signed for a bundle, the signature would normally appear on a receipt or movement slip. The receipt, if it still existed, would be more useful than a comparison made from unrelated documents.

“And if the receipt has disappeared?” Mabel asked.

“Then you document that it has disappeared. You do not fill the gap with a guess.” Agyapong said it without harshness. “A record can fail you. That does not give you permission to invent the missing part.”

The words followed Mabel out of the building. She had spent years trying to recover the testimony taken from her when she was a child. She knew what it felt like to have other people decide what her memory meant. She had promised herself she would not repeat that wrong by forcing a witness or a document to say more than it could.

On the steps, Badu called the registry and asked for the records manager. He left a formal message

requesting confirmation of the status of the 17-B bundle and preservation of all associated movement slips. He did not mention Agyapong's recollection of Mensah. There was no reason to put an unverified statement into an official request as if it were a fact.

Mabel's phone vibrated. A message from the unknown number had arrived while they were inside. It contained a photograph of a page with a single handwritten line: "The signature was never his." Beneath it, someone had typed: "Ask who held the pen."

For a moment, Mabel could hear only the traffic beyond the compound wall. The sender had anticipated their meeting, or guessed they would seek someone who knew the old registry. The photograph showed no date, no heading, and no visible file number. The paper might have come from any notebook, any office, any period.

Badu held out his hand. "Do not forward it to anyone yet."

She passed him the phone. He photographed the screen with the case reference visible, recorded the time of receipt, and asked her to preserve the original message. Then he studied the image without enlarging its claim into certainty.

"It may be genuine," he said. "It may be staged. The line does not tell us whose signature, which document, or what 'his' means."

“But it sounds as if they know what we are looking for.”

“Or they want us to think they know.” He returned the phone. “We will treat it as a lead. We will not let it become a conclusion.”

Mabel read the line again. The signature was never his. It suggested a deliberate substitution, but it might also refer to an ordinary administrative correction, a copied name, or an unrelated document. The ambiguity felt intentional. The sender was offering certainty in a form that could not be checked.

They took the image to the evidence office and logged it. Badu asked a digital investigator to preserve the message data and determine what could lawfully be established about its transmission. He made no promise that the number would reveal its owner. Phones could be shared, accounts could be misused, and a trace could point to a device without proving who had typed a message.

That afternoon, the regional registry called back. The records manager confirmed that the accession entry existed but said the physical bundle had not yet been located. The office had found an old movement index with a matching number, but the relevant column was partly damaged. A written response would follow after the index was reviewed.

“That is movement,” Mabel said when Badu ended the call.

“It is a response. Movement will be when we have the index and can verify what it says.”

He made a note of the caller’s name, the time, and the exact wording of the response. He asked for the statement in writing and requested that the damaged index be photographed before further handling. If the paper was fragile, they needed to protect it rather than hurry it into pieces.

Back at the office, Mabel began a table with four columns: claim, source, what the source actually established, and what remained unproved. The anonymous message went into the first row. Its source was unknown. It established that someone wanted them to consider a disputed signature. It did not establish that a signature had been forged, that the document belonged to the Haven House file, or that Mensah was involved.

The accession-book entry went into the second row. It established that a bundle bearing reference 17-B had been recorded in the movement system. It did not establish the bundle’s contents or the identity of the person whose initials appeared beside the notation.

The conversation with Agyapong went into the third. He had explained the registry system and remembered that Inspector Mensah had visited the office on official business. He had not identified the

handwriting, the bundle, or the person who made the entry.

Mabel leaned back. “It looks less dramatic written like this.”

“Good,” Badu said. “Evidence should become clearer when you write it down. If it becomes more dramatic, check whether you have added something that was not there.”

Near the end of the day, a messenger delivered a sealed envelope from the regional registry. It contained a photocopy of the damaged movement index and a short covering note. The entry for 17-B was visible, but the destination column had been partly obscured by a fold and a dark mark. A short code remained legible: “R.A.” The receipt column contained a signature that appeared to begin with a long vertical stroke, followed by two indistinct letters.

No full name was visible. No date could be read with confidence from the damaged section. The copy was stamped as a copy, not as an original certification of the missing words.

Badu placed it beside the accession-book image. “We need the index examined by a document specialist. We also need the original, if it survives. The code R.A. could mean several things.”

“Regional archive?” Mabel asked.

“Possibly. Records annex. Receiving authority. A staff member’s initials. We list the possibilities and verify them. We do not choose the one that suits us best.”

Outside, the late-afternoon light had softened against the windows. Mabel looked once more at the anonymous photograph, then at the index. Two sources now pointed toward a disputed signature, but neither supplied the name of the person who had signed, or the document that had been signed for. The mystery had acquired a sharper edge without becoming simpler.

Before leaving, she added one final entry to her table: “The signature was never his.” Source: anonymous sender. Status: unverified assertion. Next action: identify the document and obtain its original or a properly authenticated copy.

She underlined ‘identify the document’, not ‘find the liar’. Someone was trying to make them pursue a person before establishing what had happened. If they followed that order, they could damage an innocent person’s reputation—and give the person who shaped the records more time.

Badu locked the evidence cabinet and handed her the request number for the registry follow-up. “Tomorrow we trace R.A. through the old office directory. Separately, we ask for the original

movement slip. If the two lines meet, we will know more. If they do not, we will keep them apart.”

Mabel slipped the notebook into her bag. The sender had offered a sentence that sounded like a revelation; the official record offered a damaged code and a partial signature. They were not the same thing.

As they stepped into the corridor, Badu’s phone rang. The caller was the records manager. His voice was quieter than before.

At the registry, Mr Agyapong laid out three forms that looked nearly identical. Each contained a box for the receiving officer’s signature, a separate line for the clerk who prepared the bundle, and a space for a witness to the handover. On the disputed form, the initials in the clerk’s field resembled those on other documents attributed to Agyapong, but the signature in the receiving field was larger and slanted in the opposite direction. That difference was noticeable, not conclusive. People signed differently when hurried; copies also changed the appearance of pen strokes.

Badu asked for the original rather than accepting a scanned enlargement as decisive. The registry manager explained that the original was stored in a bound volume and could only be inspected under supervision. Badu agreed to the conditions and asked that the page be photographed before and after examination. No one was to remove it from the binding. The examiner would compare repeated letter

forms, spacing, pen pressure where visible, and the physical sequence of the entries, while making clear that handwriting comparison could not identify a signer with absolute certainty in every case.

Agyapong was interviewed separately from the manager. He said the initials were his but denied signing as the recipient. He remembered preparing bundles for collection, yet could not recall who had collected this one. Badu did not treat the denial as proof of innocence or guilt. The statement was added to the file, along with the fact that Agyapong had access to the relevant office. Access created an opportunity; it did not establish an act.

When the interview ended, Agyapong asked whether a mistake from decades earlier could destroy a person’s life. Badu answered that the investigation could not promise what the public would do, only that the evidence had to be assessed fairly. On the drive back, he told Mabel the signature question had become more precise but not yet more settled. They now had a disputed role, a denial, and a document whose fields might have been misunderstood or misused. The next step was to find a record independent of the form itself.

“Superintendent, we have found a second reference to 17-B,” he said. “It is not in the movement index. It appears in a separate register, under a different date.”

Badu stopped walking. “What does the register say?”

“I would rather not interpret it over the phone. There is a name beside the entry, but I cannot confirm that it is the person who received the bundle.”

“Please preserve the page and send us the location in writing. We will arrange to inspect it through the proper process.”

When he ended the call, Mabel saw that he had not written the name down. “You didn’t ask who it was.”

“I did not want a name delivered without its context. We will read the entry ourselves.”

They left the building with no culprit, no confession, and no complete file. But the investigation had reached a point where the gaps were beginning to have locations, dates, and procedures attached to them. That was not the answer. It was a way to keep searching without letting the unknown person dictate what the answer had to be.

Independent examination

The document examiner did not begin by naming a writer. She began by explaining what the available material could and could not support. The image of the signature was a photocopy of a photocopy, with compression and blur that concealed fine line quality.

It could be compared visually with known examples only in a limited way. Any conclusion about authorship would need original documents or better-quality reproductions and a clear account of where each sample came from.

Badu asked whether the long vertical stroke in the receiving column was distinctive. The examiner said it was common enough to be unhelpful by itself. The final letters might resemble a name, but resemblance was not identification. She recommended that they obtain the original movement slip, document its custody, and compare it with authenticated signatures made around the same period, not with a signature selected merely because it supported a theory.

Mabel watched the examiner mark the uncertain areas on a working copy. The careful process was slower than the anonymous sender's confident messages, but it offered a route that could survive scrutiny. She asked whether the phrase 'the signature was never his' had any evidential value. The examiner said it was a claim, not a finding. Without knowing the document, the alleged signer, and the source of the message, it could not be tested.

The report ended with a list of further material required. It did not identify Mensah, Emmanuel Badu, or any other person as the writer. Badu added the report to the case file and asked that it be shared only with people authorised to handle the investigation.

They would not let a preliminary opinion circulate as a definitive accusation.

Outside the laboratory, Mabel admitted that part of her had wanted the examiner to recognise the signature immediately. A name would have given the mystery a face. Badu reminded her that a false certainty could hurt someone who had no part in the events and distract them from the person who had deliberately kept the records incomplete. She folded the report into her notebook, accepting that the next step was not a confrontation but a better source document.

The registry manager arranged a supervised inspection two days later. The original movement index was brought out in a grey folder, and the manager recorded the time it left the cabinet. Badu asked that no one turn directly to the relevant page until the folder's condition had been photographed. A torn corner, a stain, or a fresh crease could be significant later, but only if its state before inspection was documented.

The entry for 17-B appeared between two routine transfers. The preceding entry concerned education-office circulars; the following one concerned archived payroll schedules. The destination code beside 17-B was faint. A small mark in the receiving column looked like a signature, but the ink had spread into the paper fibres. The manager said the page had been

stored in that condition for years, though he could not say when the damage occurred.

Badu asked whether the index had been rebound. The manager believed it had, during an office move, but the repair register was incomplete. A binding change could explain why the page edge was uneven. It could not explain the missing destination text. The team recorded both possibilities and requested the rebinding record rather than choosing the explanation that best fitted their suspicions.

Mabel watched the document examiner compare the entry with several adjacent signatures. The examiner cautioned that a person's handwriting varies with speed, surface, pen, and physical condition. A resemblance in two letters was not enough to identify a writer. The examiner could later compare a genuine signature from the same period, but even then the result might be inconclusive.

A second document surfaced with the same receiving-office code but a different signature. Its date was unrelated to Haven House, which made it useful as a comparison without making it proof of the disputed handover. The examiner cautioned that one signature could not define a person’s entire writing style, particularly where the available samples were photocopies. Badu asked the registry to locate original forms from several dates and to identify who had authorised access to the receiving desk. Agyapong’s

denial remained in the file, alongside the evidence that he had prepared the bundle. The inquiry now had a method for testing the disputed role, but it still lacked a reliable identification of the person who signed as recipient.

Agyapong’s account was sent to him for confirmation of the factual details, not for approval of the investigators’ conclusions. He corrected one date and left the disputed signature unanswered. Both the correction and the unanswered question were preserved.

The signature question remained open pending comparison with reliable original samples.

“Could somebody have copied a signature?” Mabel asked.

“Yes. Could somebody have written their own name in a way that resembles another person's? Also possible. Could the marks be unrelated to a signature altogether? Yes. That is why I need the original and known comparison samples.”

The examiner photographed the page under ordinary and angled light. The angled image made a shallow indentation visible near the receiving column, but it did not reveal a complete name. Badu asked for the image to be preserved with the examiner's notes and for the report to state explicitly what the technique could not determine.

Outside the registry, Mabel admitted she had hoped the signature would resolve the question of Mensah's involvement. Badu told her that a signature was only one link in a chain. Even if a writer were identified, the team would still need to establish what the person knew, what the transfer contained, and whether the transfer had any connection to the missing Haven House schedule.

“It feels as if every answer opens three more doors,” she said.

“Then we write down all three doors,” he replied. “We do not pretend one is already open.”

That afternoon, Badu asked the registry to arrange a supervised comparison of the surviving signature samples. He did not send a list of names marked suspect. Instead, he requested documents whose purpose and date were independently known: routine receipt forms, staff attendance sheets, and two acknowledged copies of circulars. That distinction mattered. A comparison made only against documents already under suspicion could produce a circle of assumptions rather than a reliable answer.

The registry’s conference room smelled of toner and warm dust. A clerk named Agyapong placed the certified copies on the table and read the exhibit numbers aloud while another officer checked them against the schedule. Badu watched the process without touching the papers. Mabel sat at the far end,

recording which documents had been included and which were unavailable. No one was permitted to describe a signature as genuine merely because it looked familiar.

The examiner began with the simplest question: were the marks sufficiently clear to compare? Some were not. One receipt had been copied at an angle; another had a crease running through the final letters. The examiner separated those from the clearer samples and explained that a poor image could exaggerate differences or conceal them. He could describe visible similarities, but he would not transform an uncertain comparison into a declaration about the writer’s identity.

Agyapong produced a further sheet from a locked drawer. It was an internal correction form, completed on the same day as one of the disputed transfers. The form carried two sets of initials and a blank space where the recipient’s signature should have appeared. The entry had been accepted despite the blank. A note in the margin said that the recipient had been identified verbally by a senior officer. The note did not say who had heard the identification, and the officer’s name was absent.

“That is a weakness in the procedure,” Mabel said.

“It is,” the examiner replied. “But a weak procedure does not identify the person who exploited

it. It tells us where an error could pass through unchecked.”

Badu asked the clerk to locate the instruction that permitted verbal identification. The clerk searched the current manual, then the superseded manual, and finally a bundle of circulars awaiting classification. None authorised it. That alone did not prove the instruction had never existed; old office practice was not always recorded properly. But the missing authority became a finding in its own right. They entered it into the schedule as an unresolved procedural gap.

Before they left, Agyapong asked whether the investigation would accuse the clerk whose initials appeared beside the correction. Badu answered carefully. “Not on the strength of initials alone. We need to know what the initials meant, whether the clerk was present, and whether the form was completed at the time or later. The record must be tested against the person’s account and the other evidence.”

Outside, Mabel wrote down the exchange. The wrong signature might not be a single forged mark. It might be the result of a system that had allowed one person’s assurance to stand in for another person’s acknowledgement. That possibility was less dramatic than a secret hand moving through the archive, but it could explain how a false entry survived without

every person who handled the file knowing it was false.

Badu requested interviews with the clerk, the supervising officer, and the person who had maintained the transfer book. Each interview would be recorded separately. He also asked for the original form to remain sealed until the examiner had finished documenting it. The next step was not to decide who had lied. It was to establish who had been in a position to know the truth, and what each person had actually done.

Mabel did not sleep well after the call about the second reference. She kept seeing the damaged index and the anonymous sentence side by side: The signature was never his. The wording had the confidence of a witness, but the sender had offered no witness statement, no date, and no document. It was a sentence designed to settle an argument before anyone knew what the argument was.

At dawn she made tea and spread her notes across the kitchen table. She separated what she had personally seen from what others had told her. The distinction had once been made for her, by adults who reduced a child's account to the details that suited their report. She would not let that happen to her now, even if the person doing it was herself.

Her own memory of Haven House came in fragments. The smell of damp paper in an office. A chair that was too high for her feet to reach the floor. A man standing with his back to the window. A file being lifted from a desk. Two adults speaking in low

voices, one insisting that the entry had to be corrected and another asking who had authorised the correction. She remembered being told to wait outside. She remembered that the corridor clock was loud. She did not remember seeing a signature clearly.

For years she had treated the memory as one continuous scene. Now, writing it down carefully, she realised there were gaps between the images. She could not say whether the man by the window was the same person who carried the file. She could not say whether the argument concerned Daniel, the five children, or some other record. She could not claim that the document in her memory was the one now labelled 17-B.

When Badu arrived at the office, she showed him the new notes. He read them without interrupting. “This is more useful than a confident story,” he said. “It tells us where your memory is strong and where we need independent support.”

“I hate that the gaps matter so much,” she said. “People used them to dismiss me.”

“A gap is not proof that you are wrong. It is a limit on what anyone can fairly ask your memory to establish.” He returned the pages. “The people who dismissed you were responsible for listening properly. You are responsible only for telling us honestly what you remember.”

They arranged a formal interview with an independent interviewer trained to take statements from witnesses who had been children at the time of the event. Mabel agreed, but insisted that the record preserve her uncertainty. She did not want anyone smoothing her account into a more dramatic version because it made the investigation easier to explain.

The interviewer began with ordinary questions: where Mabel had been living, how often she visited Haven House, who usually accompanied her, and whether she had spoken to anyone about the event before. The questions seemed far removed from the missing file, but they established the setting in which her memory had formed. She was allowed to pause. When she could not remember, she said so.

She described the office, the chair, the window, and the file. She explained that she had heard the phrase “the fifth line,” though she could not be certain whether it had been spoken during the argument or later in the corridor. She did not identify the speakers. She did not guess at their motives. The interviewer recorded each uncertainty instead of treating it as a weakness.

After the interview, Mabel felt drained rather than relieved. A truthful statement did not automatically become a useful statement. It could be checked against records, challenged by lawyers, or found too uncertain to support a particular conclusion. But it could no

longer be altered without someone having to explain why.

Badu met her in the waiting area. “Your account is now preserved in a form that can be examined. We will compare it with the dates and records, not use it as a substitute for them.”

“And if it proves nothing?”

“Then it proves nothing about the point we hoped it would prove. It may still tell us what to ask next.”

They returned to the office and examined the photograph of the second register. The records manager had sent it through the approved channel, along with a note warning that the original page was brittle and could not be handled repeatedly. The entry appeared under a different date from the accession-book notation. The name beside it was partly obscured by a stamp, but the surviving letters could have formed several names. The code R.A. appeared again, this time in a column headed “receiving office.”

Mabel circled the repeated code. “That makes regional archive more likely.”

“More likely, not certain,” Badu replied. “We can ask the registry what R.A. meant in that particular series. We should also ask for the office directory from that year.”

The registry manager confirmed in writing that R.A. had been used for the Regional Archive in some

records, but the code was not exclusive across all departments. The answer narrowed the possibilities without closing them. The bundle might have travelled there; it might have been recorded against a destination that later changed its name; or the same initials might have meant something else in the second register.

Mabel checked the dates against the known timeline from Haven House. The second entry fell within a period when the home was being reviewed by a government office. It was close enough to matter, but not close enough to prove a connection. She wrote the date on a separate card and placed it on the timeline, leaving space around it for records they had not yet found.

That afternoon, a message arrived from an old colleague who had worked with Mabel on a story about public records. The colleague had heard that Mabel was revisiting the Haven House case and wanted to know whether she had found the fifth child. Mabel did not reply immediately. She wondered how the colleague had heard, and whether the unknown sender had been speaking to other people.

Badu advised her to record the contact and avoid sharing investigative details. “We do not know who is passing information around. It could be someone concerned, someone curious, or someone trying to steer you. Keep your response ordinary.”

Mabel returned to the statement she had given as a child and read it beside the adult account she had written years later. The older document used short sentences and repeated the interviewer's wording. The later account contained more detail, but some of that detail came from memories she had discussed with relatives. She drew a line between what she remembered without prompting and what she had learned from other people. The exercise was painful, not because it erased her experience, but because it revealed how easily different sources could become one story in her mind.

She asked the newspaper's legal adviser how to describe the statement publicly without exposing the names of other children. The adviser warned her that a suppressed statement could be relevant to the inquiry and still contain information that should not be published. Mabel had spent years resenting the adults who controlled her account. She did not want to repeat their mistake by deciding that her own urgency gave her the right to reveal someone else's private history.

At the station, Badu arranged for the old statement to be reviewed by an officer who had not interviewed her previously. The purpose was to identify the questions she had been asked and whether the written account preserved her own words. It was not an attempt to make her repeat the story until it matched the current theory. Mabel insisted that she be allowed

to correct an error without being accused of changing her story. Badu agreed, provided every correction was dated and the original wording remained visible.

When she left, she felt neither vindicated nor defeated. Her statement had been treated as evidence that needed context, not as a magic key. She wrote a new paragraph in her notebook: I remember a file being carried out of Room Four. I do not know what was inside it, who authorised its removal, or whether the file I saw was the one now missing. That sentence was less dramatic than the account she had once wanted to publish. It was also more difficult for anyone to discredit honestly.

Mabel wrote back that she was checking historical records and could not discuss an active inquiry. The reply was brief. The colleague answered with a thumbs-up and no further questions. Nothing in the exchange proved a connection to the anonymous sender, but Mabel added it to her contact log.

Near closing time, the independent interviewer sent a clarification request about the phrase “the fifth line.” Mabel considered it carefully. She remembered the phrase, but not who had said it or what document it referred to. She answered exactly that. She would not turn a remembered phrase into a confirmed label just because the investigation had acquired a fifth-child question.

Badu approved the clarification. “That protects the statement from being made to carry more than it can carry.”

Mabel looked at the timeline on the wall. One line represented Daniel’s changing names. Another showed the transfers between offices. A third marked her own childhood memory. The lines approached one another, but they did not yet meet. The danger was to draw the final connection with a pen before the evidence did.

Before she left, she received one more message from the unknown number. It contained no photograph this time, only a question: “If you remember the room, why don’t you remember the face?”

Mabel’s first reaction was anger. Then she noticed what the message assumed: that a memory of a room required a memory of a face, and that any failure to remember must mean concealment. The sender was trying to make uncertainty feel like guilt.

She showed the message to Badu and logged it. He asked the digital investigator to add it to the existing record, then told Mabel not to answer. “The sender wants you to defend your memory on their terms. You have already done the more difficult thing: you have described it honestly.”

That evening, Mabel wrote one sentence at the top of a fresh page: I remember what I remember; I will

not manufacture the rest. It was not a clue, and it did not solve the case. It was a boundary she could keep, even when someone else wanted her to cross it.

Mabel returned to the interview room the next morning with a fresh notebook and a decision she had made on the walk from the car park. She would not try to make her memory sound stronger than it was. For years she had been asked to tell the story as if it were a straight road: she entered the corridor, saw a person carrying a file, heard an argument, and later learned that the record had changed. But memory did not arrive in a straight line. It came in fragments, and the spaces between them were real.

Badu had arranged for the interview to be recorded and for an independent officer to sit in. Mabel appreciated the formality. It meant that no one could later claim she had been coached into a particular answer. She began with what she knew directly: her age at the time, why she had been at Haven House, where she remembered standing, and the fact that she had not been authorised to enter Room Four.

“Tell us what you saw, not what you think it meant,” Badu reminded her. “If you are uncertain, say so. If you remember a sound but not the words, say that too.”

She described the corridor as narrow and poorly lit. She remembered a door that had not been fully closed and a strip of light across the floor. She recalled a man’s sleeve, dark fabric, and the pale edge of a folder held against his side. She could not honestly describe his face. At the time she had been frightened of being discovered outside the area where children were meant to wait. She had looked away when footsteps approached.

The interviewer asked whether she recognised the man as Inspector Mensah. Mabel shook her head. “I cannot identify him. I knew the name later, after adults began asking questions. The person I saw may have been him, but I would be lying if I said I recognised his face.”

Badu let the silence remain. He knew that a witness sometimes felt pressure to reward a careful question with a useful answer. He wanted Mabel to understand that uncertainty was not a failure. A limited statement that survived scrutiny was worth more than a confident statement that fell apart under cross-examination.

She then described the argument. She remembered one voice saying that a name should not have been entered twice. Another voice answered that the first entry had already been sent away. She could not tell whether the speakers were discussing a child, a file, or a decision made in an office. She remembered

the phrase because it had sounded like a disagreement about something already done, not something still being considered.

“Could the words have been different?” the interviewer asked.

“Yes. I remember the sense of them more clearly than every word. I have repeated them to myself for years, and that can change the way a memory feels. I can tell you the words I remember now, but I cannot promise they are a perfect recording.”

After the interview, Badu asked her to read the typed statement carefully before signing it. Mabel found two places where the wording had become more definite than she had been. One sentence said she had seen a man remove a file from Room Four. She crossed it out and wrote that she had seen a person carrying a folder near the door. Another said she heard an order to alter a child’s record. She amended it to say that she remembered an argument about a name being entered twice and an earlier entry being sent away.

The officer watching the corrections looked surprised. “You are making your statement less specific.”

“I am making it accurate,” Mabel replied. “If someone wants to challenge me, they should challenge what I actually remember.”

Mabel asked the newspaper to preserve the original copy of her childhood statement and the envelope in which it had been stored. The archive clerk logged the transfer and placed both in separate sleeves. She then wrote a brief account of how she had encountered the statement as an adult, including which relatives had discussed it with her. The account did not discredit her memory; it allowed investigators to understand the route by which details might have been reinforced or changed. Badu thanked her for volunteering the information and reminded her that a witness could be honest and mistaken at the same time. Mabel carried that sentence with her through the rest of the week.

Mabel closed the notebook only after she had dated the latest entry. She could not recover the child she had been or make the adults speak honestly now, but she could prevent her own account from becoming more certain each time it was repeated.

Her statement would be assessed alongside the circumstances in which it had first been recorded.

Badu did not praise her in front of the others. He simply ensured the corrections were initialled and the original draft retained. Later, when they were alone, he told her the changes might make the statement less dramatic but more useful. A lawyer could test the limits of her recollection without finding that she had exaggerated it.

That afternoon, Mabel compared the statement with the copy of the visitor register. She did not search for a name that would settle everything. Instead, she marked the details that could be checked independently: the likely month, the corridor's layout, the position of the waiting area, and the procedure for signing in visitors. She asked the former matron whether children had ever been allowed to wait near Room Four. The answer was no, not as a regular practice, but exceptions were sometimes made when offices were crowded.

An exception could explain why a child had been in the corridor. It could not establish why she had been there that day. Mabel added the answer to her notes without turning it into proof of a cover-up.

At dusk, an old memory surfaced while she was sorting her papers: a woman's hand resting on the top of a metal filing cabinet, fingers tapping twice as if counting. Mabel could not remember the woman's face or the words spoken. She wrote the image down, then drew a line beneath it and labelled it 'unverified memory—do not connect to a person yet.' The discipline felt almost cruel, but she knew how easily an image could borrow a face from a photograph seen years later.

A message arrived from Badu asking whether she had made any changes to her statement after leaving the interview room. She replied that she had not. He

explained that the evidence officer had sealed the signed copy and recorded every amendment. The question was routine, but it reminded her that the case was beginning to generate a trail of its own. If someone later tried to say that her testimony had been rewritten, the record would show how it had been handled.

Before going home, she read her statement one final time. It did not identify the person with the folder. It did not prove that a record had been forged. It did not establish who had sent the anonymous messages. It preserved something narrower and more important: what a child had noticed, what an adult had failed to investigate properly, and how the memory could now be tested against surviving records.

Mabel asked the newspaper’s archive assistant to retrieve every surviving item connected with her first interview, not merely the published story. The request sounded simple until they began listing what might count as an item: the reporter’s notebook, the editor’s margin comments, the carbon copy of the statement, the appointment diary, the old telephone log, and the envelope in which the statement had supposedly been returned. Some records had been destroyed under the paper’s retention policy. Others had been moved during a change of ownership. The assistant warned her that a missing item would not, by itself, establish

deliberate removal. Mabel agreed. She wanted a record of absence as carefully as a record of discovery.

They worked through the surviving index together. One entry had been filed under “Haven Home,” another under “Haven House,” and a third under the name of the district officer who had attended the interview. A search limited to one spelling would have missed two of them. Mabel wrote down each catalogue term and asked the assistant to preserve screenshots of the results, including the empty searches. When a thin folder finally appeared, its contents were ordinary: a travel claim, a note about a delayed appointment, and a page of shorthand no one could confidently read. Yet the folder established that the interview had taken place on a day when the paper’s published chronology suggested Mabel had not been present.

She did not treat the discrepancy as proof that the paper had lied. A reporter could have entered the wrong date; a clerk could have copied an appointment into the wrong week; a later editor could have reconstructed a sequence from incomplete notes. Mabel prepared a table with three columns—what the document said, what it might mean, and what would test that meaning. She sent Badu a copy and kept the original in the newsroom archive. The exercise made her uneasy because it exposed how much of her own memory had been organised around the story she had repeated to herself. She could remember the room, the

heat, and the adult voices, but she could not honestly place every event on a calendar.

That afternoon, she spoke to a retired copy editor who remembered the old filing system. He did not remember the child’s statement, but he recalled that sensitive interviews were sometimes logged under the supervising editor rather than the subject. He gave her two names and cautioned that either person might have handled routine paperwork without ever reading the contents. Mabel thanked him and did not publish the names. In her notes she wrote that a lead was not an allegation, and that the next contact should be a request for records rather than a question framed to suggest guilt.

Mabel closed the notebook. For years, she had believed that being heard meant persuading someone to accept her whole story. Now she understood that being heard also meant having the right to say, ‘I do not know.’

Mabel returned to the newspaper office after lunch and asked the librarian to bring out the old bound issues from the month the Haven House story had first been quietly withdrawn. The volumes were heavy and their paper had browned at the edges. She worked through them one by one, not searching for a headline that announced the truth but for small notices that might show when the story had changed. A correction,

a missing paragraph, even a changed caption could help establish the sequence of publication.

The first article described a routine inspection of the home. A later version referred to an administrative review, but no source was named. In the final printed copy, a sentence about the children’s records had disappeared. The newspaper archive could not tell her who had ordered the change. The production ledger listed a late alteration, but the initials beside it belonged to a copy editor who had since died. Mabel photographed the relevant pages under the librarian’s supervision and noted the catalogue number for each volume.

She called the retired editor whose name appeared on the old masthead. He remembered the article only vaguely. He had handled dozens of local stories that year, he said, and the office had been under pressure to reduce legal risk. He did not recall being told to remove a child’s name. He did remember receiving a telephone call from a man who insisted that a confidential review was being misrepresented. The caller had not identified himself, and the editor had not written down the number.

“Can you say it was someone from the registry?” Mabel asked.

“No,” he said. “I can say he spoke as though he expected to be obeyed. That is not the same thing.”

Mabel thanked him and ended the call without pressing him to guess. She had once mistaken confidence for certainty because the adults around her spoke in complete sentences. Now she recognised how easily a memory acquired details when a listener supplied them. She wrote the editor’s account in quotation marks only where she had his exact words, and separated his recollection from her interpretation.

Later, she played the recording for Badu. He asked whether the editor had consented to the recording and whether the newspaper had a policy governing its use. When she explained that she had obtained permission at the start of the call, he nodded. He did not ask her to hand over her notebook. Instead, he suggested that the editor be invited to provide a signed statement, with the limits of his memory plainly stated.

“You’re not going to get a name from him,” Mabel said.

“Perhaps not,” Badu answered. “But we may get a date range, a description of the pressure, and evidence that the article changed. Those are different facts. If we keep them separate, another witness may be able to confirm one of them.”

That evening, Mabel drafted a timeline of the article’s versions. She marked the gap between the first draft and the printed copy in red, then added a note: the missing sentence proved that the published text had changed, not why it had changed. The

distinction made the timeline less satisfying. It also made it honest. She sent the archive references to Badu and kept the original photographs untouched in a secured folder.

For the first time, the line she had once tried to force into a child's statement seemed to have a different purpose. It was not a place where she had to supply the answer. It was a boundary: on one side stood what she remembered and could verify; on the other stood what she suspected but could not yet prove. She could cross that boundary only when new evidence gave her a reason.

The Second Interview

Mabel returned to the newsroom archive with her editor, Adwoa, and asked to compare the first statement she had given years earlier with the later summary. She wanted the comparison done in front of a witness who had not helped prepare either document. Adwoa chose a legal correspondent from another desk and instructed him to record the process without offering interpretations.

The original statement described a person entering the administration corridor carrying a thin folder. The later summary said Mabel had seen a named official remove a file from Room Four. The difference was not a minor wording choice. The summary converted a

description into an identification and a corridor into a specific room.

“I didn’t say that,” Mabel said, keeping her voice even. “I said I saw someone with a folder. I could not see the label.”

The correspondent asked whether she was certain the original statement was hers. Mabel identified her signature and the date, then pointed out a correction in the margin that she remembered making. She did not claim to remember every sentence. The paper itself was the stronger source for the wording.

Adwoa asked why the summary had changed. Mabel did not speculate. The document had no author’s name, no approval mark, and no attached instruction. They logged those absences and requested the production file from the newspaper’s former storage contractor.

After the comparison, Mabel sat alone in the conference room for several minutes. She had spent years believing that the old statement had failed because she had been too young to explain what she saw. Now she had to face a different possibility: that other people had made her account sound more certain than it was.

Badu arrived later to collect a certified copy. He asked whether she wanted the discrepancy included in the public timeline. Mabel said yes, but with the

exact wording of both documents and a note that the source of the alteration remained unknown.

“People will say you are weakening your own evidence,” he warned.

“Then they can read the two versions,” she replied. “I would rather have them doubt the right thing than believe the wrong thing.”

Badu entered her answer in the interview record. The discrepancy did not identify the person in the corridor. It did establish that a later document had described Mabel’s memory more confidently than her original statement. That was a lead in its own right, and it had to be followed without assuming who had made the change.

The office directory arrived two days later, scanned in sections because the binding could not be opened flat. Badu assigned a records clerk to log each page as it was received and compare the names with the staff rosters already obtained. They were looking for the person responsible for the receiving-office code, but they knew the directory could only establish who worked where, not who handled a particular bundle.

The name K. B. Mensah appeared in the directory under field inspections, not registry administration. That was consistent with his known position as an inspector who sometimes dealt with children’s homes and institutional complaints. It did not place him at the archive on the date of the disputed movement. The roster for that month was incomplete, and the surviving pages listed assignments by district rather than by building.

“He had a reason to visit Haven House,” Mabel said. “And he had a reason to visit a registry.”

“Many officials had both,” Badu replied. “The question is whether he visited on the date that matters, and whether the record connects him to this bundle.”

They requested the inspection diary and the duty log. The office responded that the diary was held in a separate collection and would need a second search. Badu sent the request with the exact date range, explaining that a narrow search was less likely to disturb unrelated records. He also asked the archive to preserve the relevant pages while the request was processed.

While they waited, Mabel followed another lead: a reference in an old staff newsletter to a clerk known informally as “the man who kept lists.” The phrase had appeared in a short tribute to a retired records officer, Mr. Samuel Kwarteng, who had developed a system for tracking files that passed between departments. The tribute praised his neat handwriting and his habit of recording the name of every person who collected a folder.

Kwarteng had died several years earlier, but his daughter, Abena, agreed to meet them. She brought a small notebook that had belonged to him. It was not an official register and could not be treated as one. She had kept it because it contained household reminders,

work anecdotes, and names of people her father intended to call. She was clear that he had never told her it was a secret archive.

“He wrote everything down,” Abena said. “If a neighbour borrowed a ladder, he wrote it down. If he gave someone a document to take to another office, he wrote that down too. He believed that memory caused arguments.”

Badu explained that they were not asking her to surrender family property or to identify a suspect. They wanted to know whether her father had kept informal work notes and whether she was comfortable allowing a limited, supervised review of any relevant pages. Abena agreed, provided the notebook was handled carefully and returned the same day.

The notebook contained grocery lists, telephone numbers, reminders about pension paperwork, and brief notes from his final years at work. Most entries were mundane. A few referred to file movements using codes that resembled those in the official records, but the dates were inconsistent and the abbreviations were personal. Badu photographed the pages with Abena’s permission and recorded the limits of the material in the evidence log.

On one page, beneath a list of office supplies, Kwarteng had written: “17-B — check receiving copy; signature does not match original.” There was no full

date, only a month and a year that appeared to fit the broader period. Beside the note were the initials “S.K.” and a small mark that might have been a tick or a dash.

Mabel stared at the line. “That is the signature again.”

“It is a note that someone thought a signature did not match,” Badu said. “We need to establish what document he meant and whether the notebook entry is contemporaneous.”

Abena said her father sometimes wrote reminders to himself after a difficult day. He could have copied the note from an official file, or he could have been recording something he had heard. She did not know what 17-B meant. She had never seen the notebook entry before this meeting.

The investigators asked whether Kwarteng had kept a calendar or a diary from the same period. Abena searched a box of papers she had brought but found only a pocket calendar with several pages missing. The surviving pages showed work appointments and ordinary errands. One date in the relevant month had the initials “K.M.” beside a note reading “archive—return copy.” The entry was too brief to identify a person or explain what copy was being returned.

Badu asked the document examiner to compare the writing in the notebook with known samples of

Kwarteng's handwriting from verified office notes. The examiner cautioned that a short phrase could support only a limited comparison, particularly where the paper and ink had aged. The initial assessment found similarities but did not claim certainty. A fuller report would follow if the original notebook could be examined under suitable conditions.

Mabel understood how easy it would be to tell the story as if Kwarteng had uncovered a forged signature and then recorded the identity of the person responsible. But the notebook did not say that. It said only that a signature did not match an original. The missing noun mattered: signature on what? Original of what? Who had noticed it?

They returned to Abena's house to ask about the calendar entry. She remembered that her father sometimes carried copies between offices when a file had been returned for correction. The phrase "return copy" could have referred to a duplicate he was expected to bring back, not necessarily a document he had delivered. She could not identify K.M. with confidence. Her father had known several people with those initials.

"I wish I could give you something more," she said. "He was careful, but careful people still leave incomplete notes."

"Incomplete notes can still help," Badu told her. "We just have to keep their limits attached."

Abena gave written permission for the notebook pages to be copied for the inquiry, but retained the original. Badu documented the arrangement and ensured that the copy was marked as a reproduction from a privately held notebook, not an official record. He knew that if the case reached court, the defence would need to examine how the note had been found and what could be proved about its origin.

On the drive back, Mabel asked whether Kwarteng might have been the unknown sender. His habit of keeping lists, the note about 17-B, and the reference to a signature all seemed to fit. But he had died before the recent messages began, and nothing showed that anyone had inherited his knowledge. The sender could have found the notebook, or could have learned the same information from another source.

“We do not know whether the sender is one person,” Badu said. “A phone can pass from hand to hand. A message can be copied. Even if we identify the first sender, we still have to establish what they know and how they know it.”

At the office, the evidence clerk logged the notebook copy and cross-referenced it to the accession-book entry. Badu asked the clerk to keep the chain of custody simple and explicit: who supplied the notebook, who gave permission, who photographed it, where the images were stored, and who had accessed

them. It was not glamorous work, but the investigation depended on it.

The archive then sent a response about the inspection diary. The relevant volume had survived, but its cover was detached and several pages had been repaired. A search of the index showed a visit recorded for K. B. Mensah in the district during the same month. The date was three days after the possible notebook entry. The diary did not specify which building he visited; it simply listed “records review” among several stops.

The team located two retired clerks who had worked in the same regional office as Mensah. Their memories were uneven. One remembered that he kept lists of visits to children’s institutions; the other recalled that he often carried a small notebook but could not say what he wrote in it. Neither had seen him alter the Haven House register. Badu recorded the distinction carefully. A habit of keeping lists might explain how a person could know details later, but it did not prove that the lists contained the missing entry.

Mensah agreed to an interview at a neutral office. He arrived with a walking stick and a folder of retirement papers, and he asked whether he was being treated as a suspect. Badu explained that they were investigating the movement of records and wanted to understand his duties. Mensah said he had

visited several institutions during his career, sometimes following complaints, sometimes delivering instructions. He denied keeping unofficial lists of children. When shown a photocopy of the directory, he pointed out that the directory listed his formal post, not every temporary assignment he had undertaken.

Badu asked him about reference 17-B. Mensah studied the number for a long time, then said it looked familiar but could not place it. The answer could have been evasive, or it could have been the honest response of an older man confronted with a code used decades earlier. The interviewers did not supply him with details from the missing file. They asked him to describe his recollection first and noted where his account changed after he saw the document.

Afterwards, the team compared his statement with duty rosters and travel claims. One record placed him in the region during the relevant month, but it did not establish that he went to Haven House on the disputed afternoon. A transport entry used a vehicle number that had since been reassigned. The trail had become more specific, yet it remained incomplete. Badu told the team to resist the easy conclusion that a man who kept lists must have been the man who changed one. The evidence had to connect the person to the act, not merely to the theme of the investigation.

That placed Mensah in the district, not at the archive, and not necessarily at Haven House. It was a link, but a modest one. Badu requested the full page and the itinerary records for the day. He also asked for any travel claims or vehicle logs that could corroborate the route, while recognising that such records might not have survived.

Mabel began to see the shape of the problem. Each record was a small window. Through one, they could see a number. Through another, a signature concern. Through a third, a visit to the district. No single window showed the whole room. Their job was not to pretend the windows were one picture, but to test whether the views aligned when measured carefully.

That night, Abena called to say she had found a loose page tucked into the back of her father’s old notebook. It was not part of the notebook’s bound sequence. The page contained a list of file references and three names, one of which was crossed out. She had not touched it beyond placing it in a clean envelope. Badu arranged to collect it the next morning, with a witness present and a written record of the handover.

Before the call ended, Abena added something she had not thought important earlier. Her father had once told her that a list was only useful if someone checked the names against the people who actually

came through the door. “Otherwise,” he had said, “you are recording what an office wishes had happened.”

Mabel wrote the sentence down. It did not prove wrongdoing, but it captured the weakness at the centre of the Haven House records: a register could list a name without proving who stood before the clerk, and a signature could appear without proving who held the pen.

The man who kept lists had left them a question, not an answer. The next morning, they would examine the loose page and find out whether it belonged to the disputed period—or whether the apparent connection was another coincidence the investigation had to survive.

The address in the old directory led them to a modest house on a side street where the afternoon heat gathered beneath a corrugated awning. The retired registry officer, Mr. Samuel Tetteh, had agreed to meet them only after Badu sent a written explanation of the inquiry and confirmed that Tetteh was not being treated as a suspect. He opened the door with a notebook in his hand and glanced first at their identification, then at the official letter.

“I kept lists because offices forget,” he said as he led them into a room crowded with labelled envelopes. “People remember the meeting but forget who attended. They remember a file but forget when

it left the cabinet. A list does not remember everything, but it gives you something to check.”

Tetteh had not taken government files home. He made that distinction before they had even sat down. What he retained were personal working notes: dates of meetings, requests for copies, references to bundles that had been delayed, and reminders to follow up. He understood that even private notes could contain confidential information, so he asked that Badu record what he showed them and return every page to its folder.

Mabel noticed that the notebooks were arranged by year, not by subject. The labels were simple: ‘January–June’, ‘July–December’, ‘Follow-up’. The system looked ordinary until Tetteh opened a notebook from the year of the Haven House review. Beside several entries were small squares, some ticked and others left empty. He explained that a tick meant he had personally seen a response; an empty square meant the matter had remained unresolved when he last checked.

They searched for the reference 17-B. It did not appear in the index at the front. Tetteh turned pages slowly, stopping whenever he found a notation that might be relevant. Several pages concerned routine transfers and duplicate copies. One entry referred to a request for ‘children’s review papers’ but gave no

institution name. Another recorded that a receiving office had disputed the number of sheets in a bundle.

“Could that be the Haven House file?” Mabel asked.

“It could be. But this wording was used for more than one set of papers. I cannot identify it from that description alone.” Tetteh tapped the empty square beside the entry. “I never saw a signed response. That is why I left it unticked.”

Badu asked whether Tetteh had ever worked with Inspector K. B. Mensah. Tetteh thought for a moment and said he remembered the inspector visiting the building on official business, but he could not attach a date to the memory. He had met many officers. A familiar name was not enough to establish who had requested a file or who had signed for it.

Tetteh brought out a second notebook, thinner and more heavily annotated. It contained a list of references he had been asked to follow up after a departmental reorganisation. Near the bottom of one page was a notation that looked like ‘17-B / R.A. / confirm recipient’. The final words had been underlined twice. There was no name beside them.

“Why did you underline it?” Badu asked.

“Because I had not received confirmation. I was reminding myself to ask again.”

“Did you ask?”

Tetteh turned to the following page. There was no note recording a response. He looked troubled, not evasive. “If I had received a clear answer, I would normally have ticked the square or written the name. But I cannot say whether I forgot, whether the answer came verbally, or whether the matter was transferred to someone else.”

That uncertainty mattered. The note showed that Tetteh had been trying to confirm a recipient. It did not prove that the bundle had been misdirected, and it did not prove that anyone had deliberately hidden it. It did, however, give them a date range and a procedural question to put to the archive.

Mabel asked if she could photograph the page. Tetteh agreed after Badu recorded the notebook’s title, approximate date, and page number. The photograph was taken in his presence. He then signed a short acknowledgment stating that the notebook remained his property and that the investigators had photographed the relevant entry with his permission. The original stayed in the house.

Before they left, Tetteh remembered another detail. During the reorganisation, staff had been told to place unresolved transfer slips in a temporary tray near the dispatch desk. The tray was meant to be cleared at the end of each month. If it had not been cleared, papers could have remained outside the formal bundle for weeks. He could not say that this

had happened to 17-B, only that it was a possibility worth checking against dispatch records.

Badu wrote down the name of the officer who had supervised dispatch at the time. Tetteh warned that the officer had since died, and that the records might have been destroyed under the normal retention schedule. The clue did not guarantee another witness. It gave them a location to ask about and a reason for a specific search.

A search of the retirement office found an old notebook catalogue but not the notebooks themselves. The catalogue listed several field visits in abbreviated form, and one entry referred to an institution whose name had changed after a merger. Investigators requested the merger records to determine whether the entry could relate to Haven House. The catalogue had been prepared years after the visits, so it might contain transcription errors. Badu instructed the clerk to retain the original catalogue and make a working copy for comparison. Mensah’s name appeared in the index, but the entry did not describe what he had done. The team would need the underlying notebook or another source before drawing a conclusion.

The retired clerks’ statements were stored separately until the comparison was complete. Badu wanted the differences visible, because agreement reached after witnesses had spoken together could be

less informative than disagreement recorded independently.

The team kept opportunity, knowledge, and proof as separate categories in its working notes.

On the drive back, Mabel studied the photograph of the notebook entry. ‘Confirm recipient’ was the phrase that held her attention. It suggested that someone had noticed a gap in the chain of custody before the current investigation began. But a gap could have been an administrative oversight, a lost slip, or an intentional act. The notebook did not decide among those explanations.

“What if the person who kept the list was also involved?” she asked.

“Then his notes still need to be tested,” Badu said. “We do not treat a record as honest because it is handwritten, or as dishonest because its author had access. We check it against other records and ask whether the author’s account fits.”

Back at the office, they created a preservation copy of the photograph and logged it as an investigative lead, not as proof of the bundle’s contents. Badu requested dispatch records for the relevant period and asked the archive to identify the temporary-tray procedure. He also asked for the policy governing unresolved transfers during the reorganisation. If the process was documented, the team could determine

whether the missing confirmation was unusual or routine.

That evening, Tetteh called to say he had found a loose slip inside the back cover of the notebook. It was a reminder in his own handwriting: ‘Ask R.A. who signed.’ He could not recall writing it, but the ink and paper looked consistent with the notebook. Badu asked him not to remove or alter the slip. A time would be arranged to photograph it in place.

The note raised a sharper question, but it did not supply the answer. Someone identified only as R.A. might have been a person, a department, or a shorthand used within the office. The phrase ‘who signed’ suggested that a signature existed somewhere, yet the slip did not name the document or explain why Tetteh had been unable to confirm the recipient.

Mabel entered the new detail in her evidence table, then stopped herself from writing ‘the missing signature’ in the heading. She wrote ‘unresolved signature query’ instead. The difference was small, but it kept the investigation honest.

The man who kept lists had not given them a confession or a hidden master record. He had given them a map of unfinished work. In an investigation built around files that vanished between offices, unfinished work could matter. It was not the same as guilt.

Badu arranged the interview with retired Inspector K. B. Mensah at a community office near the old district administration building. Mensah had asked that the meeting take place during daylight and that his daughter be told where he was going. Badu agreed to the practical arrangements but explained that the interview would be recorded and that Mensah could request a break. A lawyer attended at Mensah’s request. The team did not treat his caution as guilt; people who had worked inside institutions could have reasons to distrust an official room.

Mensah arrived carrying a flat envelope and a walking stick polished by years of use. He was smaller than Mabel expected, with a careful manner that made each movement seem considered. He confirmed his former role and the kinds of inspections he had conducted. He did not claim to remember every visit to Haven House. The home had been one of many institutions on his schedule, and the surviving lists were incomplete.

Badu asked him about the lists. Mensah said he had kept personal reminders because official forms were often returned late or filed under the wrong category. He had not considered those reminders evidence; they were a way to remember which matters required follow-up. Some had been destroyed when he retired. Others had remained in the envelope because he had intended to sort them and never had.

He placed the envelope on the table but did not open it until the evidence officer had photographed its condition and recorded the transfer. Inside were several folded sheets, a pocket diary, and a typed list of unresolved inspections. The pages were not numbered, and Mensah could not say whether they had originally been stored together. The officer catalogued them as separate items before anyone discussed their contents.

The list included Haven House beside a date and the words “records check—return visit.” A second line referred to a meeting at the regional registry. Neither line gave a reason. Mensah said the notes were his handwriting, but he could not remember whether the visits had occurred on the dates written or had merely been scheduled for those dates. The diary showed that some appointments were cancelled and rescheduled without the list being updated.

“Did you see a fifth child?” Mabel asked before she could stop herself.

Mensah looked at her, then at Badu. “I remember children in the dormitory. I cannot count them from memory after all these years. If I tell you five because the papers say five beds, I would be repeating the papers, not remembering the room.”

The answer unsettled Mabel because it offered no revelation. It also sounded like the first answer that did not try to satisfy the question. She apologised for

asking it too quickly, and Badu recorded that she had asked the question and that Mensah had given the answer in those terms.

Mensah then pointed to a small notation beside the registry visit. It might have been the number 17-B, or it might have been a shorthand reference used in his office. He would not identify it without seeing the original register from that period. The team photographed the notation at high resolution and added it to the list of items requiring comparison.

Before the interview ended, Mensah asked whether his name had already been given to the press. Badu said he would not discuss operational decisions, but no finding had been made against him. Mensah nodded slowly. “A list can show what a man meant to do,” he said. “It cannot always show what he did.”

Outside, Mabel admitted she had expected him to know more. Badu reminded her that a witness’s limits could be useful if they were properly documented. Mensah had confirmed the existence of personal inspection notes, identified one possible reference, and explained why the dates could not be treated as completed visits. The team now had a new source to test, not a conclusion to announce.

The loose page was smaller than the notebook and had been folded into quarters. Its paper was thin, with a faint blue ruling and a torn edge that suggested it had once been attached to something else. Abena handed it to Badu in the presence of the evidence clerk, who recorded the time, condition, and circumstances of the transfer. No one tried to flatten it by force. The page was photographed as received before it was placed in a protective sleeve.

The list contained six references, not five. Three were crossed through in pencil, two had short notes beside them, and one had been circled. The circled entry was 17-B. Beside it, in smaller writing, were the words “compare receipt—do not rely on copy.” At the bottom appeared the initials S.K. and a date that might have been the last day of the month, although the final digit was damaged.

Mabel felt a surge of excitement, followed immediately by caution. The page appeared to connect

Kwarteng to the disputed file, but it still did not identify the contents of the bundle or the person who had signed for it. The note could have been written before a receipt was checked, after a discrepancy was found, or as a reminder to complete routine work.

Badu asked the examiner to determine whether the page's paper and ink were consistent with the period. The examiner could offer an approximate assessment, not an exact date. The ruling, paper texture, and fading were compatible with an older office sheet, but none of those features alone established when it had been written. The handwriting looked broadly similar to Kwarteng's notebook entries, though a definitive comparison required better samples and a cautious conclusion.

The phrase "do not rely on copy" changed the request they sent to the archive. Instead of asking only for the original movement slip, they asked for every receipt associated with the 17-B transfer, including cancelled copies, duplicate carbon sheets, and any register that recorded the receipt's return. They explained that the request arose from a privately held note whose relevance had not yet been established. They did not present the note as proof of forgery.

By midday, Mabel had received an email from an unfamiliar address. The subject line read: "You are making a mistake." The message contained no greeting and no signature. It said that the old records

had already been reviewed by people more qualified than her, that the fifth-child theory was a distraction, and that she should stop asking questions about signatures she could not recognise.

She read it once, then called Badu rather than replying. He asked her to preserve the email in its original form and forward a copy through the agreed evidence channel. The digital investigator recorded the headers and noted which information could be verified. The sender's display name was blank. The message did not contain an explicit threat of physical harm, but its knowledge of the investigation and its attempt to silence her made it relevant.

"Could it be the same person?" Mabel asked.

"Possibly. The anonymous phone messages and this email may be connected, but we should not assume that until we have evidence. We will record the similarities and the differences."

The message unsettled her more than she wanted to admit. It did not tell her that someone would hurt her. It did something subtler: it tried to make her feel foolish for continuing. It invoked authority without naming an authority, and it treated her lack of certainty as a reason to stop investigating rather than a reason to investigate carefully.

Badu arranged a security review with the appropriate unit. He advised Mabel not to meet unknown contacts alone, not to share the team's

movements, and to report any further attempts at intimidation. He did not encourage her to confront the sender. The goal was to preserve evidence and reduce risk, not to turn a threatening message into a private contest.

That afternoon, the archive called with an update. A receipt book from the relevant period had been located in a separate storage cabinet. The pages were not yet fully indexed, and the archive would need time to inspect them. The official who called did not describe the contents over the phone. Badu thanked him and asked that the book be preserved and that no pages be removed or rearranged during the search.

The timing made Mabel suspicious, but Badu reminded her that the email could not be used to explain every delay. The receipt book might simply have been stored in the wrong place. If the sender had inside knowledge, they might be reacting to the investigation; if not, the coincidence was still a coincidence. They would not know until they had the evidence.

At the end of the day, Mabel returned home by a different route and told a trusted person that she had received an intimidating message. She did not broadcast the details online or attempt to identify the sender through public accusations. She kept the original message and followed the safety plan Badu had discussed with her.

When she arrived the next morning, a plain envelope was waiting at the reception desk. It had no return address and was addressed to her by name. The receptionist had not opened it. Badu asked that it be photographed in place and logged before anyone handled it further. Inside was a photocopy of a page from a report about Haven House. Most of the text had been blacked out. One line remained visible: “The witness’s statement is not to be attached to the final copy.”

Mabel recognised the wording as similar to a phrase she had once heard, but she could not say that it came from the same report. There was no heading, date, author, or file number. The photocopy might be authentic, altered, or assembled from different sources. Its appearance at reception made it an investigative lead and a possible attempt to intimidate her, not a verified official record.

Badu had the envelope and copy secured. He asked the records team to search for the phrase in the known report series, using the wording exactly and then likely variants. He also asked the office to check access logs and reception records to establish when the envelope had been left, without assuming that the person who delivered it was the person who prepared it.

Mabel sat in the interview room with the photocopy in front of her. The line seemed to describe

the very thing she had feared as a child: that her words had been kept apart from the record meant to preserve them. Yet the document did not prove that this was what had happened. She needed to let the search test it.

“I want to know who did this,” she said.

The threat was not the first unsettling message Mabel had received, but it was the first that referred to her childhood statement. The wording was brief and avoided an explicit promise of harm. It warned her that some memories had been “put away for a reason” and advised her to stop asking about Room Four. Badu treated the message as an incident to document, not as confirmation that the investigation was approaching the right suspect. People sometimes threatened investigators to distract them, and sometimes a message was sent by someone who knew only what had appeared in public.

A digital specialist recorded the message as received and explained which details could be preserved from the device. The team did not ask Mabel to reply or provoke the sender. They reviewed the security arrangements at the newspaper office and agreed on a simple protocol: unexpected visitors would be directed to reception, staff would preserve any envelope or note without writing on it, and Mabel would inform Badu of new contact. The precautions were practical rather than theatrical. They were

designed to keep her safe without turning every stranger into a suspect.

Mabel's editor wanted to publish the threat immediately. Mabel argued that doing so could reveal what the sender knew and encourage another message designed to steer the story. They agreed to hold the details while the police assessed whether publication would interfere with the inquiry. Mabel hated withholding information from readers, but she understood that transparency did not require disclosing every investigative step at once.

That evening, she walked home with a colleague and found herself studying every parked vehicle. She recognised the fear as a response, not evidence. The next morning she wrote down what she had noticed and what she could not identify. There was no plate number, no reliable description, and no reason to claim that a car near her street was connected to the message. By separating the observation from the conclusion, she denied the threat the power to write the next chapter for her.

"So do I," Badu replied. "But first we find out what this page is. If it is genuine, the surrounding paragraphs may explain the context. If it is altered, the alteration itself may tell us something. Either way, we preserve it before we interpret it."

The phrase search produced a possible match in a catalogue entry for an administrative review, but the

catalogue described a different institution. The report itself had not yet been retrieved. The match could be a shared template or a similar phrase used in routine procedure. The archive requested a formal authorisation before releasing the file because it contained personal information about children.

Badu prepared the authorisation request and narrowed its scope to the relevant report and its attachments. He included a statement explaining why the witness reference mattered to an inquiry into possible record alteration. He did not ask for unrelated children’s personal histories. The request was reviewed, and access was granted to a redacted copy suitable for the investigation.

When the report arrived, the line appeared on a page that discussed how interview notes should be assembled into the final administrative summary. In context, the sentence could mean that an unverified statement should be kept separate until a supervisor reviewed it. It might also have been used to exclude an inconvenient witness. The surrounding paragraphs did not resolve which explanation applied to Mabel’s case, because her name was not present in the redacted copy.

Mabel let out a breath she had been holding. The line was real in one report, but the photocopy sent to her could still have been taken from it, altered, or used to imply a connection that had not been

established. The report gave them a procedure to investigate, not proof that the procedure had been abused.

Badu asked the archive for the attachment register and the version history of the report. If an attachment had been removed, the register might show when and by whom. If the report had been revised, the version history could identify the changes. If no such records survived, they would have to document that limitation and find another route.

Late in the afternoon, the regional archive confirmed that the receipt book contained an entry for a bundle linked to 17-B. The receiving column included a name, but the archivist cautioned that the handwriting was difficult to read and that the entry could not yet be certified. The book would be examined by a specialist, and the archive would provide a proper copy once the review was complete.

“We have an original source now,” Mabel said.

“We have a book that may contain the relevant entry,” Badu corrected gently. “That is a meaningful step. It is not yet a verified identity.”

They waited for the certified copy. Mabel added the new developments to her evidence table and marked the anonymous email and envelope as potential intimidation. She did not call them proof of a cover-up. The messages could have been sent by someone involved in the original events, someone

who had discovered the inquiry later, or someone who wanted to exploit the story for reasons of their own.

Before she left, she reviewed the security advice again and confirmed that she would not meet an unknown source alone. The investigation was no longer only about old paper. Someone appeared interested in what the team might find, but the safest and most useful response was still to document each contact, protect the records, and follow the evidence.

The first threat had not revealed a culprit. It had revealed that the investigation had become visible to someone who wanted it to stop. Mabel could not yet tell whether that person feared the truth, feared a false accusation, or simply wanted to control the story. She could only keep the message, keep the question open, and refuse to let intimidation decide what the records meant.

The envelope arrived at the newsroom shortly after the morning meeting. It had no return address and no stamp, which meant someone had delivered it by hand or placed it in the building's internal mail. The receptionist remembered seeing a courier near the front desk but could not identify him. There had been other visitors that morning, and no one had asked the receptionist to sign for the envelope.

Mabel did not open it at her desk. She photographed it where it lay, noted the time and the names of the people who had handled it, then called

Badu. He asked her to leave it untouched until an evidence officer could collect it. The instruction irritated the editor, who wanted to know whether the envelope contained a story, but Mabel refused to trade a clean chain of custody for a quick headline.

The envelope was plain and unmarked. Inside was a photocopy of a page from a document that appeared to list five entries. Four had been crossed out in dark ink. The fifth line was covered by a narrow strip of paper, as though someone had deliberately hidden the name while copying the page. Beneath it was a typed sentence: ‘Some names are safer when no one asks.’

The photocopy did not include a heading, date, signature, or file reference. It might have been connected to Haven House, but there was no reliable way to establish that from the image alone. The crossed-out lines resembled the five strokes in the earlier anonymous message, though resemblance was not authentication. Mabel recorded that observation without presenting it as proof that the same person had sent both items.

Badu arranged for the envelope and contents to be logged. The paper was examined for visible marks and copied for analysis. The team did not promise that fingerprints or other traces would identify the sender; ordinary handling, photocopying, and the passage of time could limit what could be recovered. The most

useful evidence might turn out to be the source document rather than the envelope itself.

The editor asked Mabel whether she was being threatened. She considered the question before answering. “The message is meant to make me uneasy. Whether it is a threat in the legal sense is for the police to assess. I am not going to describe it as more than we can establish.”

“You could publish the page,” the editor said. “Let the sender know we are not frightened.”

“Publishing it could expose a name if the strip lifts or if another copy is already circulating. It could also alert whoever has the original that we have received this version.” Mabel closed the evidence folder. “We should understand what it is before we turn it into a public performance.”

Badu asked whether she had noticed anyone following her or contacting her outside the messages already logged. Mabel said she had not seen anyone she could identify. She did not want every unfamiliar face to become a suspect. Badu suggested practical precautions: vary her routine where reasonable, keep messages intact, tell a trusted colleague when she left late, and report any direct approach. He did not suggest that she investigate the sender herself.

That afternoon, the team checked whether the envelope could have come from someone with access to the newsroom’s public entrance. The building’s

visitor log recorded several deliveries, but the entries were incomplete. The receptionist had not been negligent; the procedure did not require every person dropping off an unaddressed envelope to present identification. The weakness was institutional, not evidence of a particular person's involvement.

A second call came from the regional registry. The records manager said the separate register containing another reference to 17-B had a name beside it, but he was unwilling to interpret the entry until the original page could be inspected. Badu arranged a formal visit and asked that the page remain in place until then. He did not tell the manager about the threatening envelope. There was no reason to mix the two matters before any link had been established.

Mabel returned to the photocopy and examined its edges. The paper had been cut slightly unevenly. At the lower corner, a fragment of a blue stamp was visible, only a curve and two letters. It might have come from an office stamp, a commercial copy shop, or another page beneath it. She photographed the fragment and added it to the list of details to be examined, not a conclusion about where the copy had been made.

The evidence officer pointed out that photocopies could preserve defects from an earlier copy, so even a clear stamp fragment might not identify the last person who handled the page. If they could locate a

better copy or the original, they might compare paper layout, typeface, numbering, and any recurring marks. Without that, the fragment was simply a lead.

That evening, Mabel received another message: ‘Stop asking who signed.’ It contained no name and no demand for money. She did not reply. She took a screenshot, preserved the original conversation, and reported the message through the agreed channel. Badu asked the digital investigator to add it to the existing record and compare its metadata with the earlier messages, while warning that technical similarities might establish a shared device or service without proving a specific sender.

For the first time, Mabel admitted to herself that the sender’s purpose might not be to stop the investigation completely. Each message seemed to push them toward a particular question, then punish them for asking it. The sender could be trying to frighten them away, or to steer them toward a person who had been selected as a convenient culprit. The two possibilities required different responses, but neither could yet be established.

The station’s safety officer reviewed the route Mabel usually took to work and suggested small changes that would not disrupt her life unnecessarily. Mabel agreed to share her arrival times with a trusted colleague for a short period and to report any direct approach. She did not want the threat to make her

retreat from the investigation, but she accepted that caution was not cowardice. Badu kept the message within the evidence file and asked the digital specialist to record any later contact in the same way. No one claimed the sender was a suspect merely because the message was threatening. The team still needed to establish who sent it and whether that person had knowledge of the records.

The safety plan was reviewed after forty-eight hours. No new contact had arrived, and no one had identified a credible immediate threat. The team kept the precautions in place without escalating the message into a conclusion about who had sent it.

The message was logged as a threat, while its author and motive remained unconfirmed.

Badu asked her to prepare a short account of every contact, in chronological order, with the exact words and the time received. She did so, separating direct observations from interpretations. The earliest message had shown five strokes. The next had said she remembered more than she admitted. The latest told her to stop asking who signed. Together, they demonstrated that someone was following the investigation’s direction. They did not reveal whether the sender had inside access, a participant’s account, or simply a good guess.

Before leaving the newsroom, Mabel locked her notebook in her desk and took only the ordinary work

papers she needed. She told the receptionist not to confront anyone who asked for her. The instruction was not dramatic; it was sensible. She did not want an employee put at risk because the case had made the building feel unsafe.

At home, she placed her phone on the table and sat without opening the messages again. She thought of the child she had been, standing outside a room where adults were discussing a record as if the person named in it were not real. The new threat had the same cold assumption: that fear could decide which questions were permitted.

She wrote one sentence in her private notebook: ‘Do not let the sender choose the suspect.’ Then she added a second: ‘Do not let fear choose the evidence.’

The next morning, the records manager’s written confirmation arrived. The separate register did contain the reference 17-B, entered on a different date from the accession index. The name beside it was partly legible, and the office could not confirm whether it identified the person who prepared the entry or the person who received the papers. An inspection was scheduled for the following day.

Badu read the letter and placed it beside the photocopy from the envelope. One was an official record with a damaged entry; the other was an anonymous image designed to provoke. Their timing was suspicious, but timing alone did not establish a

connection. He ordered the team to pursue the registry inspection and the anonymous-message inquiry on separate tracks until evidence justified bringing them together.

“We have a real appointment tomorrow,” he told Mabel. “That is the next step. Not a confrontation, not a guess, and not a public accusation.”

Mabel nodded. The first threat had not closed the investigation. It had made the rules of the investigation more important. Whoever had sent the envelope wanted them to feel that every question carried a cost. They would have to proceed carefully enough that the cost could not be used to excuse a false answer.

PART THREE

Chapter Eleven — Emmanuel Badu’s Note

Kwame Badu did not open the envelope in the car. He waited until he reached the office, logged its arrival, and asked the evidence clerk to photograph the seal before anyone disturbed it. The records manager had sent it by registered courier after their call the previous evening. On the accompanying form, the sender had described its contents as a copy of an old register entry and a loose sheet found inside the same file. Nothing in the form connected the papers to Haven House. That connection was still theirs to test.

Kwame read his father’s note a second time after the evidence clerk had made the required copy. The handwriting was familiar enough to stir memory, but familiarity could be dangerous. He remembered Emmanuel Badu correcting school forms at the kitchen table, tapping the paper twice before signing. The note in the envelope had the same habit of leaving

a small gap before the final stroke, yet that was not a forensic conclusion. It was a son’s impression, and he told himself so before he allowed it to influence the investigation.

He informed the deputy commissioner that a document apparently written by his late father had entered the case. The disclosure was recorded to prevent a later allegation that he had concealed a personal connection. The deputy commissioner asked whether Kwame wanted another officer to take over. Kwame said he would comply with any decision, but he believed he could continue if his actions were independently reviewed. The decision was made that he could remain involved in operational work while another senior officer reviewed significant evidential decisions connected to the note.

The note referred to a “change requested after the visit” but did not name the person who requested it. It could concern the Haven House records, another institution, or an administrative correction that had nothing to do with the missing child. Kwame marked the line and refused to read more into it than the words allowed. He requested comparisons with other dated letters, but he did not submit the note to a handwriting examiner as though the personal resemblance settled authorship.

That night he took no copy home. He left the document in secure storage and called his sister only

to tell her that their father's name had appeared in an inquiry. He did not ask her to remember anything or suggest what she ought to say. If she had relevant information, it would need to be taken formally and without coaching. For the first time since the investigation began, Kwame felt the cost of the case in a place no evidence schedule could fully describe. His duty was not to defend his father's reputation. It was to discover what the records could prove, even if the answer remained uncomfortable.

The envelope was ordinary, brown, and slightly softened at the corners. Its tracking label showed that it had passed through two sorting centres before reaching them. Badu examined the label and the seal, then watched as the clerk opened it with a clean blade. Inside lay a photocopy of a ruled register page and a folded sheet of paper, thin with age. The copy carried the same damaged reference they had seen before. The loose sheet bore a short handwritten note, signed only with the initials E.B.

Badu felt the initials before he allowed himself to read them. Emmanuel Badu had been his father's name. He kept his face still and asked the clerk to record the discovery exactly as it appeared. He did not touch the page again until the initial examination was complete.

Mabel, who had arrived to review the registry response, noticed the change in him. “Is it your father?” she asked quietly.

“It may be a note written by someone using the same initials. It may refer to another Emmanuel Badu entirely.” He looked at the sheet. “We have to establish what it is before I decide what it means.”

The note was brief. It read: “Do not send the fifth copy through the ordinary desk. The register is not the original. Ask for the book kept apart from the monthly returns.” Below that, in a different line, appeared: “If they ask, I did not certify the change.” The initials E.B. sat at the bottom, followed by a date whose final digit was unclear.

Mabel read it once, then again. “The fifth copy.”

“A phrase,” Badu said. “Not yet a fact.” He wrote the words in his notebook and separated each possible meaning. It could refer to the fifth copy of a document, the fifth child in a list, or an internal copy number. The instruction about the ordinary desk suggested a records procedure, but the note did not identify the office, the change, or the person who had requested it.

He was careful not to let the phrase pull him straight toward the childhood register. They had spent weeks following fragments that seemed to fit together. Some had proved relevant; others had led to dead ends. A disciplined investigation had to allow both possibilities.

The document examiner arrived before noon. She compared the photocopy with the image sent earlier by the regional registry and found that the ruled lines and small tear near the upper margin appeared consistent. That supported the view that the two copies came from the same page or from copies of the same page. It did not establish where the page had been kept, who had written the entry, or whether the note had ever been attached to it.

“Can you date the paper?” Badu asked.

“Not to a particular year from this inspection. The paper and ink are compatible with older office stationery, but compatibility is not a date. If the original survives, we can examine it more fully. A photocopy removes many of the features that would help.”

The examiner also cautioned them that the signature-like initials could not be attributed to Badu’s father from a short note alone. A proper comparison would require authenticated samples from the relevant period and an expert assessment. Even then, the result might be limited. Initials were brief, and people’s handwriting varied.

Badu thanked her and asked for the limits to be included in the written report. It was an uncomfortable request to make about a document that might involve his family, but discomfort could not be allowed to change the standard. If the note was

genuine, it could be important. If it was not, he needed to know that too.

Mabel watched him return the note to its protective sleeve. “You could ask someone who knew your father’s handwriting.”

“I can ask, but memory is not a substitute for examination. Anyone who loved him may see what they hope to see. Anyone who distrusted him may see the opposite.” He closed the evidence folder. “We will seek authenticated records first.”

That afternoon, Badu requested copies of his father’s surviving official correspondence through the proper channel. He declared the possible personal connection in writing and asked another senior investigator to oversee any handwriting comparison involving the note. He would remain involved in the wider inquiry, but he did not want a later challenge to the evidence to rest on an allegation that he had quietly chosen the interpretation that suited him.

Mabel respected the decision, though she could see its cost. For Badu, the investigation had ceased to be only about a dead judge and a missing register. His father’s name had entered the record, and every possible explanation threatened to turn a professional question into a private one.

They returned to the note’s wording. The phrase “monthly returns” appeared in older administrative manuals as a reference to summary reports prepared

at regular intervals. Those reports often repeated information from original registers. If the original register and the monthly return disagreed, the return could show that a discrepancy had existed, but it would not by itself explain who created it.

Mabel found a digitised manual in the public archive and printed the relevant pages. Badu asked the registry for the retention schedule that applied to monthly returns, original registers, and separately held books. The note's instruction to ask for "the book kept apart" might describe a legitimate security procedure, a local filing habit, or an attempt to conceal a record. The schedule and the office's own practice would help them distinguish those possibilities.

Near closing time, the regional records manager replied. An older register series had indeed been kept separately from the monthly returns during a period when the office was short of secure storage. The register was not listed under the ordinary accession sequence. It had been transferred during an office reorganisation, but the manager could not confirm its current location. The transfer list contained a cross-reference to an archive room whose records were still being inventoried.

"That is the first verifiable meaning we have for 'kept apart,'" Mabel said.

"It is a possible meaning," Badu corrected gently. "We need to see whether the register series includes

the relevant dates and whether any entry relates to Haven House."

The manager agreed to preserve the transfer list and arrange an inspection. The process would take time because the archive room was undergoing a controlled inventory. Badu asked for a written confirmation and a list of the boxes scheduled for examination. He did not demand immediate access by bypassing the process; if the material later became evidence, the chain of custody would matter as much as the discovery itself.

That evening, Mabel stayed behind to organise the material into a chronology. The anonymous sender's messages had encouraged them to connect the initials, the disputed signature, and the fifth child. But the new note might have been written by Badu's father, by someone else with the same initials, or by a person deliberately trying to redirect the investigation. Its language gave them a route to follow, not permission to skip the route's checkpoints.

She added a separate column for contradictions. The note said the writer had not certified a change. If the writer was Emmanuel Badu, it might mean he had been asked to approve an alteration and refused. It might mean someone had falsely claimed he approved it. Or it might concern a routine administrative change unrelated to the children's records. The wording was too incomplete to choose among those possibilities.

Badu returned after a call with the senior investigator. He had arranged for the note to be examined independently and for the archive request to be handled by another officer. “I will not pretend this does not affect me,” he said. “But I will not let it decide what the evidence says.”

“Do you remember him talking about records?” Mabel asked.

“He worked in public service. He talked about forms, delays, missing stamps, and the way a small mistake could travel from one office to another until everybody treated it as truth. I never heard him mention Haven House. That absence does not prove anything either.”

For a moment, Badu seemed to consider saying more. Instead, he took out a small notebook he had brought from home. It contained a few dates and references copied from family papers, not the original documents themselves. He had found it among his father’s effects years earlier and had not considered it relevant until the initials appeared. He showed it to the senior investigator before allowing Mabel to read the page he had marked.

The page contained a list of office visits, each identified by a date and a short description. One line, written in his father’s hand according to the family’s belief but not yet authenticated, read: “Registry — separate book; return not enough.” The date was close

to the period under investigation, though the year was partly smudged.

Kwame asked an independent records officer to prepare a chronology of how the note had travelled from the archive to the courier envelope. The chronology contained a gap between the last documented inspection and the day the envelope was sent. The gap might reflect routine filing that had not been recorded, or it might point to a handling problem. Kwame did not fill it with a theory about his father. He disclosed the gap to the reviewing officer and asked that any conclusions about authorship or meaning be made independently of his personal recollections. The process felt formal and distant, but it protected the inquiry from the claim that family loyalty had shaped the result.

Kwame’s disclosure remained attached to the case file. He knew that transparency could not remove his personal connection to the note, but it allowed another officer to examine the decisions that mattered most without relying on his word alone.

The reviewing officer would assess the note without relying on Kwame’s personal recollection.

Mabel’s pulse quickened. “That sounds connected.”

“It sounds potentially connected,” Badu replied. “The notebook is a family document. We will record where it came from and ask the examiner to assess it. We must also establish what ‘registry’ meant in that

context. There were several offices he might have visited.”

He photographed the page, sealed the notebook in a protective cover, and recorded its provenance. He did not surrender it as if it were an ordinary item from the investigation; instead, he declared it and arranged a formal review. The distinction protected both the inquiry and the personal record. A document could be relevant without being conclusive, and family possession did not automatically make it reliable evidence of the event described.

When Mabel left, she carried the phrase “separate book” in her thoughts. The case was no longer a single missing file. It was a chain of records that might have been copied, summarised, transferred, or altered at different points. Each version could preserve part of the truth and distort another part. The task was to find the original source and reconstruct the path without treating the gaps as answers.

Badu remained in the office after the others had gone. He placed a fresh sheet beside his notebook and wrote three questions: Was the note genuinely written by his father? What change did the note refer to? Where was the separately held register now? He drew no arrows between them. Each required its own proof.

His phone rang at 8:17 p.m. The archive manager had located a box number in the reorganisation schedule. The box had been transferred to a

temporary records room, but its contents had not been checked against the old index. A visit could be arranged for the next morning, provided the investigation team followed the archive's inspection rules.

"Please reserve the box and preserve the surrounding inventory," Badu said. "Do not remove or rearrange anything before we arrive."

He wrote the box number on the case log, repeated it back to the manager, and ended the call. Then he looked once more at the note with the initials E.B. It might eventually clear his father, implicate him in a decision, or prove to have been written by somebody else entirely. For now, it had done one thing beyond dispute: it had pointed them toward a separate register that existed outside the ordinary filing sequence.

In the evidence room, the note lay sealed beside the photocopied index. The two items did not yet prove the same story. Tomorrow, the team would see whether the missing book could bring them together—or show that the connection they wanted was only another carefully placed false trail.

Kwame took the note to the small interview room after the morning briefing. He did not want to read it alone and then carry an untested interpretation into the case. The evidence clerk photographed the front and back, measured the paper, and recorded the

envelope’s condition. The note was short enough to fit on half a sheet. Its handwriting resembled a sample attributed to Emmanuel Badu, but resemblance was not identification. The clerk sealed the original in a transparent sleeve while Kwame and the document examiner worked from images. No one was permitted to place the note beside a pen and imitate its strokes.

The examiner began with ordinary features: letter forms, spacing, pressure variation, and the way the writer crossed the letter t. Several features were consistent with the known sample. Others could not be compared because the note contained too few repeated letters. The paper itself was commercially available and carried no unique watermark. A faint impression beneath the writing might have come from a sheet placed on top of another page, but the examiner refused to say what that earlier writing had been. “I can describe the impression,” she said, “not invent the sentence that belongs to it.” Kwame wrote the wording down because it was exactly the discipline the investigation needed.

For Kwame, the name on the note carried a private weight that the other officers could not fully see. His father had been a careful man, but careful people could still make mistakes, keep secrets, or be misunderstood by those who came later. Kwame told the team that his family connection should be disclosed in the file and that another officer should independently review any conclusion involving his

father. The decision was uncomfortable. He worried that stepping back would look like avoidance, while remaining too close could compromise the work. Badu's deputy reminded him that disclosure did not remove him from every task; it created a safeguard around the decisions most likely to be challenged.

They compared the note with the movement index and the copy of the register. The dates were close enough to suggest a possible connection, but none of the documents referred explicitly to the same transfer. The note could have been written before the register entry, after it, or in response to another event entirely. Kwame asked the clerk to create a chronology that marked each date as confirmed, copied, estimated, or disputed. The note would remain an important lead, not a verdict on a dead man's character.

Kwame asked for a second opinion from an examiner who had no prior connection to the family. The request was difficult to make, but he knew that the fact the note appeared to be in his father's handwriting would invite questions about his judgement. He submitted the known samples through the evidence officer and did not choose which examples the examiner should rely on. The examiner received copies labelled by exhibit number rather than by their relationship to the detective.

While the comparison was pending, Kwame visited his aunt, who had kept a small box of family papers after Emmanuel's death. He explained that he was looking for ordinary documents from the relevant years, not asking her to remember the case. She found a set of receipts, a school permission letter, and a note reminding someone to collect medicine. The writing varied with the paper and the pen. Kwame recognised the familiar slant, but he refused to mark any item as a confirmed sample himself. Among the papers was a separate, undated notation referring to "the child's second name" and asking that "the old entry remain attached." It did not name Daniel or Haven House, and Kwame logged it as a separate item rather than assuming it belonged to the E.B. note.

His aunt asked whether his father had done something wrong. Kwame took a long moment before answering. "I don't know. There are records with his name, but we have not established what he did, what he knew, or whether someone used his name. I cannot protect him by pretending the questions are settled. I cannot condemn him to make the investigation look decisive either."

She did not appear comforted. She had lived with Emmanuel's habits and kindness, and the possibility that his name had become part of a disputed chain of records felt like a judgement on the man she remembered. Kwame told her that the inquiry would have to distinguish his father's personal character

from the acts the evidence could establish. A good memory of someone was not proof that he could never have made a mistake; a troubling document was not proof that he had committed a crime.

The examiner’s preliminary report arrived two days later. Several letter forms were consistent with the known samples, but the quality of the disputed copy prevented a conclusive attribution. The examiner also noted that the document might have been copied from an earlier sheet, meaning the visible marks did not necessarily represent the original writer’s pen pressure. The report recommended examination of the original if it could be located.

Kwame read the report with the deputy commissioner present. He declared the family samples and the report’s limitations in the case log. The deputy commissioner asked whether he should be removed from the investigation. Kwame said he would comply with any decision, but the deputy commissioner chose a narrower safeguard: another senior officer would review all decisions involving the note, and Kwame would not be the sole person authorising any search or interview arising from it.

The arrangement felt like a loss of authority, but it also relieved him of the need to defend every decision against the suspicion that he was defending his father. He returned to the evidence schedule and rewrote the entry for the note. It no longer said “Emmanuel Badu’s

transfer note.” It said “document attributed to Emmanuel Badu; authorship and purpose not established.” The change was small, but it removed a conclusion that the evidence did not yet support.

That night, Kwame placed his father’s ordinary papers back in their box and sealed the evidence copies separately. He did not tell himself that the report cleared Emmanuel. It did not. Nor did it condemn him. The note remained a clue whose meaning depended on other records, and the investigation would have to proceed without turning family loyalty into either a shield or a weapon.

Chapter Twelve — The Quiet Office

The records manager’s written notice arrived at 8:17 the next morning. It identified the second register as an administrative control book held in a quiet office behind the regional archive’s public counter. The entry for 17-B had been made on a date different from the date in the movement index. The manager did not offer an explanation. He stated only that the register could be inspected by appointment and that the original page would remain in its binding during the inspection.

Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu read the notice once, then placed it in the case file. “That is the right way to handle it,” he said. “They have preserved the original and given us a route to examine it.”

The inspection appointment was set for ten in the morning, with a limit on the number of people permitted in the archive room. The registry manager explained the rules before unlocking the door: no pens

near the register, no loose papers on the table, no photography until the condition report had been completed. The restrictions were ordinary safeguards for fragile material, but Badu insisted that the team record them in the case notes so that no one could later claim the process had been informal or selective.

The register was thicker than it looked from the catalogue photograph. Its spine had been repaired twice, and several pages had small tears at the inner margin. The entry for 17-B appeared in a column headed TRANSFER CONTROL. A date had been written in the first field and a different date in the notes column. Neither date, by itself, explained when the bundle physically moved. The clerk’s notation might have recorded preparation, approval, or receipt. The heading alone could not answer which.

The examiner photographed the page in place and took measurements of the gap between entries. Mabel watched as the specialist explained that ink colour could not reliably establish age without suitable testing and comparison. Badu asked for the surrounding pages to be included, because an isolated entry might hide a routine practice or an irregular pattern. The manager agreed, provided the originals remained bound and the images were logged.

Before leaving, Badu asked for the written procedure that governed the register at the time the entry was made. The manager could locate a later

manual but not the earlier edition. That absence was important: the current rules could not simply be projected backwards onto a process that might have worked differently twenty years earlier. The team left with clear photographs and a request still outstanding. The quiet office had yielded more detail, but not the certainty that everyone had hoped to find behind its locked door.

Mabel Owusu had expected him to be more excited. “A second entry, a different date, and a name we haven’t seen. Doesn’t that suggest someone was moving the bundle outside the normal system?”

“It suggests the system contains two entries that need to be reconciled. We have to find out whether one records preparation, dispatch, receipt, or a later correction. Until then, the difference is a question, not an accusation.”

He arranged for a records officer and a document examiner to accompany them. The request specified that they wanted to inspect the register, photograph the relevant page under the archive’s rules, and record the entries immediately before and after it. They also requested the register’s cover, its date range, and any instructions explaining how the control book had been used. Badu insisted that the surrounding pages mattered as much as the entry itself. A line without its context could be made to tell almost any story.

The archive occupied a low building whose windows were shaded by metal louvers. At the reception counter, a clerk checked their letters and directed them down a corridor. The office at the end was smaller than Mabel had imagined. Two filing cabinets stood against one wall; a desk, a locked cupboard, and a narrow table filled most of the remaining space. The room had no sign announcing its purpose. It was quiet enough for the scratch of a pen from the adjoining room to be heard clearly.

The records manager, Mrs. Esi Quartey, greeted them and explained the conditions of inspection. The book would not be removed from the room. They could not place loose sheets on its pages, and any photograph had to include the archive’s reference card. If they needed a certified copy, they would have to submit a separate request. Her manner was formal, but not hostile.

“I want to be clear,” she said. “We are not refusing access. We are trying to preserve a register that has already suffered water damage along the lower edge. I will not have anyone press it flat or turn pages quickly.”

“Those precautions are reasonable,” Badu replied. “We will follow them.”

A staff member brought the control book in a shallow archival tray. Its cover was faded blue, the spine repaired with linen tape. The pages were ruled

by hand, with columns for reference, action, destination, officer, and remarks. Some entries had been written in blue ink, others in black. Several had been crossed through with a single line and initialled. Nothing about the book, at first glance, looked like a secret record. It looked like the ordinary machinery of administration: a place where movement was supposed to leave a trace.

The document examiner photographed the cover and recorded the condition of the binding before the relevant page was opened. Mabel watched the process, aware that the careful routine was not a delay. It was what would allow the photographs to be trusted later. The examiner used a small scale beside the page, captured the entire spread, then took closer images without touching the ink.

The entry for 17-B appeared near the middle of the page. The reference matched the one in the movement index. In the action column, the writer had entered a short phrase: “returned for review.” In the destination column were the letters “R.A.” The officer column contained a signature or initials that were difficult to read. The final column carried a date that was four days later than the date in the other register.

Mabel leaned forward, then stopped herself before crossing the table’s edge. “Returned from where?”

Mrs. Quartey pointed to the column headings. “This book does not always state the prior location.

The person making the entry was expected to cite the movement slip. If that slip survives, it should answer your question."

"Does it survive?" Badu asked.

"We have not located it. The index refers to a slip number, but the corresponding packet is not in the usual drawer. We are checking the older boxes."

Badu did not hide his disappointment, but he did not allow it to shape his questions. He asked whether "returned for review" was a standard phrase. Mrs. Quartey said it was common enough, but its meaning depended on the office and the case. A bundle might be returned because a page was missing, because a supervisor requested clarification, or because it had been sent to the wrong department. The phrase alone could not establish that the bundle had been altered.

The examiner captured the adjacent entries. One referred to a routine land-administration file. Another concerned a personnel folder returned because a signature had not been witnessed. Neither was connected to Haven House, but both showed that the control book recorded ordinary administrative returns as well as unusual ones. The surrounding entries did not reveal a hidden code or a pattern of obvious tampering.

Mabel studied the ink and the spacing. The letters "R.A." were written in a narrow hand, with the A left open at the top. She remembered the anonymous

sender's note about a signature that had never been his. She could feel the temptation to match the handwriting to the initials in the earlier index. She wrote down the visible features, then added: "No attribution possible from present image."

Badu noticed. "Good."

"I wanted to say it looks like the same hand."

"Then note what makes you think so. But until the examiner compares originals under suitable conditions, 'looks like' stays an observation. It is not an identification."

The document examiner explained that a photocopy or a photograph could distort line thickness and pressure. To compare handwriting responsibly, they would need originals or high-quality images, sufficient known samples, and a qualified examination. Even then, conclusions might be limited. A short set of initials offered very little material.

Mrs. Quartey turned to the next page only after the examiner had completed the required images. A small pencil note appeared in the margin of the following entry: "See review copy." It was not beside 17-B, and no cross-reference number accompanied it. The note might have been relevant to the same administrative sequence, or it might have belonged to an entirely different file. The examiner photographed it as part of the page, but Badu made no claim about its meaning.

“Can we search for a review copy?” Mabel asked.

“We can search the index by phrase and date range,” Mrs. Quartey said. “But ‘review copy’ is not a unique title. Several departments used the expression.”

“Then please record the search terms and the registers checked,” Badu said. “If the search finds nothing, we need to know exactly what was searched.”

The manager nodded and wrote the request down. Her cooperation was methodical rather than warm. Mabel found that reassuring. A person trying to manipulate them might have been eager to interpret the entries or steer them toward a preferred suspect. Mrs. Quartey did neither. She described what the office could do and what it could not yet establish.

At the end of the inspection, the examiner closed the book and checked that the pages lay as they had before. The register was returned to its tray and signed back into custody. Badu signed the visitor record, noting the time they had arrived, the time they left, and the reference they had inspected. Every action left a trail.

Outside, Mabel asked him what he thought the second date meant.

“I think the bundle was recorded as returned for review four days after the other entry. That may mean the first entry recorded a dispatch and the second a

return. It may mean the index was updated late. It may mean someone corrected an earlier mistake. We need the movement slip."

"And if it was deliberately returned to keep it out of the normal file?"

"Then the slip, the receiving office's register, or a witness may help establish that. We will test that possibility. We will not announce it before we can support it."

Mabel was beginning to understand that the investigation would not be solved by a single dramatic discovery. Each document opened another set of doors, and each door had to be checked before they walked through it. The process was slower than the anonymous messages made it seem. It was also the only way to build a case that could survive scrutiny.

At the office, Badu dictated a short record of the inspection while the details were fresh. Mabel prepared a parallel note for her own reporting file, carefully distinguishing the official observation from her interpretation. Neither document named a culprit. Both identified the next steps: locate the movement slip; establish what "R.A." meant in that register; determine whether the review copy could be found; and compare the date sequence against the Haven House records already obtained.

The registry later supplied a photocopy of a procedure manual dated several years after the

disputed entry. It described how transfers should be logged, but the manager warned that the practice might have changed over time. Badu asked for staff circulars and training records from the earlier period. One circular referred to a temporary paper-based system introduced during renovation, which could explain why some fields were incomplete. It did not explain the overwritten date or the missing leaf. The new information widened the possible explanations while also giving the investigators a more precise set of documents to request. The quiet office had not yielded a confession, but it had revealed how much depended on understanding the procedure in force at the time.

The archive manager signed the inspection record and noted the condition of the register when it was returned. Badu asked for a copy of the signed record before leaving, ensuring that the inquiry preserved not only what they saw but also how the inspection had been conducted.

The inspection record preserved the condition of the register at the moment it was examined.

Later that afternoon, Mrs. Quartey called. The archive's staff had found a catalogue card referring to a "review packet" stored under a legacy series, not under the 17-B number. The card listed a box number and a note that the packet had been transferred during an office reorganisation. It did not say that the

packet contained Haven House records. It did, however, provide a new location to search.

Badu asked her to preserve the card and send a scan with its catalogue context. He also requested the transfer list for the legacy series. The manager agreed, warning that the list was incomplete and might take time to retrieve.

When the call ended, Mabel stood beside the case board. The string connecting 17-B to the other documents remained only a working aid, not evidence in itself. She removed one line that implied a direct connection and replaced it with a note reading: “Possible relationship—verify through source records.”

“You’re changing the board,” Badu said.

“I’m changing what it claims.”

He gave a small nod. “That is how it should work.”

Before she left, an email arrived from the digital investigator about the anonymous message. The available technical information did not identify the sender. It did show that the image had been forwarded through a service that stripped some original metadata. There was no reliable location data to report. The investigator cautioned that the absence of metadata did not prove deliberate concealment; many ordinary services removed it automatically.

Mabel read the note twice. The sender remained unidentified, and the message remained an unverified lead. The quiet office had yielded a real entry, a date discrepancy, and a catalogue card—but not the answer they wanted.

Badu closed the file for the day. “Tomorrow we follow the legacy series. We will ask for the box, document every transfer, and compare what we find with the original sources. If the packet is there, it may tell us something. If it is not, the transfer list may still tell us where it went.”

Mabel looked at the case board one last time. The investigation had not leapt forward; it had become more exact. The archive’s quiet room had not yielded a confession or a name. It had yielded a route that could be checked. For a case built around missing records, that was enough to keep going.

The records manager met them at the public counter and took them through a door that looked no different from the cupboards around it. Beyond it, the office was narrow and unusually quiet. A desk faced the wall; two metal cabinets stood beneath a high window; a small fan moved warm air from one side of the room to the other. The manager explained that the office had been used for control books because staff needed to consult them without bringing members of the public into the restricted archive. He did not claim

that the arrangement had always been followed. He had inherited a procedure, not witnessed its creation.

Before opening the cabinet, the manager showed the team the access log and the key-control sheet. The two records were maintained separately. The access log recorded who entered; the key sheet recorded who signed for the key. On the date under review, the name on the key sheet was legible, but the access log had a correction in a different hand. That could indicate a late administrative correction, a routine mistake, or an attempt to conceal who had entered. The documents alone could not decide among those possibilities. Badu asked for copies of the relevant pages and for the names of everyone authorised to make corrections under the policy then in force.

Mabel noticed that the correction had been made in blue ink while the original entry was black. The difference was visible, but it did not establish when the ink had been applied. The manager said the office had changed suppliers more than once and that blue pens were common in the building. The examiner photographed the page under ordinary and angled light, then warned them not to infer an exact date from colour. Mabel wrote down the caution beside her observation. She was learning that a visible difference could be real and still tell them less than it first appeared to tell them.

The manager offered to search for the old procedure manual. It took him twenty minutes to find a copy in a cabinet marked “superseded.” The relevant section required two staff members to verify a correction to a control entry, but the surviving page did not say whether the same rule had applied when the disputed entry was made. They would need the earlier edition. The manager promised to check the depot’s catalogue and provided a signed note confirming the request. The team left with no culprit and no confession, but with a policy question precise enough to answer.

The archive manager met them before the public counter opened. He had brought the superseded procedure manual, the current manual, and a register of staff access cards. He wanted the inspection to be orderly, he said, because the missing page had already made the archive look careless. Badu replied that a careful record of the inspection would help the institution as much as the investigation. They agreed to record each action and any limitation before the register was opened.

The quiet office was not secret. It was a cramped administrative room used when a file required a second check or when a visitor needed privacy. A printer occupied one corner, and a row of labelled trays covered the wall. The room’s ordinary

appearance made its importance easier to miss. Several entries in the old control book had been verified there, but the room had no dedicated camera and its access log recorded card use rather than the identity of the person holding the card.

The manager explained that staff sometimes lent their cards to colleagues when the counter was busy. He said the practice had been discouraged but not consistently prevented. Badu asked for the written policy and the training records. The manager produced a circular reminding staff not to share access cards, issued several years after the disputed date. There was no signed attendance sheet proving that every worker had received it.

The team examined the access log against duty rosters. One card had been used at a time when its assigned holder was recorded as being on leave. That discrepancy might mean the roster was wrong, the card had been lent, or someone had used it without permission. It did not identify the user. The manager requested an internal review, and Badu asked that the original log be preserved before any administrative correction was made.

Mabel noticed that the control book’s instructions had been copied in different inks. The examiner said the variation could reflect ordinary updates made over several years. Without a reliable dating method for each addition, the colour of the ink could not

establish when a rule had changed. He photographed the entries and recorded the visible differences, but declined to infer that the darker writing had been added after the disputed transfer.

A clerk who had worked in the building at the time remembered a supervisor who preferred to settle urgent questions verbally. She could not remember whether that supervisor had handled reference 17-B. Her recollection was written down and shown back to her for correction. She crossed out a phrase that implied she had witnessed a specific transaction and replaced it with a more accurate statement: she remembered the practice, not the individual transfer.

Badu thanked her for making the correction. It was precisely the kind of distinction the inquiry needed. A pattern could explain how a record became unreliable, but the team still had to connect the pattern to the disputed entry through independent evidence. The clerk’s statement supported a concern about procedure; it did not prove that a named official had altered the register.

Before the inspection ended, the manager signed a preservation notice covering access logs, staff rosters, old manuals, and surviving training documents. The archive would provide copies formally. As the manager closed the office, Mabel understood why it was called quiet: decisions made there could leave little trace unless someone recorded them.

The records manager's call came at 8:17 the next morning. He sounded as if he had spent the night rehearsing a statement he did not want to make. The second register had been located, he said, but the page containing the entry for 17-B was no longer in the folder. The binding showed where a leaf had been detached. Nobody at the registry could yet say when it had happened.

Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu asked him not to touch the folder again. He requested photographs of the folder as it had been found, a written account of who had accessed the room since the previous inspection, and confirmation that the remaining pages had been secured. He did not accuse the manager or anyone on his staff. A missing page was a serious fact, but it was not, by itself, proof of who had removed it or why.

When he put the phone down, Mabel was already standing by the office door. She had heard enough to understand. 'The page has disappeared.'

‘The manager says the page is missing. We still need to establish when it went missing.’ Badu wrote the time of the call in his notebook. ‘Keep those two statements separate.’

Mabel looked at the growing case board. The reference 17-B sat in the centre, linked by thin lines to the accession book, the damaged movement index, the anonymous photograph, and the disputed initials. Until yesterday, the missing material had seemed to be buried in the past. Now a page had vanished from a folder that investigators had only just begun to examine. The present had become part of the chain of custody.

‘Could someone have removed it before we asked for the register?’ she said.

‘Yes. Could it have been misplaced during an earlier reorganisation? Also yes. Could the gap have been there for years? Yes. We need the access records and the physical examination before we decide which explanation deserves attention.’

Badu assigned a records officer to prepare a formal preservation notice and contacted the appropriate evidence specialist. He wanted the folder examined without further handling, the torn or cut edges photographed, and the condition of the binding documented. If fibres or marks remained, they might help establish how the leaf had been removed. They

might not identify a person. Every request had to say what it could realistically prove.

Mabel went through her notes from the previous afternoon. The covering note from the registry had been signed by a staff member who had not mentioned the second register. That omission might mean the person had not known about it. It might mean the register had been found later. Or it might mean the information had been withheld. She wrote all three possibilities in the margin and resisted the urge to circle the one that frightened her most.

At nine-thirty, the registry manager arrived with a sealed evidence envelope containing photographs taken before the folder was moved. The images showed the open register, its numbered leaves, and a narrow strip of paper still caught close to the stitching. The page was absent, but the photograph did not reveal whether it had been cut out or detached along an old fold. A small handwritten mark on the next page read ‘see annex’. The annex was not among the documents in the folder.

‘What annex?’ Mabel asked.

‘That is what we need to establish,’ Badu replied. ‘It could refer to a supporting document, a separate bundle, or an attachment that was never filed here.’

The manager explained that the register had been stored in a room used by several departments over the years. The access book showed entries by staff who

had legitimate reasons to consult records. Some names were complete; others were initials. One week had no entries at all because the book itself had been sent for rebinding. He could not certify that nobody had entered the room during that period.

Badu asked him to provide the original access book and identify each person who had held a key during the relevant period. The manager agreed, though his expression tightened when the request included former staff. ‘I do not want innocent people treated as suspects because their names appear on an old list,’ he said.

‘Neither do we,’ Badu answered. ‘That is why we are asking for the list, not declaring what it means.’

The manager looked relieved, but only slightly. He had spent much of his career believing that a well-run registry was a quiet place: forms received, entries made, files shelved, requests answered. Now the office was being asked to explain not only what it held, but what it could not account for. Every gap seemed to reflect on the people who had worked there.

The missing leaf changed the mood of the inquiry, but Badu would not allow the team to call it proof of a cover-up. A page could be removed deliberately, damaged during handling, or lost before the register entered the archive. Each possibility required a different line of inquiry. The first task was to establish the last date on which the leaf was definitely present.

The second was to identify everyone who had accessed the folder since that date. Only then could investigators assess whether the disappearance was recent or merely newly discovered.

The archive manager provided access logs, staff rosters, maintenance records, and a list of visitors who had been authorised to enter the room. Some records were electronic; others were handwritten and incomplete. The team preserved the originals and made working copies, noting gaps rather than filling them with assumptions. A door-access entry showed that a staff card had been used after closing time, but the card belonged to a shared unit and did not identify the person holding it. Badu requested interviews with everyone who had been assigned the unit instead of treating the cardholder’s name as the answer.

Mabel asked whether the missing leaf might have contained the name of the fifth child. The examiner said it might, but the remaining register did not establish that. The leaf could have contained a continuation of the transfer notes, a blank page, or an unrelated entry. Its position in the binding offered a clue about sequence, not content. Mabel wrote the possibilities down and disliked all of them because none gave her the clean revelation she wanted.

That afternoon, the registry issued a preservation notice covering adjacent boxes and any duplicate index cards. Badu requested that no one reorganise

the shelves until the inventory had been photographed. The instruction irritated staff who wanted the archive returned to normal, but it prevented routine tidying from destroying evidence of where the register had been stored. The disappearance was now a separate event with its own timeline. Whether it connected to the original alteration remained a question, not a verdict.

Mabel understood that discomfort. Institutions often defended themselves by defending the people who had served them. Yet a careful inquiry had to make room for both truths: staff could be honest and still have incomplete systems; a system could be badly maintained without every error being deliberate. Equally, a person could exploit ordinary disorder to hide an intentional act.

The evidence specialist arrived shortly before noon. She inspected the photographs and asked that the original folder remain sealed until she could examine it in controlled conditions. She cautioned that a photograph of a torn edge could not reliably distinguish a recent removal from older damage. The strip caught in the stitching might be part of the missing leaf, but it might also belong to an earlier repair. She would not make a finding until she had the object itself.

Badu noted each limitation. He had seen investigations damaged by confident interpretations

of poor copies. A blurry mark became a name; a missing document became a confession; an unexplained delay became proof of guilt. Those leaps could destroy a case and leave the actual wrongdoing untouched.

While the specialist arranged collection, Mabel called Madam Efua Nyarko, the former matron of Haven House. She did not tell the older woman that a page had vanished. Instead, she asked whether the phrase ‘see annex’ meant anything in the records the home had once received from government offices.

Madam Efua took a long time to answer. ‘Some letters had attachments. Some had lists sealed separately because they contained children’s details. But I cannot say which papers you have found.’

‘Do you remember a register of five children connected with Room Four?’

‘I remember officials asking questions about records. I remember being told not to copy certain names into the ordinary visitors’ book. But I will not tell you that it was the same register unless I see it or someone shows me a reliable description.’

Mabel wrote down the distinction. Madam Efua’s memory mattered, but the woman was not pretending to remember more than she did. ‘Did anyone tell you to destroy a list?’ Mabel asked.

‘No one used that word to me. I was told that some papers were confidential and had to be returned to the office that sent them. Whether they were returned, I cannot say.’

‘Who collected them?’

‘There were many visitors over the years. Some signed. Some arrived with letters. I cannot give you a name just because you need one.’

The call ended without a breakthrough, but Mabel felt a reluctant respect for the answer. The witness was not offering a dramatic revelation. She was protecting the difference between a remembered instruction and an identified person. That difference might be the only thing preventing the case from turning into another story built around somebody else’s certainty.

In the afternoon, the digital investigator reported that the anonymous message had been routed through a service that did not disclose a subscriber identity in the material currently available. The message data could be preserved, but it did not identify the sender. There were lawful steps still available, subject to the required process, yet no quick technical trick would make the name appear.

‘So we have a person who knows about the investigation,’ Mabel said, ‘but we cannot prove whether they are helping us or steering us.’

‘Correct,’ Badu said. ‘The sender may possess genuine documents. They may also possess copies that have been altered, or fragments taken out of context. We verify every item independently.’

A new message arrived on Mabel’s phone just after three. It contained no photograph, only a sentence: ‘You have asked for the wrong file.’ A second message followed a minute later: ‘The page was not the record. The list was.’

Mabel showed Badu before replying. He asked her not to engage. The words could refer to the missing annex, the five names, or an entirely different list. The sender had once again supplied a phrase that sounded meaningful but could not yet be tested.

‘They know the page is missing,’ Mabel said.

‘Or they know we are looking at the register. That is not the same thing.’ Badu asked the investigator to add the messages to the case log. Their timing was relevant; their truth was unproven.

At four, the registry manager returned with a photocopy of the old room-access book. One entry stood out because the writing was more complete than most: ‘K. Mensah — review papers — 14:20.’ The date fell within the period when the second register was known to have been stored in the room. But the book did not record which papers had been reviewed, whether the visitor had entered alone, or whether the entry referred to the missing leaf.

Mabel felt the pull of the name. Inspector K. B. Mensah had already appeared in the investigation through the initials on another document. Two references could be a meaningful pattern. They could also be two ordinary records about the same official performing legitimate duties. The entry did not say he removed anything.

Badu asked the registry to confirm whether the handwriting in the access book could be attributed to the staff member who maintained it. He also requested any duty roster that could establish who was on reception that day. If the visitor had signed personally, they would need to compare the original entry with reliable examples of his signature, not with a cropped photograph sent by an unknown person.

‘What if Mensah really did take the page?’ Mabel asked after the manager left.

‘Then we will need evidence of that act, not merely evidence that he visited the room. We must also allow for the possibility that he was looking for the same missing records we are.’

The possibility irritated her because it widened the uncertainty just when she wanted it to close. But she knew Badu was right. A visitor could have been a witness, a custodian, an investigator, or a person with something to hide. The register did not tell them which.

Before leaving, the evidence specialist sealed the folder for examination and issued a receipt describing its condition. Badu checked the wording carefully. It recorded that a leaf appeared absent and that a narrow strip remained near the binding. It did not say when the leaf had been removed, who had removed it, or what it contained. The report was less dramatic than the rumours already forming around the office, but it was dependable.

Mabel updated her evidence table. The missing leaf was now a confirmed physical gap. The reference to an annex was confirmed in the surviving register. The anonymous sender's claim that 'the list' mattered remained unverified. The access entry for K. Mensah was authentic as an entry in the copy provided, but its meaning and authorship still required examination.

She added an action beside each line: inspect the original register; locate the annex; identify the access-book writer; obtain the duty roster; preserve the anonymous messages; ask Madam Efua whether she could review a properly prepared description without being led toward a particular answer. The work looked slow and ordinary. That was precisely why it might survive scrutiny.

As the office began to empty, Badu received a formal note from the records manager. A preliminary search had located an old catalogue card for an annex bundle, but the card listed no contents. Its location

field contained a code that had been crossed out and replaced in another hand. The replacement code pointed to a storage room that had been closed during a building renovation years earlier.

‘Another room,’ Mabel said.

‘Another place to search,’ Badu corrected. ‘We do not yet know whether the bundle is there.’

He authorised a preservation request for the room’s remaining inventory and asked that the room not be cleared or reorganised until it could be inspected. He also requested the renovation inventory, which might show whether materials had been moved elsewhere. The search would take time. If the bundle had been transferred, the trail might be recorded in a document no one had thought relevant until now.

That evening, Mabel returned to the photograph of the handwritten sentence: ‘The signature was never his.’ She placed it beside the new access-book entry, but she did not draw a line between them. Not yet. The message might have referred to Mensah; it might have referred to someone else entirely. The unknown sender had given them enough to suspect a connection and not enough to prove one.

She closed the notebook only after writing one final sentence: ‘A missing page is evidence of absence; it is not evidence of the person responsible.’

Across town, Badu received a short confirmation that the storage room could be inspected the following morning. Attached was a scanned inventory from the renovation period. Most of the entries were mundane: broken shelves, old stationery, files transferred to the central archive. Near the bottom, one line had been marked ‘sealed bundle — return to originating office’. The box number had been overwritten, and the originating office field was blank.

Badu printed the page and placed it in the case file. The words did not name Haven House, Room Four, or the fifth child. They did, however, establish another recorded movement of a sealed bundle whose destination had not been properly completed.

The access interviews produced no direct admission and no clear account of the missing page. One employee recalled moving a folder to make room for a repair; another remembered that the cabinet had been left open during an inventory. Their recollections differed on the day, and neither had a contemporaneous note. Badu asked the reviewing officer to compare their statements with the maintenance schedule rather than decide which person sounded more certain. The team also checked whether the detached leaf had been transferred separately under another reference. That search found no match, though several boxes remained uncatalogued. The missing page was still missing, and

the inquiry recorded that fact without turning every imperfect memory into an accusation.

The missing leaf was entered as a separate unresolved item in the case plan. That prevented its disappearance from being folded into the original alteration without evidence of a connection. Two irregularities might share a cause, but the investigation had to demonstrate that link.

The missing leaf and the earlier alteration remained separate lines of inquiry.

For the first time that day, the trail seemed to move forward without the anonymous sender’s help. The investigators had not recovered the missing list, and they had not identified the person who removed the page. But they had a room to inspect, an inventory to authenticate, and a chain of official records that could be tested against one another.

Badu switched off the desk lamp. The next morning might reveal nothing more than an empty shelf. It might reveal the annex itself. Until then, the missing page remained what the evidence said it was: a gap in a register, surrounded by questions that had not yet earned answers.

The access log arrived late in the afternoon, stamped by the registry's administration unit. It listed staff entries into the records room, but the log did not

identify which cabinet each person had opened. Several names appeared during the relevant week, including cleaners and maintenance staff whose access was routine. Their presence was not evidence of wrongdoing. It meant only that the room had not been continuously sealed.

Badu asked the manager to prepare a separate account from memory before showing him the access log in detail. He wanted the manager's recollection recorded independently, so that the list of names would not shape it. The manager described the folder as present during an inventory, then absent when a clerk returned to retrieve it. He could not narrow the interval beyond a day and a half.

The inventory itself contained a correction. A line originally labelled “restricted schedules” had been crossed out and replaced with “miscellaneous attachments.” The correction carried initials, but the date beside them was smudged. The clerk who had made the inventory had retired and could not immediately be located. Badu requested the original worksheet and the office instructions that governed such changes.

Mabel studied the photocopy. “If the folder was renamed, someone could have looked for the wrong description.”

“That is one possibility,” Badu said. “Another is that the correction was ordinary housekeeping. We

need to know whether the description changed before or after the folder disappeared.”

A technician inspected the cabinet shelf and found no fresh damage. The dust pattern showed that something of similar width had rested there, but dust could not identify the missing object or date its removal precisely. The technician documented the measurement and declined to infer more from it.

That evening, the anonymous sender sent a photograph of a blank shelf. The angle resembled the cabinet in the registry, but the image included no label or identifying feature. Mabel saved it, recorded the time, and sent it to Badu through the agreed evidence channel. Neither of them replied to the sender.

The message frightened her more than the earlier ones because it appeared to know about the missing folder. Yet the photograph might have been taken long before the current search, or in a different room altogether. Badu arranged for the digital investigator to compare the image with the documented cabinet, while warning that visual similarity would not by itself prove where or when it was taken.

The next morning, the manager found a second inventory reference in a separate catalogue. It described a sealed packet transferred to an annex, but the catalogue did not state that the packet was the missing folder. Badu requested the annex receipt and the staff roster for the transfer date. For the first time,

the team had a route to follow that did not depend on the anonymous sender's claims.

The missing page changed the inquiry's pace. Badu asked the records manager to prepare a chronology of the last known handling of the folder, including routine access that might otherwise have been dismissed as irrelevant. The chronology had to include names, times, the source of each entry, and any uncertainty. Where the access log could show only that a card had been used, it could not be rewritten as proof that its assigned holder had entered the room.

The first review found that three people had accessed the archive corridor during the relevant week: a registry clerk, a maintenance worker, and an outside technician repairing a faulty light. Their recorded duties were ordinary. The technician had signed in at reception, but the sign-in sheet did not record the precise rooms visited. The maintenance order confirmed the repair, yet it did not say whether the technician had entered the storage area where the folder was kept.

Badu interviewed each person separately. The clerk remembered looking for a related volume but not removing a page. The maintenance worker had changed a bulb and tightened a door closer. The technician remembered the corridor but could not identify the cabinet. None of the accounts independently placed a person at the register when

the page disappeared. Their statements were preserved without labelling any of them a suspect on the basis of access alone.

The records manager was visibly embarrassed. He offered to resign responsibility for the archive. Badu told him that the immediate task was preservation, not a symbolic punishment. “If you leave now, we lose the person who knows how the catalogue works,” he said. “The institution can review your management separately. Our evidence must not depend on whether anyone feels ashamed.” The manager agreed to remain available and to report any further discovery at once.

A separate search of the annex produced a packet with a label similar to the missing folder’s reference. The packet’s seal was old and unbroken, but its inventory described only “administrative correspondence.” No one assumed it contained the missing page. The team photographed the exterior, recorded the seal, and obtained authority to open it under observation. Inside were two routine letters, a blank form, and a copy of a transfer receipt with a torn corner.

The receipt was useful because it referred to a movement between departments, but the destination code differed by one character from the code in the current index. The examiner warned that the difference could be a typing error, a misread

character, or a genuinely different reference. The team requested the source ledger and any dispatch record that could distinguish those possibilities.

Mabel studied the torn corner. It had no handwriting, no seal, and no unique mark that could connect it to the missing page. She resisted the temptation to imagine that the page had been deliberately torn from the receipt. The packet might have been assembled long before the present inquiry. Its value lay in the surviving reference and the route it suggested, not in a dramatic appearance.

That evening, Badu drafted a brief internal report. He stated that the page was missing, that the last known location had been established only within limits, and that several people had legitimate access to the corridor. He also noted the newly found receipt as a lead requiring verification. The report did not identify a culprit. It gave the next team a reliable account of what was known and what remained open.

The Access Log

The archive manager arranged for the team to inspect the electronic access log in a room with no public terminals. A systems officer explained that the building’s current software had replaced an older platform twice. Some dates had been migrated, while others survived only in monthly reports printed for

audit. The team could not treat a missing electronic entry as proof that no one had entered the room.

They began with the date range surrounding the last confirmed sighting of the schedule. The report listed authorised users, but several entries used shared department credentials. One access occurred after normal hours under a code assigned to a whole unit. It was not possible to identify the individual who had used it.

“Can you recover the machine that created the report?” Badu asked.

“The server was decommissioned,” the officer said. “We may have a backup image, but restoration would take time and might not preserve every field.”

Badu authorised the work and requested a written explanation of the migration process. Mabel asked whether the log could have been edited after the fact. The officer said privileged users could correct certain fields, but the system should create a secondary audit entry. Whether that secondary log had survived was another question.

A junior archivist, who had been waiting to answer questions about a transfer slip, quietly added that the old office sometimes kept a paper key register beside the security desk. The register might show who signed out a key, though it would not prove who actually used it. Badu asked her to document the memory and identify where such registers were usually stored.

The team found three boxes of security paperwork in an off-site store. The first contained blank forms, the second routine monthly summaries, and the third a damaged register with several pages stuck together. The archivist refused to separate the pages without a conservator. The decision delayed the search, but it prevented the only surviving copy from being torn.

At the end of the day, they had a shared credential, a possible backup, and a damaged paper register awaiting conservation. None established who removed the file. Together, however, they gave the inquiry specific tasks: recover the backup, identify the authorised users of the shared code, and preserve the register before trying to read it. The missing file was no longer a single mystery; it was a set of questions with separate evidential paths.

The storage room was smaller than Mabel expected. It sat behind the old administrative wing, beyond a corridor that smelled of damp paper and floor polish. The door had been repainted, but the metal plate beside it still carried the pale outline of a sign someone had removed years earlier.

The storage room inventory was carried out in the presence of the building manager and a representative from the archive. They listed each shelf, container, and loose item before moving anything. A faded floor plan showed a narrow room beyond the corridor, but its labels had been revised at least twice. The words ROOM FOUR appeared in a typed schedule, while a handwritten note referred to a “children’s room.” The team photographed both without assuming that the labels described the same space at every point in the building’s history.

Behind a cabinet they found a shallow wooden tray containing old key tags, a broken padlock, and a bundle of maintenance slips. None of the items was immediately linked to the murder or the missing

register. The key tags were numbered, but their labels had faded; one brass tag carried the words ROOM FOUR in lettering that did not match the type used on the newer labels. The locksmith, called to document the mechanism rather than speculate, explained that a tag could be moved from one key to another and that a key's presence in the room did not prove who had used it.

Badu asked the photographer to capture the objects where they lay before the evidence clerk assigned separate numbers. The brass key was not treated as the key to Judge Agyeman's study. That distinction had already caused confusion in the earlier investigation, and Badu wanted it recorded in the notes. The locksmith would later test the lock only under a documented procedure and would not be asked to recreate an event for which they lacked a reliable timeline.

When the room was released back to the building manager, Mabel stood in the doorway and tried to imagine the children who had once occupied it. She stopped herself from assigning each bed to a name. The physical room could help establish layout and use; it could not restore every child's memory. Five bed frames might explain why a list mentioned five children, but they did not prove that all five were present together. The fifth bed was a clue worth following, not an answer by itself.

Badu arrived with a records officer, a photographer, and a representative from the building management unit. The room had been secured overnight under the preservation request. Before anyone crossed the threshold, the officer read out the authorisation and recorded the names of everyone present. Badu insisted on the procedure even though the room looked unremarkable.

“If we find nothing, we need to be able to say we searched properly,” he told Mabel. “If we find something, we need to show that it was here before we touched it.”

Inside were metal shelves, a desk with one broken drawer, several cartons of office forms, and a narrow cabinet whose lower door had warped. Dust lay thickly across the upper shelves, but the floor near the cabinet showed a recent crescent where something had been dragged. It might have been a cleaner, a maintenance worker, or someone moving a box. The mark was photographed before anyone speculated about it.

Mabel stood just inside the doorway and tried to look at the room as a witness rather than a reporter. She had learned to separate what drew the eye from what carried meaning. A room could feel secret without having been used for a secret. An empty shelf could look deliberate when it had simply been empty for years.

The inventory listed seven cartons, two ledgers, and a group of loose catalogue cards. Only six cartons were present. The missing carton was described as “miscellaneous transfer material”, without a date range or department name. A handwritten note beside the entry said “R.A. — see secondary index”. The writing was faint and the letters could not be confidently attributed to anyone.

“R.A. again,” Mabel said.

“A repeated code,” Badu replied. “That is worth following. It is not yet an identity.”

The photographer took images of the inventory, the shelves, and the gap where the seventh carton should have been. The records officer checked the catalogue cards one by one, announcing each title before placing it in a protective sleeve. Most related to routine administration: staff leave, vehicle maintenance, procurement forms, and obsolete stationery. One card had no title at all, only the number 17-B and a small pencil mark resembling five short strokes.

Mabel felt her pulse quicken, but she kept her hands by her sides. The five strokes resembled the anonymous image she had received, though resemblance could not establish that the cards were connected. Similar marks might be a clerk’s tally, a counting aid, or a notation whose meaning had been lost.

“Photograph it in place,” Badu said. “Then record the front and back. No one writes on it, folds it, or puts it in a pocket.”

The reverse was almost as faded as the front. Beneath a stamp were the words “Dormitory inventory — amended copy”. Below that, a date had been crossed through and rewritten. The corrected date was legible only in part. It appeared to fall within the period when Haven House records had moved between offices, but the final digit could not be established from the copy alone.

“Could this be the fifth-bed record?” Mabel asked.

“It could be a card describing a dormitory inventory,” Badu said. “That is all we can say today.”

The phrase brought back the confusion that had dogged the investigation from the beginning. Room Four was associated with a confidential judicial review. The dormitory had five beds. People had spoken as though the room and the dormitory were one place, but no reliable evidence had established that. Conflating them would turn a possible clue into a false map.

Mabel opened her notebook and wrote two separate headings: ROOM FOUR and DORMITORY. Under the first she listed the review file, the suppressed statement, and the question of who entered the room. Under the second she listed the

beds, the amended inventory, and the missing carton. She drew no line between the columns.

Badu noticed. “Good. Keep them separate until the evidence joins them.”

They continued through the room. In the broken drawer, the team found blank forms and a paper envelope containing a carbon copy of a transfer slip. The slip was too fragile to unfold completely, so the records officer photographed it under controlled light before supporting its edges. The visible fields showed a dispatch date, a receiving-office code, and a signature that had bled through from the sheet above. The signature could not yet be read.

The dispatch code was not 17-B. It was a different reference, followed by a notation that might indicate an attachment. Badu asked that it be included in the list of items for specialist examination, but not treated as part of the same bundle until the cross-reference was checked.

“Could the missing carton have been kept in that cabinet?” Mabel asked.

“Possibly. We document the empty space and ask who had access to this room. We do not assume the missing carton was ever in that cabinet.”

The building management representative produced an old access schedule. The room had been used by several departments after the records office

moved. Keys had been issued to a maintenance supervisor, two clerks, and a contractor who worked on the building during a renovation. The schedule did not prove that any of them had entered the room on the date relevant to the missing records. It did provide names and dates that could be checked against work orders and duty rosters.

One entry had been amended in blue ink. The original name was unreadable beneath a correction strip. The initials beside it were “E.A.”, not “R.A.” The alteration was not automatically suspicious; access schedules were sometimes corrected when staff changed roles. But the person who made the amendment had not initialled the correction in the space provided.

“That is a procedural irregularity,” Badu said. “We will ask for the original schedule and the amendment record. It does not prove that anyone was hiding anything.”

Mabel found herself thinking of the unknown sender again. Every time a new mark appeared, the sender’s messages tried to supply its meaning. The five strokes meant a child; the initials meant a particular officer; the missing signature meant forgery. The official records offered fragments, and the sender offered a story. Her task was to stop the story from swallowing the fragments.

At noon, the team completed the initial search. No carton labelled 17-B had been found. No original Haven House register had appeared. The most useful discoveries were the catalogue card, the transfer slip, the incomplete inventory, and the amended access schedule. Each was logged, photographed, and assigned a reference number. The room was resealed while the records officer arranged a more detailed search of the remaining shelves.

Outside, Mabel called Madam Efua Nyarko, the former matron of Haven House. She did not ask the older woman to identify the card from a description. Instead, she asked a narrower question: had the home maintained a dormitory inventory that listed the number of beds in each room?

“We had lists for bedding, mattresses, and repairs,” Madam Efua said after a pause. “Sometimes the list said how many beds. Sometimes it said how many children were assigned to a room. Those were not always the same thing.”

“Would a fifth bed have meant there were five children in the room?”

“Not necessarily. A bed could be kept for a child arriving later, or moved when a mattress broke. We were short of supplies. We made do.”

“Do you remember an inventory being amended?”

“Many were amended. If a bed was moved, someone wrote it down. If an inspector came, we tried to make sure the list matched what was there. But I cannot remember a particular fifth bed after all these years.”

Mabel thanked her and recorded the call according to their agreed procedure. Madam Efua had not confirmed a fifth child or connected the dormitory to Room Four. She had explained why a bed count could differ from a headcount. It was a useful warning against treating a number as a person.

Badu listened to the recording later that afternoon. “The fifth bed may be literal. It may be an administrative label. It may be a clue somebody planted because they knew we would be drawn to it.”

“And if it was a bed kept for an expected child?” Mabel asked.

“Then we need records of arrivals, placements, and departures. Not just a bed list.”

They requested the home’s surviving placement books, supply inventories, and correspondence about the movement of children during the relevant period. The request made clear that they were seeking records for a specific investigation and that sensitive information about unrelated children should be protected. Badu did not want the search to expose private histories that had nothing to do with the case.

That evening, Mabel reviewed the evidence table. The catalogue card showed that someone had filed an amended dormitory inventory under a reference linked to 17-B. The transfer slip suggested that related paperwork had moved between offices. The access schedule showed that several people could have entered the storage room at different times. None of these facts established who removed the missing carton or whether it contained the original Haven House records.

She added a separate line: “Fifth bed — do not equate with fifth child without independent evidence.” Then she saved the table in two locations and sent a copy to Badu through the case’s secure channel.

At 8:17 p.m., her phone vibrated. The anonymous sender had written: “You found the bed. Now ask who was meant to sleep in it.”

Mabel stared at the message. It was the first time the sender had referred directly to the dormitory search. That might mean the person had access to the investigation, or it might mean they had anticipated the direction of the inquiry from the clues they had already supplied. The message still contained no evidence that could be independently verified.

She did not answer. She captured the message, recorded the time, and forwarded it to the designated evidence contact. Then she called Badu.

“They know we found the card,” she said.

“Or they know we would look for it. We need to review who knew the search schedule, but we must not assume that a message arriving afterward proves someone was inside the room.”

The locksmith returned with a written report explaining the limits of the key examination. The brass tag could be associated with a room label, but neither the tag nor the lock established who had carried it or when it had last been used. The duplicate study key from the earlier murder inquiry was a separate item and was not part of this room’s evidence. Badu asked that the distinction be repeated in any briefing because the similar labels had already encouraged confusion. The report also noted that an old lock could be opened or replaced without leaving a reliable trace years later. The key was therefore retained as a historical object, not presented as a shortcut to identifying a culprit.

The key tags were photographed and placed in a labelled container. The report described their condition and lettering, avoiding claims about their use. Mabel understood that an object could be relevant to the history of a place without proving who had entered it.

The key could describe a place without identifying the person who had used it.

“It feels as if they are trying to direct us.”

“They are. The question is whether they are helping, manipulating us, or doing both. We keep our own sequence of work.”

Mabel returned to the photograph of the five strokes. In the first version, four had been crossed out. The fifth remained untouched. She had thought of the strokes as children, then beds, then names. Now she wondered whether the marks had been used to make a simple tally look like a code. It was possible that the sender had chosen an image whose ambiguity was its real purpose.

Before bed, she wrote a note for the next day: trace the inventory date; identify the origin of the catalogue card; check access to the storage room; obtain the placement books; keep the dormitory and Room Four as separate locations unless records connect them. She added one instruction in capital letters: DO NOT LET THE MESSAGE SET THE QUESTION.

Across the city, Badu received the preliminary report from the records officer. The catalogue card was genuine as an object found in the storage room, but its original filing date remained uncertain. The carbon transfer slip required specialist imaging. The missing carton had been listed in an inventory, but no record yet showed when it had last been seen.

He placed the report beside the old photograph of the Room Four door. Two spaces now stood at the centre of the inquiry: a confidential review room and

a dormitory with an amended bed count. They might eventually prove connected. Until then, the difference between them was as important as the clues themselves.

The fifth bed had not given them the fifth child. It had given them a question precise enough to investigate—and a warning about how easily a number could be turned into a story.

Badu closed the file only after adding the next set of requests. The work would continue through records, witnesses, and verifiable dates. Whoever sent the messages could wait. The investigation would not follow a stranger's instructions merely because the stranger knew how to make a mystery sound like an answer."

The timeline analyst pinned each record to a separate row on a board. The clinic card used the time a child was registered; the transport ledger recorded when a vehicle departed; the school register reflected when an attendance entry was completed; and the maintenance slip might have been written after the work was finished. The four times looked precise because they contained numbers. Their meanings were not identical. The analyst asked the team to stop using the word "contradiction" until they had established what each record was intended to measure.

A short interview with a former driver added another complication. He remembered that journeys were sometimes entered at the end of a shift, especially when the vehicle returned late or the clerk was busy. He could not recall the particular trip and did not claim to recognise the signature on the ledger. His account explained a possible source of delay in recording, but it did not establish that the disputed entry had been made late. Badu ordered the statement to be checked against the driver’s employment dates and the route records.

Mabel created a third timeline showing only events independently supported by more than one source. It was less complete than the first two and far less dramatic. The disputed visit remained within a broad afternoon window, but the exact minute could not be defended. She marked the uncertain period with a shaded band instead of a single line. The visual change made the gap impossible to ignore: the investigation could describe a sequence, but it could not yet claim a minute-by-minute reconstruction.

The analyst recommended that any later report explain the uncertainty in plain language. If a court or inquiry needed to choose between the versions, it would need to hear from the people who created the records and examine the procedures in force at the time. Neither summary could be accepted simply because it looked official. Badu approved the recommendation and asked that all future briefings

distinguish verified time, estimated time, and time copied from a secondary record.

The building manager brought an old maintenance ledger from a separate cupboard. Its pages were swollen at the edges, and a number of entries had been written in pencil before being overwritten in ink. He explained that the ledger recorded repairs, not the names of children who used the rooms. It could show when a partition had been installed, when beds had been moved, and when a door had been replaced. It could not establish who slept in a particular bed on a particular night. Badu asked that the ledger be handled as a separate source rather than folded into the children’s register simply because the two records concerned the same building.

A carpenter’s entry described a room as “five-bed dormitory,” while a later inventory listed four beds in the same space. At first, the difference seemed to support the theory that a child had been removed from the record. The building manager offered another possibility: during repairs, one bed had sometimes been moved into a passage and returned after the work. He could not say whether that explained the specific entries, because the ledger did not include a complete daily inventory. The team photographed the pages and arranged to compare them with purchase receipts and the annual property returns. The discrepancy had become a question about physical objects as well as names.

Mabel walked the room slowly, stopping where the old plan placed the fifth bed. The current wall had been repainted so many times that the earlier outline could not be seen. She tried to picture a child standing there, but stopped herself. Imagination could help her understand a space; it could not fill in a missing identity. She asked the manager whether former staff might remember the arrangement. He supplied three names but warned that memory after so many years would need careful handling. Badu decided that any interviews should begin with open questions and only later introduce the plan, so the interviewees would not simply repeat details they had been shown.

Before leaving, the team sealed copies of the plan, ledger extracts, and current photographs in one evidence packet, each with its own exhibit number. The original maintenance ledger stayed with the building manager under a written preservation request. It was important that the investigation not take possession of every old paper it encountered. A source could be preserved, copied, and independently checked without being removed from its lawful custodian. That distinction would matter if the records were later challenged in court.

The maintenance ledger led them to a retired carpenter who had repaired the iron frames at Haven House. He lived with his son in a modest house behind

a row of shops and remembered the job because the home had paid him late. He still kept a small receipt book, not as evidence but because he had used it to settle old accounts. Badu arranged for the book to be examined and copied under a written agreement, with the carpenter’s permission recorded.

The receipt book listed five bed frames repaired during one visit. It did not list five children. The carpenter explained that the frames had been moved between rooms while the building was being painted, and one frame had been stored in a passage for several days. He could not remember which child had used which bed, and he did not want the investigators to mistake a furniture count for a headcount.

“Were there always five children?” Mabel asked.

“I repaired beds,” he answered. “I did not keep the children’s register. Some nights a bed could be empty. Some children could be away with relatives. I cannot tell you who slept there from a receipt.”

The answer confirmed the distinction that the archive records had begun to suggest. Five frames were a physical fact. The number of children present on a particular date was a separate question. The team added the carpenter’s receipt to the maintenance exhibits and requested the home’s surviving attendance sheets, if any existed. The receipt could help establish the layout of the room, but it could not resolve the identity of the fifth child.

The old floor plan also required care. Its drawing showed a narrow room beside the dormitory, but the date of the plan was uncertain. A later renovation might have altered the layout. The building manager produced a work order for a partition and a replacement door, yet the order had no attached completion certificate. The team photographed the current structure and marked which conclusions depended on the older plan.

Daniel walked through the corridor with his lawyer present. He recognised the turn toward the dormitory but could not say whether the room had looked exactly as it did in the drawing. His memories were shaped by time, and the building had changed. He asked to leave when the questions became too detailed. Badu ended the walk-through rather than press him to produce certainty from fragments.

Later, Daniel told Mabel that he had hated the iron beds because their frames made a sharp sound whenever someone shifted in the night. He remembered that sound more clearly than any face. Mabel asked whether he remembered a child in the fifth bed. Daniel shook his head. He could remember the room and still not know who had occupied it. For once, the absence of an answer did not feel like a failure; it was a limit that could be stated plainly.

The team sealed the maintenance receipt, floor-plan copy, and work order as separate exhibits. In the

case summary, Badu wrote: “The evidence establishes that five bed frames were repaired; it does not establish that five children occupied them simultaneously.” The sentence was not the solution to the mystery. It prevented a misleading shortcut from becoming part of the official account.

Chapter Fifteen — Two Versions of the Same Day 292

The two records arrived in separate envelopes, delivered by different officers and logged five minutes apart. Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu insisted on that separation. One was a certified extract from the district registry’s daily movement book; the other was a photocopy of a summary prepared by Haven House Children’s Home. Both referred to the same date, but they disagreed about what had happened that afternoon.

Mabel Owusu laid them side by side on the conference table. The registry extract recorded a visit from an official identified only as ‘K.M.’ between two and three o’clock. The Haven House summary stated that no official visitor had entered the home that day. A third document, an attendance sheet, listed five children present in the afternoon session, though one name had been written over so heavily that only the final letter remained visible.

“Three documents, one day, and three different stories,” Mabel said.

“Three records with inconsistencies,” Badu corrected gently. “We do not yet know whether they tell different stories about the same event. We need to establish how each was made, who was responsible for it, and whether the dates refer to the same calendar.”

He drew a line down a fresh page and made two headings: VERIFIED and UNRESOLVED. Under the first, he wrote the dates printed on each document and the offices that had supplied the copies. Under the second, he listed the uncertain handwriting, the meaning of the initials, and the question of whether the Haven House summary was a daily log or a retrospective report.

Mabel knew the discipline was necessary, but the contradictions tugged at her memory. She could still picture the corridor outside Room Four, the high window, the smell of floor polish, and an adult voice telling another adult that the list had to be corrected before the next morning. Memory gave her impressions, not a calendar. For years, other people had treated the uncertainty as a reason to dismiss everything she remembered. She had no intention of making the opposite mistake by pretending every image in her mind was exact.

“I remember the argument,” she said. “I remember someone carrying a folder. I cannot place the date without help.”

“Then we record that precisely,” Badu said. “Your recollection can help us test a timeline. It cannot be used to manufacture one.”

Their first step was to ask the registry for the full page before and after the entry. The extract they had received showed only the relevant line. Badu requested a certified copy with the neighbouring entries, the register’s cover information, and an explanation of the date format used that year. He also asked whether the initials ‘K.M.’ were entered by the clerk who maintained the book or copied from a visitor’s own signature.

The second step was to find the original Haven House summary. The photocopy had been supplied from an archive carton, but its cover carried no reliable indication of when the copy had been made. The home’s former matron, Madam Efua Nyarko, had already warned them that reports were sometimes rewritten at the end of a month, when staff gathered scattered notes into a single account. If this summary was retrospective, its silence about a visitor might not mean the visitor had never come.

Badu arranged a meeting with Nyarko and asked her to bring any surviving examples of the forms used during that period. They met in a quiet room at the

district office. Nyarko arrived with a cloth bag containing two old notebooks, a set of blank forms, and a letter from the home's former administrator. She had kept them because she had once been asked to explain the difference between the daily attendance sheets and the monthly summaries.

"The attendance sheet was supposed to be completed on the day," she explained. "The monthly summary was not always written on the day. It was assembled from the sheets, the meal count, and staff notes. If a page was missing, the person preparing the summary sometimes filled a gap from what they remembered."

"Was that acceptable practice?" Badu asked.

"It was common. That does not mean it was good practice." Nyarko opened one notebook. "We were understaffed. Some people tried to keep the paperwork accurate. Others treated it as something to finish before an inspection."

She showed them a form with boxes for children present, visitors, supplies received, and incidents. The form had a space for the person completing it to initial each page. On the summary they were investigating, the initials had been cropped off in the photocopy. Without them, they could not identify the compiler.

Mabel pointed to the visitors' section. "If an official came, would they always be written here?"

“They should have been. But visitors did not all follow the same route. Some went to the administrator’s office. Some arrived with a letter and were taken directly to a meeting. The person completing the attendance sheet might not see them.” Nyarko hesitated. “I am not saying that happened on this date. I am explaining how the records could differ.”

Badu thanked her for making the distinction. He asked whether she recognised the handwriting on the overwritten name. Nyarko studied the copy without touching it. She said the original might allow her to recognise the way the writer formed certain letters, but the photocopy was too dark and the name too heavily altered. She would not guess.

After the meeting, Mabel walked with Badu to the records office. “It feels as if every explanation creates another gap.”

“An explanation should narrow the possibilities,” he said. “Today we learned that the summary may have been compiled later and that the visitor entry may have been made by someone other than the visitor. We have not solved the discrepancy, but we know what questions to ask next.”

The registry responded the following afternoon. Its full-page copy revealed that the ‘K.M.’ entry sat between a delivery receipt at 1:40 p.m. and a court clerk’s collection at 3:15 p.m. The entry itself had no

time recorded. A small mark in the margin matched a symbol used elsewhere to indicate that a visitor had presented a letter. It did not identify the letter or prove that the visitor went to Haven House.

The neighbouring entries also exposed a problem with the date. The register's heading used the local office's standard date format, but a faint correction had been written above the day number. The clerk's certification confirmed the correction was present in the original. It did not confirm who had made it or when.

Mabel leaned close to the scan. "Could that correction move the entry to the day before?"

"It could, depending on the original number beneath it," Badu said. "But the image does not support a reliable reading. We need an examination of the paper and ink. Until then, we keep both possibilities open."

The next morning, the archive manager gave them supervised access to the original register. A records officer remained present throughout. Badu photographed the page under the office's procedure, noted the condition of the paper, and asked the officer to record any handling or movement. Mabel watched the process, aware that the smallest careless action could later give someone grounds to challenge the evidence.

The correction was visible under magnification, but no one in the room claimed to read the original number with certainty. A document examiner would have to determine whether the top mark had been written over an earlier entry and whether the ink differed. Even then, the examiner might only be able to say that two inks were distinguishable, not who had used them or why.

On the way back, Mabel received a message from the anonymous number. It read: ‘You are comparing the wrong dates.’ There was no image this time, no explanation, no sign that the sender knew what the registry had supplied. The message could have been a warning or a trick. It could have come from someone with inside knowledge, or from someone watching their movements and making an educated guess.

Badu told her to preserve it and not reply. He entered the message in the case log, along with the time it arrived. He did not tell the records office about the message, because it was not yet clear whether it had any connection to the documents. The team would not allow the sender to direct the investigation by issuing cryptic commands.

That evening, Mabel returned to the timeline. She marked three candidate dates: the date printed on the Haven House summary, the corrected date in the registry book, and the date implied by a separate supply receipt. The receipt showed that an extra meal

count had been requested, but the request could have been made for a staff meeting or an unrecorded visitor. It did not identify a child or official.

She put the receipt aside and looked again at the five names on the attendance sheet. Four were legible. The fifth had been overwritten. She could not tell whether the change had replaced a name, corrected a spelling, or hidden a line that had been entered by mistake. Yet the same date was now linked to a visitor notation, an uncertain correction, and a list whose fifth entry could not be read.

For the first time, she saw a way to test her own memory without treating it as proof. If she could identify the order of events rather than the date, she might compare the sequence with the records. She wrote down what she recalled: a folder carried past the corridor; an argument about a list; a door closing; a child asking whether someone was leaving. She marked every detail with a confidence level and added the things she could not remember: faces, exact words, and the time of day.

When Badu reviewed the notes, he asked whether she had written them before or after seeing the new documents. Mabel admitted that the folder and list had been on her mind for days.

“That matters,” he said. “It does not make your memory worthless. It means we should be careful

about separating the original recollection from details that may have been prompted by the records.”

Together, they divided her notes into two sections: memories she had recorded before the latest discovery, and details she had added after reviewing the documents. The first section could guide questions. The second could suggest lines of inquiry but required even more caution. Mabel felt an unexpected relief. The process did not erase her memory; it gave it boundaries that no one could quietly move later.

A week later, the document examiner issued a preliminary report. The correction in the registry entry appeared to have been made with a different writing instrument from the original line, but the examiner could not determine the exact date of either mark. The report also warned that the copy of the Haven House summary was insufficient for handwriting comparison. An original was required.

The result did not settle the date. It did establish that the correction deserved further scrutiny and that the current photocopy could not support a confident attribution. Badu attached the report to the case file and requested the original summary through the proper archive process.

Before closing her notebook, Mabel wrote a sentence across the top of the timeline: ‘Two versions of the same day do not prove which version is true.’ Under it, she listed the next steps: locate the original

summary; identify the compiler; establish the date correction; determine what the ‘K.M.’ notation referred to; and compare the sequence of events with independent evidence.

Badu read the list and nodded. “That is the investigation.”

“It is slower than I expected.”

“Truth is often slower than the story people tell about it.” He gathered the copies into a folder. “But a story can be made to fit almost anything. A properly tested record has to survive questions.”

As they left, the registry manager called with one final update. The archive had located a sealed envelope attached to the original summary’s storage jacket. It had not been opened during the initial search because it was catalogued as administrative correspondence, not as part of the report. The envelope’s outer label bore the same date as the disputed entry and a reference number ending in 17-B.

Badu asked the manager to preserve the envelope and its jacket exactly as found. They would arrange a supervised examination the following day. He did not ask what was inside. Until the seal, label, and chain of custody were documented, even a seemingly obvious connection could be misleading.

Mabel left the office thinking about the two versions of the day. One record said no official visitor had come. Another recorded initials and a letter. A corrected date made the entries harder to align, while the sealed envelope promised context but not necessarily an answer. The unknown sender might be right that they were comparing the wrong dates. Or the message might be another attempt to make them abandon a careful method for a convenient suspicion.

For now, the only honest conclusion was that the records disagreed. Tomorrow, they would learn whether the envelope helped explain why.

The analyst tested the proposed timeline against the opening hours of the clinic and the recorded shift times of the driver. The result ruled out one interpretation of the transport entry but left two others possible. The analyst explained that a timeline could narrow the range of events without identifying the person responsible for them. Mabel amended her notes and sent the correction to Badu, making sure the earlier version remained archived. She had once believed that a strong investigation meant reducing every question to one answer. Now she understood that an honest investigation might preserve two plausible accounts until a witness or record could distinguish them. The disputed afternoon remained central, but it was no longer treated as a fixed point on the clock.

The analyst circulated the revised timeline with every estimated interval clearly marked. Mabel checked the wording before it went into the briefing pack. She wanted readers to see the uncertainty directly rather than discover it later as a weakness in the investigation.

Every revised time was traceable to its source and its stated limitations.

The two records were placed under separate covers after the first comparison. Mabel had been tempted to mark the conflicting times in red, as if the colour could make the contradiction more decisive. Instead, she prepared a neutral transcription of each entry, preserving the spelling, abbreviations, and punctuation exactly as they appeared. Interpretations would go in a separate column.

The district movement book used a twenty-four-hour clock in most entries, but the disputed line had a shortened time notation. The Haven House summary recorded only a broad afternoon period. One clerk told them that the shortened notation was common when a page was completed in haste; another said the time could have been copied from a later note. Neither had handled the original entry when it was made.

The photograph was examined first for signs of alteration and then for what it could actually show. The paper had curled at one corner, and the image

was soft around the faces. A specialist found no obvious evidence of a composite, but the age and quality of the print limited what could be concluded. The people in the background were too blurred for confident identification. A child near the doorway appeared to be looking towards the camera, yet the angle made it impossible to say whether the child was looking at the photographer or at someone standing nearby.

On the reverse, a short pencil notation gave a month and a year but no location. The handwriting did not match the label on the envelope, though the two might have been written by different people at different times. Mabel asked whether the notation could be dated. The specialist explained that paper and graphite could sometimes be examined, but such analysis might not yield a reliable calendar date. The team therefore treated the inscription as a lead and searched for independent photographs, event schedules, and staff rosters from the same period.

Daniel studied the image with his lawyer present. He recognised the building’s window pattern but would not identify the child in the doorway. He said the figure’s posture reminded him of someone he had known, then withdrew the comparison because he could not separate the memory from the stories he had heard since the inquiry began. Badu thanked him for stating the uncertainty. No one asked him to choose a name from a list.

The photograph was scanned at high resolution and stored alongside the untouched original. Mabel wrote a caption for the case file that described visible features without naming any person: five figures could be counted, though one was partly obscured; the setting might be an institutional corridor; the date and location remained unverified. It was a careful caption, and she knew how little of it would make a compelling headline. Still, the photograph had preserved a moment. Their job was to discover what moment it was, not to force it into the story they already had.

Badu requested the duty roster for that day and the daily attendance sheet. If the listed official had been elsewhere at the relevant time, that might challenge one interpretation, but the absence of a name from a roster would not automatically prove the person had not visited. Rosters could be incomplete, and visitors sometimes arrived under a department's general authority rather than an individual's name.

Mabel returned to the memory she had described in her statement. She remembered the sound of a folder striking a table and an adult saying that the list must not leave the room. She did not remember a clock, a date, or a name. When she tried to add those details, she could feel how easily the later investigation filled the empty spaces.

She told Badu she wanted the statement to remain unchanged unless she had a genuine correction. He

agreed. A witness should be allowed to clarify a point, but should not be coached into matching a document. If a later record contradicted her memory, the contradiction would have to be examined honestly.

A sealed envelope arrived from the archive with a receipt attached. The receipt identified the packet by a code and date, but the date did not align neatly with either version of the day. The envelope itself showed no visible sign of tampering. The seal would be examined by the archive officer before they opened it, and the receipt would be checked against the transfer ledger.

“It might be the missing link,” Mabel said.

“It might be a related record, or an unrelated packet with a similar code,” Badu answered. “We can be hopeful without deciding what it is before we open it.”

Mabel placed the envelope in the evidence tray and wrote the next steps on the board: verify the date, verify the seal, compare the receipt, identify the person who transferred it. The two versions of the day remained side by side, neither accepted as the complete account. The next document would be allowed to challenge both.

Badu asked the timeline analyst to present the conflicting records without trying to reconcile them at the outset. The analyst used a large board divided into three columns: the time recorded, the source of the

time, and the degree of confidence that could reasonably be placed in it. A clock entry copied from a daily summary was marked differently from a time written by a person who had personally witnessed an event. The distinction made the board look untidy, but it stopped the team from giving every timestamp equal weight.

The district registry’s movement book showed an official visit between two and three o’clock. The Haven House summary stated that no official visitor had entered that day. A clinic card recorded a child’s appointment, but its time appeared to have been added in a different hand. A transport ledger showed a vehicle leaving the district office without naming its passenger. Each record had a plausible administrative purpose, and none alone could settle the contradiction.

The analyst explained that the clinic’s clock had been reset after a power interruption that week. The clinic could confirm the date of the appointment from its daily list, but the exact time was less secure. The transport ledger was completed at the end of a shift, not at the moment the vehicle departed. The registry book was more precise, yet its initials did not identify the person who had personally seen the visitor.

Mabel asked whether the records could all be accurate in different ways. The analyst said that was possible. The visitor might have been recorded at the

registry but not at the home; the summary might have been completed from memory; or one of the dates might have been copied incorrectly. There were other explanations. The task was to test them against evidence that did not depend on the same source.

They contacted the driver named in the transport ledger. He remembered driving an official to the district office that week, but not which day. His old duty roster showed that he had been assigned to the vehicle, while the fuel slip recorded a purchase that afternoon. The fuel slip supported the possibility that the vehicle had been used; it did not identify the passenger or prove the purpose of the journey.

A former clinic administrator located a bound appointment book stored separately from the card. The entry confirmed that a child had been scheduled that day. The administrator could not verify the time because the book used appointment slots rather than arrival times. That independent source strengthened the date but left the disputed hour unresolved.

Badu instructed the analyst to keep both versions on the board. “We can say the records conflict,” he said. “We cannot choose the version that makes the story easiest.” Mabel copied the board into her notebook, preserving the question marks. The investigation had moved forward by learning which parts of the timeline were dependable and which were not.

Before the meeting ended, the analyst proposed one more search: the district office's surviving duty allocation sheets. If the visitor had been assigned to a specific officer, those sheets might establish who was expected to travel, even if they could not prove who actually did. Badu authorised the request. The timeline remained unsettled, but it had become a set of testable questions rather than a single disputed story.

The Driver's Ledger

The transport department produced a ledger that had been stored with vehicle maintenance records rather than journey sheets. Its entries were brief: vehicle number, fuel issued, driver initials, and a general destination. It did not name passengers. The analyst warned the team that a fuel issue could support a journey but could not prove that the vehicle had travelled to the place written in the ledger.

A retired driver, Mr. Tetteh, agreed to review the relevant page. He recognised the format but not the particular entry. He explained that a driver might collect fuel for a scheduled trip that was later cancelled, or use a vehicle for a different task if an officer changed the plan. The destination was sometimes written before departure and corrected later.

“Would a correction always be initialled?” Badu asked.

“It should be. If the office was busy, the driver might make the note at the end of the day. That was bad practice, but it happened.”

The analyst placed the ledger beside the clinic appointment book and the school register. The dates overlapped, but the times did not align cleanly. The clinic recorded an appointment slot, the school recorded the time a notice was entered, and the transport ledger recorded fuel rather than departure. Each document answered a different question. Treating them as though they shared one clock had created a false sense of precision.

Mabel asked Mr. Tetteh whether he remembered a child travelling in the vehicle. He shook his head. He had driven many routes and did not want to attach a face to an entry simply because the investigation had supplied a name. He offered to review the duty allocation sheets, but warned that they listed assigned staff, not necessarily the people who completed a trip.

The analyst rebuilt the timeline with separate columns for event date, record date, recorded time, and confidence level. Two events previously shown as consecutive now overlapped within a broad window. Another could not be placed at all. Badu instructed the team to preserve the earlier timeline as a superseded working version rather than erase it. The correction

itself might later matter if someone asked how the investigation had reached a particular assumption.

When the meeting ended, Mabel understood that a timeline could look authoritative simply because it was drawn in straight lines. Their new chart was messier, with gaps and ranges, but it was more faithful to the evidence. It did not tell them what had happened. It showed exactly where the records stopped telling them.

PART FOUR

Chapter Sixteen — The Person in the Photograph

The photograph arrived in a plain envelope without a return address. It reached the newspaper office shortly after midday and passed through reception to Mabel with the internal mail. She placed it between a staff notice and an article proof. Nothing about it announced that it might change the investigation.

Mabel did not open it alone. She called Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu and asked him to come to the office. Until he arrived, she photographed the envelope where it lay, noted the time, and asked reception to preserve the delivery log and any available camera footage. The steps felt almost absurdly formal for a thin envelope, but the anonymous sender had repeatedly tried to control the pace and direction of their work. They had agreed not to let another unexplained item become an exception to their own procedures.

Badu arrived twenty minutes later with a document sleeve and a small evidence label. “Who handled it?” he asked.

“Reception, then the office messenger, then me. I have names and times. I haven't opened it.”

“Good. We'll record that and be precise about what we can and cannot recover.” He examined the exterior without turning it over more than necessary. No obvious writing showed through the paper. The tape was ordinary stationery tape, and the envelope had no visible stamp. It could have been delivered by hand or placed in the newspaper's outgoing tray by someone with access. The delivery log might narrow the possibilities, but it would not identify the sender by itself.

Inside was a single photographic print and a note folded once. The print showed five children standing in a row outside a low building. Behind them, a painted sign was partly hidden by a tree branch. The image was old enough for the edges to have yellowed, but the faces were clear in the original print. One child stood slightly apart from the others, looking away from the camera. At the back of the group, an adult figure had been caught at the edge of the frame, only one shoulder and part of a hand visible.

Mabel's first response was not recognition. It was the unsettling feeling that the photograph had been chosen because someone expected her to recognise it. She placed both hands flat on the desk and let herself look at the whole image before narrowing her attention to any one face.

The note contained seven words: “You were there when the picture was taken.”

Badu read it, then set it beside the photograph. “The sender states that you were there. The photograph does not establish that yet.”

“I know.” Mabel hated how quickly she had wanted to answer. There were fragments from her childhood that returned in flashes: a hot courtyard, the sound of a metal gate, adults speaking in low voices after they believed the children had gone to sleep. But a memory could be genuine and still attach itself to the wrong day or place. She had learned that after years of trying to reconstruct the hours surrounding Room Four. She would not let a stranger's caption become the frame around her own recollection.

They made a high-resolution copy of the photograph and recorded the dimensions, paper type, visible damage, and all writing on the reverse. The back carried a faint blue mark that might have been the remains of a studio stamp, but no readable date. A specialist would examine the print for clues about its age and production. Badu requested that the original remain sealed when not being examined, and Mabel wrote down every person who had seen it.

“Five children,” she said after the first record was complete. “That is what the sender wants us to notice.”

“Possibly. But five children in a photograph do not automatically mean the five children in the records. We need to identify the location, date, and people independently.”

The building was their first lead. Its low veranda and narrow windows did not resemble the current Haven House, which had been renovated twice since the period under investigation. Yet the sign behind the tree seemed to contain the letters H and A, or perhaps M and A. It could be a school, a home, a clinic, or a building with a different name altogether. Mabel enlarged the image on her screen, but each attempt to sharpen the sign produced more pixels, not more certainty.

Badu contacted the records manager and asked whether any officially held photographs accompanied the children’s home inspection reports. He also requested the relevant inspection index, not a list of names selected to fit the photograph. The distinction was important: if they asked for a particular person, an archivist might search only for that name and miss a record filed under the institution or date.

Mabel called Madam Efua Nyarko, the former Haven House matron, and described the building without showing her the photograph. She asked whether the home had used a photographer for group pictures. Madam Nyarko remembered occasional photographs at Christmas and at official visits, but she

warned that her memory of individual dates was poor. Some pictures had been kept in the office; others were taken away by visitors. She could not say whether the five children in the print had ever lived at Haven House.

“Do you remember a child who stood apart from the others?” Mabel asked.

“I remember many children who stood apart on some days,” the former matron replied. “That is not an identity. A child may be tired, frightened, angry, or simply looking at someone outside the frame. Please do not turn a posture into a history.”

The answer stayed with Mabel. The photograph invited a story: one child separated, four gathered together, an adult lurking at the edge. But the image could not tell them why the child looked away, who stood behind the camera, or what had happened before and after the shutter clicked.

That afternoon, Badu and Mabel visited the regional archive with a formal request for inspection photographs and the corresponding accession entries. The archivist brought out a catalogue volume and a box of contact sheets. Each item was logged before it was opened. The procedure took time, and the delay irritated Mabel until she remembered that the investigation depended on the same safeguards. An unlogged photograph could be challenged later; an

original removed from its folder could be misfiled or damaged.

The first contact sheets showed buildings, kitchens, beds, and groups of children. None matched the anonymous print exactly. In one image, five narrow beds stood in a dormitory; in another, six children lined up beneath a sign that was clearly legible. The archive's notes identified the dates and photographer for those images, but there was no matching print among them.

“Does that rule out Haven House?” Mabel asked.

“No,” said the archivist. “It means we have not found this photograph in this box. The archive is not complete, and the print may never have been part of an official collection.”

A separate register listed photographs loaned to visiting officials. Several entries were incomplete. One described a “group outside west building” but gave no names. The date fell within the broad period they were investigating, yet the reference code differed from 17-B. Badu asked for the entry to be copied and the original preserved. He did not announce that they had found the photograph's origin. They had found a possible lead that needed corroboration.

At the archive's reading table, Mabel studied the register's handwriting. The entry had been made in dark ink, with the date written in a different hand. A later note indicated that the photographs had been

returned, but there was no signature beside it. The missing signature might have been a clerical oversight. It might indicate a poorly maintained loan system. It did not, by itself, prove that anyone had stolen or concealed the photographs.

As they prepared to leave, the archivist asked whether they wanted to inspect a smaller envelope of loose prints that had been found inside the back cover of an unrelated album. The prints had no catalogue numbers and had been set aside pending identification. Badu agreed, provided they were logged and examined under supervision.

The envelope contained eight prints. The first showed a gate. The second showed a room with a table and two chairs. The third was a close view of a wall calendar. The fourth showed the same low building as the anonymous photograph, but from the opposite side. The sign was less obscured. It read “Haven House,” though the first word was partly covered by a strip of peeling paint.

Mabel felt the room contract around her. She did not touch the print. She waited while the archivist entered it into the temporary inspection log and placed it beside the anonymous image. The windows, veranda posts, and sloping roof appeared to match. Even so, the print had no date or names. It established that the building was likely Haven House; it did not

establish who the children were or whether the two photographs had been taken on the same day.

The fifth print showed the children from the anonymous photograph, but the angle was wider. The adult figure at the edge of the first image was now visible from the waist up. The person's face was turned away. In one hand was a flat folder with a pale label. The label was too small to read, but its rectangular shape resembled the file covers used in old administrative offices.

Mabel's breathing slowed as she forced herself to look carefully. The person wore no uniform. There was no clear badge, no readable name, no feature that could reliably identify them. The folder might be important, or it might be an ordinary clipboard. A photograph could suggest a question; it could not answer it without support.

Badu asked the archivist to document the envelope's condition and the order in which the loose prints had been found. The prints were not automatically part of the same event merely because they had been stored together. Their paper stock and processing marks might help establish whether they came from one batch. The archivist agreed to consult a photographic conservator and search the acquisition records for the album's previous owner.

On the drive back, Mabel said, “I think I remember the gate.”

Badu kept his eyes on the road. “What do you remember about it?”

“Not a date. Not a person. The sound when it closed. And a shadow on the ground that moved across the courtyard.” She paused. “But I may be remembering the gate from another day. I need to write it down before I start fitting it to the picture.”

“Write the memory exactly as it comes. Put the photograph beside it as a separate event. If a connection emerges, we record how it emerged.”

That evening, Mabel made two entries in her notebook. Under “Memory,” she recorded the gate, the sound, the shadow, and her uncertainty. Under “Photograph,” she recorded the visible facts: five children, a building likely to be Haven House, an adult partly visible in one image and more fully visible in another, and a folder with an unreadable label. She added what remained unknown: date, identities, photographer, purpose of the visit, and whether the folder related to the missing records.

She then called Daniel Sarpong. She did not send him the photograph or tell him what she hoped he might see. She asked whether he remembered any group photograph taken at Haven House, and whether he recalled a visitor carrying a folder. Daniel took a long time to answer. He remembered being made to stand for photographs on more than one occasion, but he could not recall the dates. He remembered adults

who came to inspect the building and adults who came to speak privately with the matron. He could not say that the person in the print was one of them.

“Don't ask me to name a face from a picture I haven't seen,” he said. “I have spent too long being told what my own past means. If you want my help, let me say what I know and what I don't.”

Mabel apologised. She understood. “That is exactly what I want.”

Before the call ended, Daniel added one detail. In one of the old photographs, he thought he had once seen a small table placed near the west veranda, with papers stacked beneath a cloth. He could not remember whether the table was present on the day of a group photograph or whether the memory belonged to a different visit. Mabel wrote it down as an unverified recollection, not as confirmation of the folder in the image.

The next morning, the photographic conservator reported that the anonymous print and the loose archive prints appeared to use similar paper, but the finding was preliminary. Similar paper could be sold for years, and the prints might have been made by the same studio at different times. The conservator found no reliable date stamp and no evidence that the note had been attached to the photograph when it was first developed.

The search for related images produced a group photograph from a community event held near the same period. The building in the background had a similar window pattern, but the angle and later renovations prevented a firm match. The photographer’s name was printed on the mount, giving the team a possible source for original negatives or a studio register. Investigators contacted the studio’s successor and asked whether any records had survived. Mabel did not publish the photograph while that inquiry was underway. She knew that naming a child from a blurred image could expose an innocent person to years of speculation. The image remained a lead, and its caption continued to state what could be seen rather than what the team hoped it meant.

The studio search remained open, but the photograph was not used to identify anyone publicly. Mabel added a reminder to the file that a resemblance was not an identification. Until a reliable source confirmed the image’s date and location, it would remain a supporting lead.

The photograph remained private until its provenance could be independently established.

Badu read the report and placed it with the other evidence. “We have a probable location and a group of related images. We do not yet have a date, names, or proof that the folder is connected to 17-B.”

Mabel looked again at the child standing apart. She could not tell whether the child was frightened, distracted, or simply looking toward someone outside the frame. She could not tell whether the adult was watching the children or waiting for the photographer to finish. The image had given them a place to investigate, not a verdict.

The anonymous sender had tried to make the photograph a test of Mabel's memory. Instead, it had become a test of the investigation's discipline. The next step was clear: trace the loose prints' provenance, identify the photographer if possible, and compare the date range against the official visitor records. Only then could they ask whether the person carrying the folder was connected to the altered files.

As Mabel closed her notebook, a new message appeared on her phone. It contained no photograph this time, only a sentence: “You have found the right building. Now find the day.”

She showed it to Badu and logged it. He looked from the message to the archive reference and then to the anonymous print.

“The sender knows what we found,” Mabel said.

“Or the sender knows what they sent us would lead here.”

“Do you think they are helping us?”

Before the preliminary hearing, Mabel met with her legal representative to review the difference between memory and inference. She was asked to identify which details she had seen herself, which she had read in the records, and which she had heard from another person. The questions were not designed to undermine her. They were meant to prevent a confident answer from concealing several different sources. Mabel practised saying “I do not remember” without adding an explanation that might sound like an excuse.

At the hearing, the chairperson clarified that the session was not a criminal trial and that no finding of guilt would be made on the basis of a single disputed document. The purpose was to determine what records were available, how they had been handled, and which questions required further investigation. Mabel’s statement was read in the form in which it had been preserved. When she corrected a date she had previously given from memory, the correction was recorded alongside the original rather than substituted silently.

A representative asked whether she had ever discussed Room Four with Daniel before the investigation. She answered that they had spoken about Haven House but had not agreed on the details of the missing file. She could not guarantee that their conversations had never influenced their recollections, and she did not pretend otherwise. The

answer felt risky, but it was accurate. The chairperson asked that the possibility of shared information be considered when the accounts were compared.

Outside the room, a reporter asked Mabel whether she had finally proved that officials had hidden a child. She refused the wording. The hearing had established that the records were inconsistent and that her childhood statement deserved proper examination. It had not yet established who changed the record or why. She gave a brief statement about the need to protect witnesses and preserve documents, then left without adding a dramatic conclusion. For once, she did not feel that restraint was surrender. It was the only way she could keep her testimony useful.

“I think they are trying to influence us. Whether that helps or harms the investigation depends on what we can verify.” He returned the phone. “We will find the day through records, not because an anonymous person tells us to.”

For the first time since the envelope arrived, Mabel felt that the photograph had become less powerful. It was no longer a mysterious image demanding that she remember. It was an object with a location, a chain of custody, related prints, and questions that could be tested. The person in the photograph remained unidentified. The folder remained unreadable. But the search had moved from the sender's suggestion to a

set of independent tasks—and that was a kind of progress.

The examiner made a working copy of the photograph and separated the visible features from the assumptions people had already attached to it. The image showed a corridor, a doorway, and several figures too small for reliable identification. One figure appeared to carry a folder. The angle made the object look rectangular, but the examiner warned that it could have been a file, a book, or another item of similar size. The photograph’s mystery lay partly in how easily a viewer could supply what the image did not show.

Mabel visited the newspaper’s old photography desk and asked whether any negatives from the relevant period survived. The archive assistant found a box of contact sheets with incomplete labels. Several frames showed the exterior of Haven House during a public inspection, but none matched the corridor image exactly. The contact sheets were photographed in place, and the assistant documented the box’s location before it was returned to storage.

A retired photographer remembered that reporters had sometimes been allowed into the public rooms but not the residential wing. He could not say who had taken the anonymous image. He explained that photographs were occasionally copied from contact

sheets when the original negative was missing, and the resulting copy could lose information around the edges. That possibility mattered because the doorway in the anonymous photograph was partly cropped.

The team examined the back of the print under magnification. It contained no reliable date stamp, only a faint pencil mark that might have been a number. The paper type was common in the period and could not narrow the date to a particular day. The examiner recorded the mark but did not treat it as a reference until a comparable sample could be found.

Daniel studied the image with his lawyer beside him. He said the corridor felt familiar, but he could not identify the people. Mabel watched his face and realised how much pressure a photograph could place on a person asked to remember childhood. A familiar doorway could prompt a true memory, a mistaken association, or a feeling with no clear source. Badu asked Daniel to describe only what he could state without guessing.

Daniel described a window at the end of the passage and a patch of sunlight on the floor. Those details did not appear clearly in the photograph, and the current building had been altered. The examiner said they could be checked against older plans, but even a match would establish the layout, not the identity of the figures. Daniel agreed to have his account recorded with that limitation.

Mabel wrote a note for the newspaper editor explaining why the image could not yet be published as proof of a person’s presence. The editor was disappointed; a dramatic photograph would attract attention. But the newspaper agreed to hold it until the provenance and context were better understood. Mabel knew that withholding an image could frustrate readers. Publishing it prematurely could also turn an uncertain outline into a public accusation.

At the end of the day, the photograph was returned to its sleeve, and the working copies were logged. It had provided a corridor to investigate and a reason to search the photographic archive. It had not named the person in the image. That unanswered question remained important precisely because the team had resisted the urge to fill it with a convenient name.

The Photographic Archive

The municipal photographic archive occupied two rooms behind the records office. A curator named Mr. Addo brought out contact sheets from the period when Haven House had been photographed for a public works report. He wore cotton gloves and placed each sheet under a clear cover before turning it toward the team. The photographs had been catalogued by project, not by building, so the search required them to check images of drainage work, road repairs, and school visits as well as the children’s home itself.

One contact sheet showed the east corridor from the opposite direction. The window Daniel remembered was visible, although the partition line had changed. Another image showed a group of officials standing near a doorway. The faces were too small to identify, and the print had no reliable date beyond the year assigned to the project folder.

“Could this be the same day?” Mabel asked.

“It could be from the same period,” Addo replied. “The catalogue date is not always the date the photograph was taken. Sometimes it is the date the film was developed or donated.”

The curator showed them the accession card. It had been rewritten after a water leak damaged the original card. The new card listed the project title and the donor’s office, but not the photographer. A separate box contained envelopes of negatives, though the labels were incomplete.

Badu requested a controlled scan of the relevant frames and a search of the donation ledger. He also asked that the original contact sheet remain in the archive unless a court order required otherwise. The team did not need to remove an object to study it; they needed a documented image and a clear account of how it had been produced.

While the scanner warmed, Daniel looked at the corridor image. “I think I remember the window,” he

said, then corrected himself. “I recognise the shape. I cannot say the photograph proves I was there.”

No one pressed him. The curator recorded his statement as a present-day response to the image, not as an identification of the people shown. The scan revealed a faint handwritten number on the back, but it did not match any accession number in the current catalogue. Addo agreed to check old donation ledgers for the same notation.

The archive had provided a possible link between the building and the photograph, but not a person, date, or event. As they left, Mabel wrote down the three separate questions the image raised. She had learned to distrust the moment when a photograph seemed to answer everything at once.

The notice arrived on a Tuesday, printed on plain paper and delivered through the proper channel. Mabel Owusu was requested to attend a preliminary hearing concerning the handling of records connected to the former Haven House Children’s Home. The notice did not call her a suspect or promise that her account would settle anything. It said only that her evidence might assist the review of disputed records and that she could bring a legal representative.

She read it at the kitchen table twice. The first time, she noticed the date. The second, she noticed the words ‘subject to questions’. They seemed harmless enough, but she remembered the last time adults had asked her to describe what she saw as a child. Her words had been written down, shortened, and eventually treated as though she had said something different.

Kwame Badu did not tell her to attend or to refuse. He explained what the notice meant and encouraged

her to seek independent legal advice. ‘You are not there to help us by saying what we want to hear,’ he said. ‘You are there to give your own account. If you do not remember, say so. If you are unsure, say so. If a question is unclear, ask for it to be repeated.’

‘And if they tell me I have remembered it wrong?’ Mabel asked.

‘They may challenge your memory. That is different from proving it wrong. You should not argue beyond what you know. The records must be examined alongside your testimony.’

She contacted a lawyer who had no involvement in the original investigation. He reviewed the notice and met her for an hour. He did not rehearse answers with her. Instead, he asked her to describe the limits of her recollection, the conditions in which she had made her earlier statement, and the ways her memory might have been influenced by later discoveries. It was uncomfortable, but it was fairer than pretending memory was a recording that had never changed.

By the time Mabel returned to Badu’s office, she had written a short list in her notebook: what I saw; what I heard; what I was told later; what I inferred; what I cannot remember. She showed it to him.

‘That is a useful distinction,’ he said. ‘Keep it with you. Do not let anyone merge those categories.’

The hearing took place in a modest room in the administrative complex. There were no cameras, no crowd, and no dramatic announcement. A panel chair explained that the session was preliminary and that its purpose was to clarify the record trail, not to decide criminal responsibility. A clerk recorded attendance. Mabel's lawyer sat beside her, and Badu waited outside until he was called to provide information about the investigation's chain of custody.

The first questions concerned her earlier statement. Mabel confirmed that she had been a child when she saw an adult remove a file from a room she understood to be Room Four. She remembered the file's shape, the movement of the adult's arm, and a brief argument between two adults. She could not confidently identify the person carrying the file. She could not state the exact date without relying on records she had seen as an adult.

'Did you see the person alter a document?' the panel's counsel asked.

'No,' Mabel said. 'I saw a file being removed. I heard an argument. I did not see anyone write on or change a page.'

'Did you hear someone say that a child's name had been changed?'

Mabel paused. 'I remember words about a name and a record. I cannot honestly say that I remember the exact sentence. I have seen the disputed records

since then, and I do not want to confuse what I learned later with what I heard that day.'

The clerk wrote for several seconds. Mabel watched the pen move and felt an old tightness in her shoulders. She asked that her answer be read back. The clerk did so, and Mabel requested one correction: the note said she 'believed' the room was Room Four. She explained that, as a child, she had known it by that name because adults used it, but she could not independently confirm the room's official designation from memory alone.

The correction was made. It was a small act, but it mattered. The written record would now show the difference between her childhood understanding and the present-day question about the room's official use.

Questions turned to the photograph of five children. Mabel was shown a copy that had been recovered through the inquiry. She recognised the general arrangement of the children but would not identify every face. She said the image stirred a memory of a photographer visiting the home, though she could not fix the year. The adult near the edge of the frame was partly obscured. She could not identify that person from the image alone.

'You have previously said the photograph reminded you of the day the file was removed,' counsel said. 'Does that mean the events happened on the same day?'

‘No. It means the photograph reminds me of that period. I cannot say the events were on the same day.’

‘But you suspect they were connected?’

‘I think the possibility should be investigated. That is not the same as knowing they were connected.’

Her lawyer did not interrupt. The panel chair nodded and asked the clerk to preserve the distinction in the transcript. Mabel felt no triumph. She had not delivered the revelation that some people seemed to want from her. She had done something harder: she had refused to make her memory more certain than it was.

Badu was called next. He described how the team had obtained copies of the accession book and movement index, how each document had been logged, and why the team had not treated the initials K. Mensah as proof that Inspector K. B. Mensah personally handled the bundle. He explained that the original movement slip had not yet been located and that the registry’s code ‘R.A.’ had several possible meanings.

A panel member asked whether the anonymous message stating ‘The signature was never his’ had been authenticated.

‘No,’ Badu answered. ‘We have preserved the message and referred its technical aspects for examination. At present, we cannot establish who sent

it, which signature it refers to, or whether the claim is true.’

‘Does the investigation regard it as evidence?’

‘It is evidence that an anonymous message was received. The assertion within it remains unverified. We are following it as a lead, not presenting it as proof of forgery.’

Mabel listened from the waiting area. She had feared that the process would turn every uncertain detail into a fixed accusation. Instead, the questions forced the investigators to label their uncertainties. That did not guarantee justice, but it made it harder for a guess to travel through the system disguised as fact.

During a break, a registry officer approached Mabel. He introduced himself as the official who had arranged the index copy. He said he had not expected her to be so cautious about her own testimony.

The evidence examiner began by separating the material into three groups: original records, copies whose source could be verified, and copies whose origin remained uncertain. Mabel had expected the discussion to focus on the most mysterious page. Instead, the examiner spent nearly an hour on the routine documents that established who had received each item and when. Without those ordinary records, even a remarkable discovery could be challenged as something inserted after the investigation began.

The examiner demonstrated how a photocopier could thicken a faint line or close the gap between two separate marks. A handwritten five might look like an S when the copy was darkened; a crease could resemble a stroke of ink. The team agreed that enhanced images would be supplied with the original scans and a note describing the process. No image would be presented as though it were the paper itself. The same care applied to transcribed words: uncertain letters would be marked as uncertain, not silently completed.

Badu asked whether the evidence could establish that the missing name had been deliberately removed. The examiner replied that the surviving materials showed a gap and an irregular sequence, but intention required more than the physical condition of a page. A leaf might have been removed for a reason unrelated to the child’s identity, and the remaining records did not establish when the removal occurred. Investigators would need testimony, access records, and perhaps evidence of a later attempt to conceal the gap before making a stronger claim.

Mabel revised the evidence schedule while the discussion was still fresh. Beside each item she added a line headed LIMITS. The work was slower than writing a narrative, but it stopped the case from promising more than it could deliver. At the end of the meeting, the team had no single document that solved the mystery. They had something more defensible: a

map of what was known, what remained disputed, and what evidence might resolve each uncertainty.

‘People have told this story for years,’ he said. ‘I thought you would remember more.’

‘People have told me what they think happened for years,’ Mabel replied. ‘That does not make their versions my memories.’

The officer looked embarrassed. ‘I did not mean to criticise you.’

‘I know. But if you write down that I remembered something, please write down exactly what I said.’

He promised he would. She did not assume the promise guaranteed anything. She had learned to ask for the record to be read back.

When the hearing resumed, the panel examined the two versions of the monthly summary. One listed five beds in the dormitory inventory; another listed four occupied beds and one bed marked ‘temporarily unavailable’. Neither document identified a fifth child by name. The panel asked whether the discrepancy established that a child had been concealed.

‘No,’ Badu said. ‘It establishes a discrepancy in the records. We need to identify the purpose of each form, who completed it, and whether the figures refer to beds, residents, or a different reporting period.’

Mabel added, when invited to clarify her own knowledge, that she remembered children moving

between sleeping spaces during periods of repair. She could not say whether that practice explained the entries. She had not seen the original forms being completed and did not know who had approved them.

The panel requested the underlying registers, staff rosters, maintenance notes, and any instructions explaining the forms. It also asked the registry to preserve the originals and record every person who handled them from that point onward. For the first time, the inquiry's requests were not limited to the suspicious page. They reached the ordinary documents that might explain it.

After the session, Mabel and Badu met in the courtyard. He had kept his questions to the evidence and had not tried to guide her account. She thanked him for that.

'You should not have to thank me for it,' he said. 'It is the minimum.'

'The minimum was missing before.'

He did not argue. His father's name remained somewhere inside the same chain of records, and neither of them could yet say whether Emmanuel Badu had been misrepresented, used without his knowledge, or involved in a decision that later harmed a child. Kwame had insisted that the investigation not protect his father by avoiding the question, but he would not condemn him simply because the initials looked familiar.

Mabel asked whether he believed the hearing had helped.

‘It has narrowed what we can responsibly claim,’ he said. ‘That is progress, even if it does not feel like an answer.’

After the hearing, Mabel read the transcript and identified two places where her spoken answer had been shortened in the summary. The differences did not reverse her meaning, but she requested that the full answer be attached so the context would remain available. The clerk accepted the request and recorded the amendment without deleting the first version. Mabel felt relief that a correction could be made openly rather than hidden. Badu later told her that the transcript process mattered because future readers might rely on a single sentence without hearing the question that preceded it. The hearing had not resolved the case, but it had created a more reliable record of what Mabel actually said.

The amended transcript was stored with the original and the correction request. Mabel kept a copy for her own records, aware that a faithful transcript was not the same as a perfect memory. It was, however, a fairer account of what she had actually said.

The corrected transcript would travel with the original, preserving the full history of the evidence.

Her phone vibrated before they reached the gate. The unknown sender had written: ‘You told them what you remember. Did you tell them what you forgot?’

Mabel stopped. The message was designed to make caution sound like guilt. It suggested that uncertainty itself was suspicious, that any gap in memory must hide a secret. She showed it to Badu without replying.

He logged the time and asked her to preserve the message. ‘Do not answer. We cannot know whether the sender has any information about the hearing or is simply guessing. The timing is concerning, but we must establish how they could have known.’

‘Could someone in the room have sent it?’

‘Possibly. So could someone who saw the notice, someone monitoring a public schedule, or someone who guessed that you would be questioned. We will check access, not assume.’

They reported the message through the established channel. The inquiry’s clerk confirmed that the hearing attendance list was restricted, but the date of the session had appeared on a general administrative calendar. That did not explain the message, but it offered an ordinary route by which someone might have anticipated the event. The investigators recorded both possibilities and requested the relevant access logs.

That evening, Mabel read the draft transcript supplied for her review. One sentence had been compressed: ‘I cannot confidently identify the person carrying the file’ had become ‘I could not identify the person.’ The meaning was close, but the shorter version erased the distinction between then and now. She marked it for correction and attached a note explaining why the wording mattered.

Her lawyer approved the request. The clerk confirmed the amendment would be considered before the transcript was finalised. Mabel placed the pages in a folder and labelled it ‘Hearing—draft, corrections pending’. She did not file it with the original childhood statement. One was a new account made as an adult; the other was a record of what had been said years earlier. They could be compared, but they should not be merged.

The next morning, the panel issued a short direction. It did not make findings about who had changed the records. It required the registry to locate the original movement slip or certify the steps taken to search for it; to explain the code R.A. from the relevant year’s manual; and to provide the full context for both monthly summaries. The direction also required that Mabel’s corrected transcript preserve her distinction between direct memory and later inference.

Badu read the direction in silence, then placed it in the case file. ‘This gives us three specific things to verify.’

‘And if the slip is never found?’ Mabel asked.

‘Then we document the search, identify who was responsible for keeping it, and test the other records independently. A missing document is not a blank cheque for a theory.’

Mabel looked toward the window. The investigation was moving slowly, and the anonymous sender continued to push at her uncertainty. But the hearing had produced a more reliable account, a clear list of records to be obtained, and a written instruction that the original documents be preserved. The truth had not appeared in one dramatic statement. It was being approached through corrections, limitations, and questions that remained open.

Before leaving, she added a line to her notebook: ‘Under oath, I did not become more certain. I became more exact.’ Beneath it she wrote the next question: who had access to the hearing notice, and who knew enough about the disputed records to turn a gap in memory into a threat?

For now, she would not answer it. She had learned what happened when someone filled a gap too quickly. The next step was to follow the record, wherever it led—even if it led to a name she feared, a person she trusted, or no name at all.

Chapter Eighteen — What the Record Can Prove

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The conference room had no windows, only a clock that ran three minutes fast and a long table polished so often that the wood seemed almost black. Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu had requested the room because he wanted every document laid out where all present could see it. No one was to leave with a private interpretation that could not survive a question from someone else.

Mabel arrived carrying the evidence schedule she had prepared. Each item had a reference number, a source, a date of receipt, and a short statement describing what it could establish. She had learned to distrust dramatic summaries. A document described as ‘proof of the fifth child’ could turn out to be a list of beds, a list of names, or a list copied from another list. The difference mattered.

Present were Badu, the records manager from the regional registry, a document examiner, and the lawyer assigned to advise the inquiry. The examiner

had not been asked to identify a culprit. His task was narrower: compare the available copies, assess the visible alterations, and explain what could and could not be said about the writing and paper.

He began with the two versions of the monthly summary. The totals differed by one. In the first copy, the attendance total had been entered in blue ink; in the second, the number was darker and the final digit had a different shape. The difference was real, but the copies alone could not show when it was made or who made it. Neither copy was the original sheet.

“So somebody changed the number,” Mabel said.

“The copies show different numbers,” the examiner replied. “That is the secure statement. It is reasonable to investigate whether one was changed, but I cannot identify the sequence without the original or a reliable history of the copies.”

Badu nodded. “Put that distinction in the report. We are not asking you to make the evidence stronger than it is.”

Next came the movement index. The code 17-B appeared in the register, and a damaged destination column carried the letters R.A. The examiner said the mark beside the entry might be a signature or a notation, but the photocopy lacked enough detail for a firm opinion. The partial signature did not match any sample in a way that justified identification. There

were too few comparable features, and the quality of the copy was poor.

The registry manager confirmed that a second register contained a reference to the same number under another date. The entries might concern the same bundle, but the link had not yet been established by a continuous chain of custody. The manager could confirm the register existed and where it had been kept in recent years. He could not say who had handled it before the office reorganisation.

Mabel watched the claims shrink to their proper size. It was frustrating, but it also gave the investigation a shape. Instead of one enormous theory about a secret file and a hidden child, they had a series of specific questions: what did 17-B describe, where had the bundle gone, why did the dates differ, and whose authority had been recorded on the movement slip?

The examiner opened the carton only after photographing the seal and confirming that the number matched the transfer sheet. Inside were folded schedules, a thin exercise book, and several envelopes that had stuck together at the edges. The team did not pull them apart. Each item was photographed in place, assigned a temporary position number, and lifted with tools appropriate to its condition. The exercise book’s cover bore a faded institutional stamp, but the stamp was incomplete and

could not independently establish where the book had been used.

The first schedule listed four beds in a room and five children under a broader heading. At first glance, the difference looked like the missing link. The archivist warned that the headings might refer to different dates or categories: beds available on one day, children registered during a period, or children considered in a review. The team checked the reverse of the sheet and found a small note referring to a continuation page that was not in the carton. The missing continuation could explain the layout—or deepen the problem.

Daniel asked to see the schedule. His lawyer reminded him that viewing it could influence his memory, so Badu explained that he was free to decline. Daniel chose to look but made no identification. He said the handwriting on one line seemed familiar, then corrected himself: it resembled the writing he remembered from childhood forms, but he could not say that it was the same hand. The statement was recorded with that qualification. No one asked him to guess which child had occupied which bed.

Mabel compared the schedule with the visitor register and the two versions of the day. The records supported the possibility that a fifth child had been included in an administrative review even though

only four beds were listed in that particular document. They did not establish whether the fifth child was Daniel, another child, or a category carried forward from a different date. The phrase “fifth child” had become a powerful label, but the evidence still required the team to ask the harder question: fifth in which list, on which day, and according to whose definition?

The lawyer asked about the photograph of the five children. The image had been found in an envelope with no original label. A faint mark on the reverse might have been a date, but it was incomplete. The photograph could support the claim that five children had been photographed together. It could not, by itself, identify all five children, prove they occupied five beds at Haven House, or establish that any one of them was the child referred to in the confidential review.

“And the adult at the edge?” the lawyer asked.

“The image is too soft for identification,” the examiner said. “The figure appears to hold a rectangular object, but I cannot confidently call it a file. It could be a folder, a book, or something else.”

Mabel looked at the image. In memory, the adult had become taller and more threatening over the years. In the photograph, the person was a blur at the edge of the frame. She felt embarrassed by the distance between the image and the certainty she had

once attached to it, then reminded herself that memory was not a courtroom exhibit. It was a starting point that required careful testing.

Badu asked her to describe what she remembered without looking at the photograph. She did. She remembered being told to wait near a doorway, the smell of floor polish, and an adult voice saying that the list had to be corrected before morning. She did not remember the speaker's face. She could not swear that the voice belonged to any named person. She had first connected the words to the file only years later, after she learned what Room Four meant.

"That is useful," Badu said. "Not because it gives us a name, but because you have separated the memory from the later interpretation."

The anonymous messages were considered last. Their sender had supplied details that appeared to anticipate the investigation, but no message had yet been independently authenticated as coming from a person with direct knowledge of the original events. The sender might be a witness, a former employee, someone repeating old gossip, or someone deliberately steering the inquiry. Until their identity and source were established, the messages could guide searches but could not settle facts.

The meeting ended with a written list of actions. The registry would preserve the original registers and provide supervised access. The examiner would

inspect the original movement slip if located. The inquiry would trace the office code R.A. through contemporary directories rather than assume its meaning. Mabel’s statement would be preserved in her own words, with later deductions separately labelled. The photograph would be examined for provenance, not used as a shortcut to identification.

After the others left, Mabel remained beside the table. “We have so many pieces, and none of them tells us who did it.”

The team tested its draft summary by asking an officer who had not worked on the case to identify which claims were supported directly and which relied on interpretation. He marked several sentences that sounded certain but were based on only one source. Mabel revised them, replacing “the record proves” with “the record is consistent with” where appropriate. The changes made the report less forceful but more accurate. Badu insisted that the same standard apply to evidence that seemed to implicate a person and evidence that might clear them. The final schedule would show both strengths and weaknesses. It was not the task of the investigation to make every document fit one explanation; it was to test explanations against the documents.

The final schedule identified the source behind each conclusion: recollection where the claim came from a witness, and a reference number where it

came from a document. This made it harder for interpretation to masquerade as fact.

“That is where we are,” Badu said. “A case is not improved by pretending we have reached a place we have not reached.”

He gathered the papers into separate folders. One held confirmed records, another held disputed copies, and a third held leads requiring verification. The arrangement looked less satisfying than a wall covered in red string, but it was harder to deceive.

At the door, the registry manager returned with a message he had received from an archivist at the central depot. A storage carton listed in the old catalogue had been located in a section scheduled for reorganisation. The carton’s label was incomplete, but its number corresponded to the second register entry. No one had opened it yet.

Badu asked the manager to secure it and document everyone who handled it. He did not ask what was inside. That answer would come only after the carton was examined under a proper record of custody.

Mabel left the room with a new understanding of what the records could prove. They had not named the person who changed the papers. They had shown where the question could be tested next. For the first time in weeks, the next step did not depend on an

anonymous message. It depended on a carton in an archive, waiting to be opened in front of witnesses.

The registrar did not close the hearing immediately. She asked the parties to identify which exhibits had been admitted as originals, which were certified copies, and which remained provisional. The distinction slowed the room, but it also prevented the record from becoming a collection of papers whose authority nobody could explain.

Badu listened while the clerk read each exhibit number aloud. The photocopy of the movement index was marked provisional because the original had not yet been produced. The catalogue card was admitted only to show that a reference had existed in the archive system, not to prove the contents of the missing bundle. Mabel’s statement was evidence of what she remembered and of the steps she had taken to preserve her account; it was not a substitute for a document that had never been found.

Counsel for the records office objected when a witness described the initials beside the transfer entry as Mensah’s signature. The chair sustained the objection. The witness had recognised the letters, not the hand. That correction irritated the people who wanted the hearing to produce a single dramatic answer, but Badu quietly wrote it down. A boundary stated in public was harder to erase later.

During the break, a junior clerk approached Badu with a question about the numbering of the exhibits. She had noticed that one page in the copied index carried a faint pencil mark that did not appear in the office’s digital scan. She was careful not to suggest what it meant. She simply asked whether the original had been photographed under raking light, a technique that could sometimes reveal pressure marks left by writing on a sheet above it.

“Has anyone done that?” Badu asked.

“Not that I can see in the file,” she replied. “The scan is flat. It captures the ink, but not the surface.”

Badu thanked her and requested that the point be recorded as a technical lead. He did not allow the clerk to handle the exhibit again, and he did not promise that the mark would reveal anything useful. The original would need to be examined by a qualified document specialist, with its condition recorded before and after the process.

When the hearing resumed, the chair ordered the registry to preserve the original index, if located, and any associated transfer slips. The order did not declare that the records had been falsified. It required the office to retain potentially relevant material while the dispute was investigated. For the first time, the process had produced a practical safeguard rather than another argument about memory.

Mabel watched the clerk write the order into the minutes. The language was dry, almost painfully ordinary. Yet a preservation order could protect a fragile page from being discarded, cleaned, or altered while everyone debated its meaning. It gave the investigation a chance to ask the next question without losing the object needed to answer it.

Outside the room, a reporter asked whether the hearing had proved that a child’s identity had been changed. Badu declined to turn an interim proceeding into a verdict. He said that the hearing had clarified the status of several records and established steps for preserving them. The question of who had altered any record, if an alteration had occurred, remained open.

The examiner arranged the documents in a sequence that followed their custody rather than the theory of the case. First came the box intake sheet, then the depot transfer receipt, then the catalogue card, then the register extract. A gap appeared between the transfer receipt and the catalogue card: the surviving paperwork did not show who had carried the packet across that interval. The gap was real, but it did not identify the person responsible. The examiner wrote “custody not documented in surviving material” on the chart instead of using the more dramatic phrase “file stolen.” Badu insisted that the wording remain exact.

They tested the numbering system against unrelated files from the same period. Several records used a letter that looked like the number eight, and at least one catalogue entry had been corrected after a routine audit. That comparison weakened the claim that every mismatch had been created to hide the fifth child. Some errors were ordinary. The question was whether the disputed records showed a pattern beyond the error rate found in comparable files. The analyst asked for more samples before offering an opinion. Mabel understood that the answer they wanted would take longer because it had to survive comparison with evidence that had nothing to do with their preferred theory.

A senior officer asked whether the team could now identify the person who altered the register. The examiner said the present material could not support that conclusion. The page contained more than one writing instrument, but no reliable method could assign each mark to a named person from the available samples. A correction could have been made by an authorised clerk, an unauthorised employee, or someone whose role was not recorded. The team recorded each possibility and listed what evidence might distinguish them: staff rosters, procedure manuals, handwriting samples, and testimony from those who handled the book.

At the end of the meeting, Badu asked every participant to state one conclusion they believed the

evidence supported and one conclusion it did not support. The answers were restrained. The packet had moved through several offices; the catalogue contained an unexplained discrepancy; the original register remained missing; and the identity of the person who made the disputed correction was not established. They could say those things publicly if required. They could not yet say who had arranged the substitution, who had known about it, or whether the same person was involved in Judge Agyeman's death.

Mabel later wrote the same distinction in her notebook. A record could be authentic and still contain a false statement. A copy could be accurate as a copy and still reproduce an earlier mistake. A witness could be honest and still be unable to identify the person who stood in a doorway decades before. The investigation had to hold all three possibilities at once.

The examiner asked the team to imagine that every document on the table had been created for a different purpose. A visitor register recorded entries; a transfer receipt documented movement; a maintenance slip described work on a building; a photograph preserved a scene from one angle. None had been designed to answer the whole question now before them. Their combined value depended on whether the separate records genuinely converged, not whether the investigators could tell a smooth story from them.

He demonstrated the point with two copies of the same page. One had been scanned in colour and the other photocopied in black and white. The pencil mark beside the disputed entry was clear in the first and nearly invisible in the second. If a clerk relied on the second copy, the mark might be missed. If an investigator relied on the colour copy alone, the mark might be given too much importance. The examiner logged both versions and recommended that the original be sought before any conclusion was drawn about the mark’s sequence or purpose.

The lawyer asked whether the discrepancies indicated deliberate alteration. The examiner answered that alteration was one possibility, but not the only one. A correction could be authorised and properly recorded; a copy could lose a mark; a clerk could misread a reference; or someone could change an entry without authority. The visible evidence had to be considered alongside procedure, witness accounts, and the history of each document.

Badu asked what could be stated confidently at that stage. The examiner listed only narrow findings: the copies differed; one reference was inconsistent across surviving indexes; the control book showed an entry with incomplete supporting information; and the available signatures did not permit a conclusive attribution. Each statement could be traced to an exhibit. None identified the person responsible for the original discrepancy.

Mabel prepared a revised evidence schedule. She removed adjectives such as “suspicious” and “secret” from the descriptions and replaced them with observable facts: “page absent from folder,” “reference differs by one character,” “recipient field blank,” and “date source uncertain.” The new schedule was less exciting to read. It was also harder to misuse because it did not smuggle an interpretation into the description of an object.

A senior officer asked whether the investigation was moving too slowly. Badu replied that speed would not repair a weak chain of reasoning. They could act quickly where evidence justified action, but they could not convert every inconsistency into proof of conspiracy. He requested a short list of the next three tests that could most clearly distinguish competing explanations: locate the original transfer receipt, identify the author of the correction entry if possible, and verify the access record against independent duty information.

The examiner agreed to produce a report that separated observations from opinions and opinions from limitations. The report would include the methods used, the items examined, and the reasons no definitive attribution could be made. The lawyer requested that any later review receive the same underlying materials, not just the conclusion. Badu approved both requests and added them to the action log.

When the meeting ended, Mabel looked at the evidence schedule and realised that its gaps were not empty spaces to be filled by imagination. They were instructions. Each gap named a question the team had to answer, or acknowledge it could not answer. The case had not become simpler, but it had become more disciplined.

The review team reconvened three days later to test whether the new action list had produced evidence or merely more requests. The registry had supplied a certified extract from the dispatch book, but the page was a summary prepared at the end of the month. The entry for the disputed envelope appeared beside two routine transfers and contained no description of the contents. The clerk who certified it explained that the extract reproduced the book faithfully; he could not certify that the original entry was accurate in every respect.

Badu asked the clerk to explain the difference. The clerk said certification meant that the copy matched the record held by the registry, not that the events recorded had necessarily occurred exactly as written. It was a distinction that sounded obvious when spoken aloud, yet the case had repeatedly shown how a certified document could be treated as if it settled every question. Mabel added the explanation to the schedule so no later summary would quietly turn a record of an entry into proof of the underlying event.

The team then compared the dispatch entry with a courier route sheet found in a separate office. The route sheet listed the building but not the envelope number. The courier’s initials appeared at the bottom, though the courier had since retired and could not be located. A former supervisor confirmed that the route sheets were completed after delivery, often from memory and from the order in which stops were made. The two records were compatible, but neither independently confirmed the envelope’s contents or its recipient.

The lawyer asked whether the combination was enough to conclude that the missing schedule had been sent. The examiner said it supported a possible transfer route, but the chain remained incomplete. The dispatch book described an envelope; the route sheet described a journey; the missing receipt would have linked the two. Without that link, the conclusion had to remain qualified. Badu instructed the clerk to preserve the original book and to search for any duplicate receipt filed under the destination office’s former name.

The exercise forced the team to revisit an earlier assumption. They had spoken of the schedule as though it had definitely travelled with the other papers. The procedure manual showed that schedules were sometimes dispatched separately, while the records now available showed only that an envelope had gone to a related office. It was possible that the

schedule was inside. It was also possible that the envelope contained something else. The team revised the case chronology to show both possibilities rather than presenting one as established fact.

Mabel drafted two paragraphs for the eventual public account. The first described what the records showed: a dispatch entry, a route sheet, and a missing receipt. The second explained what remained unknown: the contents of the envelope and whether it had reached the intended officer. Her editor suggested combining them into a sharper sentence. Mabel declined, explaining that the sharper version would imply a connection the evidence had not yet made. The editor accepted the distinction and asked her to keep the language accessible without making it more certain than the facts.

Before leaving, the examiner signed the updated schedule and listed the methods used to compare the copies. The lawyer checked that each conclusion referred to a specific exhibit. Badu authorised the next request for the original accession register and assigned an officer who had not previously handled the disputed documents. The investigation had gained a better map of the records, not a culprit. That was progress, even if it could not yet provide the answer Daniel wanted.

The Independent Review

The lawyer arranged an independent review of the evidence table before the team submitted its next report. The reviewer, a retired appellate registrar named Mrs. Serwaa Boateng, had no connection to Haven House and had not followed the investigation in the press. She asked to receive copies of the exhibits without the team's theory attached.

For two days she examined the transfer receipt, the route sheet, the access log, the disputed signature, and the different versions of Mabel's statement. When the team returned, she had written each proposed conclusion on a separate sheet and marked the source that supported it. Some conclusions had one source. Others depended on a chain of documents with a missing link.

"You have several records that are consistent with a transfer," she said. "You do not yet have a record that proves what was inside the envelope at each stage. You have a statement summary that names a person, and an earlier statement that does not. You have to explain that conflict rather than select the version that supports your theory."

Badu asked whether the gaps made the evidence unusable. Boateng said no. A gap did not automatically destroy a case, but it limited the claim that could safely be made. Independent evidence might later fill

the gap; if it did not, the final report would have to say what remained uncertain.

She also challenged the order in which the team had presented its findings. They had placed the anonymous message near the beginning, where it framed the records as a deliberate erasure. Boateng suggested starting with the authenticated documents and describing the message later as an unverified lead. The order mattered because readers often treated the first explanation as the lens through which every later fact should be read.

Mabel disliked how restrained the report would sound. It would not tell readers who had changed the name or why. But she could see that the stronger version was the one that survived a sceptical reader. She rewrote the introduction so it began with the conflicting records, not the anonymous accusation.

Boateng signed her review and noted that she had not independently verified every source; her task was to test whether the conclusions matched the material supplied. Badu added that qualification to the case file. The review did not solve the mystery, but it exposed where the investigation’s language had outrun its evidence. That correction gave the next stage a firmer foundation.

The carton arrived at the records examination room under seal the next morning. Its outer wrapping was old, the corners softened by years of storage, but the seal applied by the depot was intact. The archivist who had located it signed the transfer form, and the registry manager checked the number against the catalogue before anyone touched the fastening.

Mabel stood behind the marked line with Badu. Neither was permitted to handle the contents until the examiner had photographed the carton from every side and recorded the condition of the label. The procedure felt slow. It was also the first time that the mystery's central physical object had been brought into view without the anonymous sender controlling the moment.

Inside were several thin folders, two bundles of loose sheets, and a brown envelope marked with a faded reference. The envelope was not labelled 17-B, but a cross-reference in the catalogue connected it to

the same series. The examiner removed each item in order, photographed it, and assigned a temporary exhibit number.

The first folder contained routine maintenance requests. The second held attendance tables from a children’s home whose name had been abbreviated. The loose sheets included a list of room allocations, but several lines had been cut off when the paper was trimmed for binding. No single page announced a revelation. The significance lay in the way the entries overlapped.

One sheet listed four children under a heading that appeared to refer to beds in a dormitory. A separate page, filed behind a divider, recorded a confidential review involving five children. The papers had been stored together, but the examiner warned that this did not prove they had been created together or that the lists described the same event.

Mabel leaned forward. “There are four names here.”

“And a fifth line beneath the fold,” Badu said. “We should not assume it was a name until the page is flattened and photographed.”

The conservation specialist humidified the folded edge in a controlled process and opened it without tearing the brittle paper. A faint line emerged. It contained a partial entry, but not a complete name.

The visible letters could belong to more than one name, and a dark stain obscured the ending.

Mabel felt her heartbeat quicken. For years, the phrase ‘Ask the fifth child’ had sounded like a command left by someone who knew exactly where the truth was hidden. Now the fifth line was in front of them, and it was incomplete. The mystery had not become simple merely because the paper had surfaced.

The examiner placed a transparent scale beside the line and took high-resolution images under several types of light. The results might reveal erased writing or pressure marks, but he warned that no technique could guarantee recovery. He would report what the images showed, not what the investigators hoped to see.

The brown envelope contained a typed memorandum with a handwritten note at the bottom. The memorandum referred to a review meeting and instructed that the public summary contain no personal details about the children. The handwritten note stated that one entry had been transferred to a restricted register. There was no signature, only a small mark that resembled the letter K followed by a stroke.

“It could be the same hand as the movement entry,” Mabel said.

“It could,” the examiner replied. “But we have not compared originals, and even a handwriting match would not prove who held the pen. A person can write for someone else. We need context.”

Badu asked the archivist to explain the catalogue history. The carton had been moved twice during office reorganisations. At one stage it had been described as general welfare records; later, someone had added a cross-reference to restricted correspondence. The archivist could identify the dates of the recorded moves, but not the person who had first placed the envelope among the papers.

The restricted register was not in the carton. A note said it had been stored separately because it contained identifying details about children. It had not yet been located. Its absence did not prove destruction, but finding it had become the team’s most important records task.

Mabel returned to the room-allocation sheet. The four names were clear enough to read, though the investigators would not publish them. The fifth line remained partly obscured. A margin note referred to ‘the child not entered on the general return.’ It did not say why the child was omitted, whether the omission was deliberate, or whether the child was the same person later known as Daniel Sarpong.

Daniel was brought into the process through his lawyer and asked whether he wished to review the

documents relevant to his own history. He agreed, but insisted that he not be treated as an object of curiosity. He had spent too much of his life being told what his records meant by people who had never asked him what he remembered.

When he saw the partial line, he went quiet. “I cannot read that name,” he said at last. “And I do not remember this paper. I remember being moved from one place to another. I remember adults telling me to answer to a name that changed depending on which office we were in. But I cannot tell you that this line is mine.”

Mabel respected the answer. It was tempting to make his life fit the document because the story seemed to be closing around him. But Daniel’s uncertainty was honest, and honesty was more valuable than a convenient recognition.

The examiner’s preliminary imaging showed possible pressure marks beneath the fifth line. They might be traces of writing on a sheet that had once rested above it, or marks from the binding process. The enhanced image did not produce a reliable name. The team agreed not to circulate the image beyond the authorised inquiry until the full report was ready.

That afternoon, the archivist located an index card stored in a different cabinet. It cross-referenced the restricted register to a numbered cabinet at the central depot. The card also carried a note: ‘Access

only with authorisation from the review secretary.’ The secretary’s post had been abolished decades earlier, and the name on the card was incomplete.

Badu asked the depot to preserve the cabinet and all access records. He also asked for the administrative order that had established the restricted register. The paper trail was finally pointing toward the office that had controlled access, not merely the staff who had moved boxes.

Mabel stepped outside while the archivist prepared the formal request. The phrase ‘the fifth child’ had been a mystery for so long that she had almost turned it into a person before the evidence could. Now she understood that it might describe the fifth entry, the fifth child at a meeting, the child excluded from a public return, or a person who had been given a different identity. Those possibilities overlapped, but they were not identical.

Her phone remained silent. For once, the unknown sender had offered no instruction. Perhaps the sender had not known the carton would be found. Perhaps they were waiting to see what the investigators did with it. Mabel stopped herself from choosing between those explanations.

Before the day ended, the examiner sealed the carton’s remaining contents and signed the custody log. The partial fifth line, the memorandum, and the index card were each recorded as separate exhibits.

The records could now be tested against other sources. They could not yet answer the central question.

Badu joined Mabel in the corridor. “We have found the missing series, not the whole truth.”

“And the fifth child?” she asked.

The archivist compared the schedule with the institution’s annual return, which counted registered children at the end of each month. The figures did not match the number of beds shown on the room plan, but the forms used different reporting periods. A child could be registered at the home without sleeping in that room, and a bed could be listed even when it was temporarily unused. The comparison therefore supported neither a simple count of five children in the room nor a claim that the fifth name was invented. Mabel added the annual return to the evidence schedule and wrote a question beside it: what population did each form intend to count? The answer might be less dramatic than the title of the mystery, but it was essential to solving it fairly.

Mabel resisted calling the schedule a list of five children. Until the dates and headings were reconciled, that phrase could hide more than it revealed. She kept the original wording and added a separate note describing the possible interpretations.

For now, ‘the fifth child’ remained a question, not a conclusion they could announce.

“We have found a fifth line and a reference to a child excluded from a general return. We have not proved that those references describe one person. That is what we must establish next.”

The answer did not give Mabel the release she wanted, but it gave her something sturdier than a revelation: a method. They would find the restricted register, compare its entries with the surviving school and medical records, and ask Daniel to review any identification that genuinely concerned him. No one would force a name into the gap simply because the gap had become unbearable.

As she left the depot, Mabel thought of the five children in the photograph. They had been made into a puzzle by adults who kept records but failed to preserve the truth behind them. The investigation’s task was not to make the children fit a mystery. It was to restore the difference between what had happened to them and what the paperwork later claimed.

The register was brought to the archive reading room under a written chain-of-custody record. Two staff members carried it in a rigid conservation box. They logged the time, the condition of the binding, and the name of every person who handled it. No one was permitted to remove a page or place a loose sheet between its leaves. The procedure looked slow to

Mabel, but after everything they had learned about missing attachments, slowness felt like protection.

The relevant entry appeared in a section reserved for amendments. It did not name a fifth child in a way that could settle the mystery by itself. Instead, it referred to a correction made to a household count and directed the reader to a separate schedule. The schedule was not attached. A narrow strip of paper remained where a tab had once been, leaving a clean rectangle in the dust along the inside cover.

“Can we say the schedule was removed?” Mabel asked.

The conservator shook her head. “We can say the register refers to a schedule that is not presently attached. The binding shows a difference in the paper and dust pattern. It cannot tell us when the schedule was last present, who removed it, or whether it was stored elsewhere by design.”

Badu asked for the archive’s accession notes and the earliest surviving description of the register. If the schedule had been stored separately from the beginning, the gap would mean something different than if an old inventory listed it as an attached leaf. The distinction could not be settled by looking at the empty space alone.

The first inventory described the volume as containing “main register and related schedules,” but did not name each schedule. A later catalogue called it

a “register with amendments.” Neither description established whether the schedule had ever been bound into this copy, so the gap alone could not prove removal.

While the conservator photographed the relevant pages, Daniel waited in a separate room with his adviser. He had asked to see the entry himself, but Badu explained that access had to be arranged in a way that did not compromise the archive’s handling rules or turn the inspection into an informal identification procedure. Daniel was not a document expert, and his reaction could not authenticate the record. He would be given a proper opportunity to review the evidence through the agreed process.

When they eventually met, Daniel did not ask whether the register proved who he was. He asked whether it showed that someone had once been counted differently. Badu told him that the record pointed to a disputed count and a missing schedule, but the schedule’s contents were not yet known.

“Then it tells us there was a question,” Daniel said, “not the answer.”

“That is the fairest way to put it.”

Daniel looked at the photograph of the amendment entry. “All my life, people have spoken as though a form can settle a person. One form says one name, another says another, and everyone acts as if the

paper has the right to decide which life belongs to me.”

Mabel understood why the discovery hurt him even without giving him a final answer. The records had become a kind of authority over his life precisely because they were treated as complete. The work now was not to replace one unquestioned paper with another. It was to reconstruct the sequence of decisions, mistakes, and possible interventions that had produced the conflicting identities.

Before leaving the archive, Badu requested a certified image of the amendment page and a written statement describing the condition of the binding. He also asked the archive to search its separate schedule series under the date range and reference codes found in the inventory. The search would be logged, including unsuccessful results, so that the absence of a document could be described accurately rather than turned into a rumour.

The team requested the annual returns from three nearby institutions, not because they believed the missing child must have been moved to one of them, but because the transfer schedule referred to a receiving code that had not yet been decoded. The request went through the proper channels and included the date range, the code, and the reason for the search. Badu avoided sending the whole case theory. He wanted each office to search its own

records without being led toward a name or answer. If a return contained a matching entry, the team would then ask for the underlying source and the policy used to create it.

One institution replied that its older registers had been damaged by water and that some pages were unreadable. Another found a similar code, but it belonged to a transport voucher rather than a child’s file. The third had no surviving material for the relevant year. None of those responses proved that a transfer had occurred or that it had not occurred. Mabel wrote each result into the search log, including the negative replies. A failed search could later help establish the limits of the archive, provided the team could show exactly where and how it had searched.

Daniel read the list of institutions in silence. He recognised one name from a childhood memory but could not explain whether the memory came from a visit, a conversation, or something he had learned as an adult. Kwame asked him not to force the recollection into a statement. Instead, Daniel described the memory in his own words and separated what he remembered seeing from what he had later been told. The officer recorded the distinction and arranged a follow-up interview only after Daniel had reviewed the statement. The process was slower than a direct question asking whether he had lived at the institution, but it reduced the risk that a suggestion would become a memory.

That evening, Mabel reviewed the evidence board and removed a red thread that had connected the receiving code to a named official. The connection was only a possibility, not an established link. She replaced it with a note listing the unanswered steps. It was a small change, but she felt the investigation becoming more reliable as the board became less certain-looking. The fifth child was not a label to attach to whichever person happened to fit the story. It was a question that had to be answered through records, testimony, and a chain of reasoning open to challenge.

The anonymous sender did not contact Mabel that evening. She refused to treat the silence as evidence that the sender had been exposed or frightened; it was only silence. She noted it, then closed her notebook. The next steps were clear: locate the schedule, establish its history, and only then ask what the missing names meant.

The archivist found a second catalogue card tucked behind a folder of routine correspondence. It referred to a confidential review by a code that resembled the one on the carton, but the final character was smudged. The card's date was clear enough to place it within the same month as the disputed transfer. It did not list the children's names. Instead, it referred to an attached schedule that was not present in the folder.

Badu asked for the card to be examined in place and photographed before it was removed from the

drawer. The archivist recorded the surrounding cards so the context would not be lost. The examiner compared the smudged character with the registry's numbering conventions and said it could be either a B or an 8. That ambiguity matched the earlier catalogue problem, but similarity alone did not establish that both cards referred to the same packet.

The team searched the index under both possibilities. One route led to a transfer list for ordinary correspondence; the other led to a restricted review series. The first list contained no children's schedule. The second had a gap between two numbered items. A missing number might indicate a removed item, an unused number, or an entry moved to another series. The archive could not explain the gap without the underlying accession register.

Daniel was shown the catalogue card through his lawyer. He recognised neither the code nor the handwriting. He asked whether the missing schedule might finally prove which name he had been given as a child. Badu said it might contain useful information, but they did not know whether it had ever been stored with the packet. They would not promise him an answer before they had located the source document.

That answer frustrated Daniel. He had spent years living with documents that seemed to contradict one another, and each new lead appeared to offer relief before revealing another uncertainty. He asked

whether the investigation would ever be able to tell him what had happened. Badu said they would keep testing the evidence and would tell him plainly where it stopped. “You deserve a true answer,” he said, “not an answer we invent because the waiting has become unbearable.”

Mabel interviewed a former administrative assistant who had helped type confidential schedules. The assistant remembered preparing lists for meetings but not the names on this particular one. She explained that the typed schedule was sometimes sent separately from the covering letter because the letter could be circulated more widely. If that procedure had been followed, the schedule might have travelled in a different envelope and been filed elsewhere.

The assistant’s account gave the archivist a new search route: outgoing correspondence books and the separate dispatch ledger. The team requested both, with the relevant period clearly defined. The dispatch ledger showed an envelope sent to an office that later changed its name. It did not describe the contents, and no receipt had survived. The entry was a lead, not proof that the missing schedule had reached its destination.

At the end of the search, the team had a plausible route through which the schedule might have moved, but no schedule and no confirmed recipient. Mabel wrote the findings in two columns, “established” and

“possible.” She placed the dispatch entry under possible and the existence of a separate schedule procedure under established only to the extent supported by the assistant’s account and surviving instructions. The fifth child remained a question, not a name to be announced.

Additional archive-search scene

The next afternoon, the archive sent a note confirming that the older catalogue had been stored separately during the office reorganisation. The note included a reference to a temporary index, but the index itself had not yet been found. Badu assigned the search to an officer who had not worked on the earlier requests, and asked that the search terms be recorded exactly. If the index was missing, they needed to know whether it had been listed in a handover inventory or merely remembered by staff. A recollection that a document once existed was a useful lead, but it could not replace the document itself.

Mabel asked the archivist how records were transferred when an office changed its name. He explained that ordinary files were usually moved in numbered batches, while restricted material could be transferred under a separate schedule. The schedule might identify the boxes but not list every page inside them. If a box arrived with its seal intact, the receiving office could confirm the box had arrived without knowing whether every expected attachment was

present. That procedure offered one possible explanation for the gap, but it did not establish that it had happened in this case.

The explanation changed the question they asked of the archive. Rather than asking only, “Where is the missing schedule?” Badu requested the transfer inventory, any exception report, and the sign-off sheet for restricted materials. Each record could answer a different part of the problem: what was expected to move, what was recorded as received, and whether anyone reported a discrepancy. The request was wider than the earlier one, but it was still bounded by a specific date range and a known administrative change.

Daniel listened as Badu explained the new search. “So we still don’t know if it was ever there,” Daniel said.

“That is correct,” Badu answered. “We have evidence that a separate schedule was a normal possibility, and we have a dispatch entry that may relate to it. We do not yet have the record that connects those facts.”

Daniel looked disappointed, but he nodded. He had begun to understand that a careful answer could feel like another delay while still being more valuable than a confident guess. He asked that the search result—whatever it was—be shared with him and his lawyer. Badu confirmed that the request would be recorded

and that no document would be withheld merely because its contents complicated the current theory.

Mabel added a final line to the case timeline: “The transfer route is plausible; the contents and receipt remain unverified.” She read it twice, then left it unchanged. The fifth child was still not identified by the surviving evidence, and the people who had handled the records could not yet be arranged into a single chain of responsibility. But the questions were becoming more precise. They knew what document to seek, which office to ask, and what evidence would be needed before a missing schedule could become more than a possibility.

The search request was copied into the action log, and a second officer checked the wording against the exhibits. The team would not describe the missing schedule as stolen unless evidence established both its prior existence in the relevant packet and its unauthorised removal. For now, the record showed a gap and a route worth pursuing. That distinction protected the investigation from turning a reasonable suspicion into a public allegation.

Badu closed the folder only after the evidence clerk confirmed that the new requests had been assigned reference numbers. The next answer might clarify the trail or reveal another gap. Either outcome would be recorded without being forced into a conclusion.

The Search Room

The district office approved a supervised search of the last surviving storage room connected to the old review committee. The room had no formal name in the current catalogue. Staff called it the search room because that was where uncatalogued boxes were placed while waiting for assessment. Two archivists and an evidence officer attended, and every box was photographed before it was moved.

The first cartons contained routine appointment notices and blank forms. The second held duplicate correspondence already listed in the archive inventory. In the third, the team found a thin folder marked “supplementary schedule—see separate list.” The folder was empty except for a fastening strip and a small note recording that an attachment had been expected.

Mabel felt the old impulse to call it the missing schedule. She stopped herself. The folder showed that a supplementary schedule had been anticipated, not that the schedule they sought had ever been placed inside it. Badu asked the archivist to check the accession book for the folder’s date and previous location.

A transfer card showed that the folder had been moved from a cabinet in the administration block to the storage room during a reorganisation. The reason column was blank. The staff member whose initials

appeared on the card had died, and no supporting list was attached. The card established a movement of the folder, but it did not explain what had happened to the expected attachment.

The evidence officer photographed the fastening strip and sealed the folder in a protective sleeve. The archivist prepared a report describing the search method, the boxes examined, and the material found. She also listed the cartons not yet examined, so the team would not imply that the entire room had been searched when only a portion had been processed.

Daniel listened to the explanation with his lawyer present. He asked whether the folder meant his name had been deliberately removed. Badu told him that it did not establish that. It strengthened the reason to search for the schedule, but the link between the folder and Daniel's identity remained unproven.

Daniel looked at the empty sleeve. "Then we keep looking," he said.

"We keep looking," Badu replied, "and we keep the difference between what we found and what we hope it means."

The search continued into the next week. The team had located a new documentary trail, but not the missing name. The fifth child remained a question that could not be answered by counting beds, reading a folder label, or assuming that every absent page had been removed on purpose.

The restricted register was found in a locked cabinet at the central depot, exactly where the index card said it should be. The cabinet’s access log showed that it had been opened only a handful of times in the previous twenty years. The most recent entry was routine: an archivist had checked the cabinet during an inventory and recorded that the seal was intact. No unexplained visit appeared in the surviving log, though the earliest pages were missing.

The inquiry obtained written authorisation to inspect the register. A depot officer, the registry manager, Badu, the examiner, and Mabel were present. Daniel chose to attend with his lawyer. The register was placed on a support cradle, and each page was photographed before it was turned. The old binding made the pages difficult to open fully, so the examination proceeded slowly.

The first entries were ordinary administrative notes: names, dates, referral numbers, and brief

instructions about confidentiality. Several names had been carried into later registers under altered spellings. A margin note explained that the public return was to contain only the number of children in care, not identifying details. That instruction could explain why a name was absent from one list, but it did not explain why the related entry had been moved to a restricted register or why the later records disagreed.

Near the middle of the register, the team found a reference to the Haven House review. The entry listed five children for confidential consideration, but one name had been obscured by a strip of paper attached to the page. The strip was old and had been affixed before the register’s most recent binding. The examiner could not determine from appearance alone who had placed it there or when.

Badu asked that the strip be examined by a conservator before any attempt was made to lift it. The team would not risk destroying the very evidence they had waited years to find. While the conservator documented the paper, Mabel compared the dates with the surviving school and medical records.

The sequence was revealing. A child recorded under the name Emmanuel Sarpong appeared in an early entry. In a later record, the same referral number was associated with Emmanuel Badu. Still later, a school document used Daniel Sarpong. The

sequence matched what Daniel had previously learned about his identity, but the register alone did not explain why the names had changed or who had authorised the changes.

Daniel read the pages in silence. When he spoke, his voice was controlled. “This confirms that the names were used in the records. It does not tell me who decided which one I should answer to.”

“Correct,” Badu said. “The register proves the sequence of recorded names, subject to the examiner’s report. It does not, by itself, prove the motive or the person responsible.”

The conservator’s report, delivered two days later, found that the paper strip was not part of the original page. Its adhesive and paper were consistent with a later addition, but the available tests could not date it precisely. Under magnification, faint impressions were visible on the page beneath. They were incomplete and did not support a reliable reconstruction of the concealed name.

The register had been altered after its creation, but the available evidence did not identify who made the change. Missing access-log pages and an incomplete authorisation system prevented the team from reconstructing every hand that had handled it.

Mabel returned to her own statement. She had remembered an adult saying that a list had to be corrected before morning. The register showed that a

name had changed across several records and that a later strip concealed part of an entry. Those facts were consistent with her memory, but they did not prove that she had seen this particular register or that the speaker had ordered the alteration. She amended her statement to make the distinction explicit.

The anonymous sender finally contacted her again. The message contained no photograph, only a sentence: ‘You have the name. You still do not have the reason.’ Mabel saved it and reported it to Badu. It was the first message that appeared to acknowledge the discovery of the restricted register, but it still did not identify the sender or explain how they knew what the team had found.

Badu asked the digital investigator to compare the message’s metadata with earlier messages. The analysis might reveal whether they came through the same service or device, but it could not guarantee identification. The sender had avoided direct conversation for months. The investigation would not reward that strategy by treating the sender as an authority.

The team interviewed former staff members again, this time showing them only the verified portions of the register and asking precise questions about procedure. One former clerk remembered that confidential entries sometimes required a second signature from a review secretary. Another recalled

that emergency transfers could be recorded after the fact if the official responsible was unavailable. Neither remembered the specific case. Their accounts suggested possible administrative routes, not proof that any route had been used here.

The signature on the movement slip was compared with authenticated examples from the same period. The examiner found similarities in some letter forms but insufficient evidence for a confident identification. The initials K. Mensah remained a lead, not a conclusion; the record did not establish who wrote them or what role the entry described. Inspector K. B. Mensah would have to be asked about the entry, and any answer would need to be checked against independent records.

The inquiry also reviewed the evidence surrounding Judge Kweku Agyeman's murder. The records suggested that the judge had encountered the confidential review, but they did not establish that the altered register alone explained his death. The stopped clock remained unreliable as a time marker. The duplicate key could show how the study door might have been secured from the corridor, but it could not identify who had done so on the night of the murder. The old case and the children's records were connected by leads that still required proof, not by a single document that solved everything.

Mabel had once believed that finding the fifth child would resolve every contradiction. Now she saw that restoring an identity would not restore the history around it. Who the child was, who altered the records, who benefited, and whether any of those people were connected to the judge's murder remained separate questions.

At a final review meeting, Badu summarised what could safely be said. Five children had been listed for confidential consideration. One entry had been moved into a restricted register. Records associated with the same referral number used different names over time. A later paper strip concealed part of one entry. The public summary did not contain the same details as the restricted record. The original authority for these changes remained uncertain, and the available signature evidence did not identify the person responsible.

He then listed what could not yet be said: that every altered name referred to the same individual; that Inspector Mensah had made the alteration; that Emmanuel Badu had authorised it; that the anonymous sender had direct knowledge; or that the records alone established the motive for Judge Agyeman's murder. Each statement would require further evidence.

The lawyer advised that the findings be submitted to the appropriate authority for continued

investigation and, where evidence supported it, formal questioning. No one was to announce a culprit publicly. Daniel's identity records would be corrected only through the proper legal and administrative process, with his participation and access to the supporting documents.

After the meeting, Daniel stood with Mabel in the courtyard. "I used to think that if I could find the first name, I would know who I was."

"Do you?" she asked.

"I know more than I knew. I know what the records called me, and I know that the records do not agree. I still have questions about who made those choices." He looked toward the street. "But those questions belong to the people who made them. They do not get to decide everything about the person I became."

Mabel understood the burden hidden in the instruction to ask the fifth child: it made one person seem responsible for explaining an institution's silence. Daniel—and the other children whose records had been used—deserved lives larger than the evidence assembled about them.

Badu came out carrying the sealed copy of the preliminary findings. The investigation would continue. The old records still needed examination, Mensah's role remained unproved, and no established evidence yet connected the altered register to the

judge's murder. There would be interviews, document tests, and challenges from anyone accused. If the evidence supported charges, it would have to withstand a court's scrutiny.

Mabel received one last message that evening. 'You have found the first truth,' it read. 'The second truth is who was protected.' There was no signature and no new evidence. She showed it to Badu rather than replying.

He read it, then placed it in the case log. "That is a question, not an answer."

"Who was protected?" Mabel repeated.

"We will investigate who benefited from the secrecy, who had authority to change the records, and who acted to preserve the changes. But we will not let an anonymous person choose our suspects for us."

The anonymous message offered no answer, but it raised a legitimate question about who benefited from secrecy. Confidentiality may once have protected a child; later alterations may have turned that protection into concealment. The records still did not show when, why, or by whom that change occurred.

Mabel closed her notebook. The mystery remained unresolved: the register did not identify who altered it, and the name on a page could not explain a whole life. Still, the evidence was now documented well enough to be checked and challenged.

The files now had exhibit numbers, custody records, and explicit lists of unanswered questions. Any further claim would have to be supported by evidence that could withstand scrutiny.

The restricted register's transfer trail was reconstructed on a whiteboard, with each movement supported by a reference to the source document. Some transfers had two signatures; others had only a stamp and a date. The earliest section was incomplete, and the team marked that gap in red. They could show that the register had moved between departments, but they could not identify every person who had handled it. The missing entries were not treated as proof that a particular official had taken the book. They were gaps in the chain that still needed explanation.

The conservator's report clarified a small catalogue discrepancy: one card read 17-B, while a later index appeared to say 17-8. The characters were similar in the old typeface, and the error could have begun as a simple transcription mistake. Yet the difference had sent requests to two separate files, delaying the inquiry and making it harder to know which bundle a clerk meant. The report recommended preserving both forms in the catalogue with a cross-reference rather than silently changing one to match the other.

Daniel gave a statement through his lawyer. He confirmed that the records had raised questions about his childhood identity but did not claim to know who

had altered them. He said he wanted the official record corrected only if the evidence justified the correction, and he did not want another child's name exposed to make his own story complete. Mabel heard the statement and understood that the search for truth had to include the right to remain uncertain about parts of the past.

Badu prepared a summary for the deputy commissioner that separated established facts from unresolved questions. It identified the irregular register entries, the conflicting dates, the missing leaf, and the evidence that a fifth child may have been included in a review. It did not name a murderer or accuse a person of altering the record without sufficient support. The summary ended with a request for further examination of the original transfer books and for a formal review of the handling of Mabel's childhood statement.

And somewhere beyond the inquiry, the person who had sent the messages knew that the investigators had stopped following the clues blindly. Whether that person had helped preserve the truth or had helped bury it remained unknown. The case would continue, not because the records had delivered a final answer, but because they had finally made the right questions impossible to ignore.

EPILOGUE — THE UNSENT LETTER

Two days before the next case conference, Mabel received a letter with no return address. The envelope had been posted locally and carried no identifying mark beyond the date stamp. Inside was a single sheet typed on a modern machine. The writer claimed to have seen a copy of the supplementary schedule years earlier and said it had been kept in a private office after the public file was closed.

Mabel did not call the writer a whistle-blower in her notes. The letter gave no name, no searchable location, and no detail that only a genuine witness could know. She photographed it, placed the original in a sleeve, and informed Badu and her editor. They agreed that the claim should be checked, but not published as fact.

The letter asked them to look for a “blue dispatch book.” The archive already held a blue book, but its contents related to routine mail and had not been linked to the missing schedule. Mabel wrote down the possibility and the risk of confirmation bias: once a source named an object, the team might see that object as proof even if it was unrelated.

Badu assigned an officer who had not handled the earlier dispatch records to inspect the book. The officer found several entries for the relevant department but no clear reference to the schedule. A page had been repaired with archival tape, and a note

on the repair record said that the original paper had split along a fold. There was no indication that text had been removed.

The team requested the repair photographs to check whether any writing had been obscured before the tape was applied. The conservator agreed to review them and cautioned that even a visible entry would need to be connected to the correct packet. The anonymous letter had created a new line of inquiry, not a conclusion.

At the case conference, Badu read the letter’s claim aloud, followed by the limitations recorded beside it. No one speculated about the sender’s identity. Mabel proposed a public note saying the inquiry had received new information but had not verified it. Her editor accepted the wording: accurate, even if less dramatic than readers might hope.

When Mabel left the office, she understood the phrase “the second truth” differently. The next truth might not be a confession or a hidden document. It might be the discovery that a promising lead was wrong—or the careful proof that it was right. Either result would matter, provided they could show how they knew.

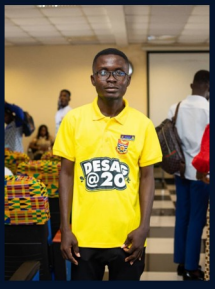
A MYSTERY THAT CONNECTS THE PAST, THE PRESENT, AND A CHILD'S UNANSWERED IDENTITY

When a mysterious photograph surfaces, it sets in motion a chain of events that reaches into the past—and threatens to uncover the truth about a lost child, a powerful man, and a cover-up that has lasted for years.

As new evidence emerges and old secrets resurface, Detective Kwame Badu and his team are drawn deeper into a case more complex than they imagined.

The Last Witness: The Fifth Child is a gripping story of justice, betrayal, and the search for truth—where nothing is as it seems, and the past still has a voice.

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